

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Govt notifies 1,000 acres of Southern Ridge as reserved forest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved the notification of around 1,000 acres (400 hectares) of additional land in the Southern Ridge as reserved forest, taking the total notified Ridge area in the capital to nearly 13,000 acres (5,250 hectares).

The decision, approved under Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act, 1927, is aimed at strengthening statutory protection of the Ridge and promoting conservation, ecological restoration and green cover, the Chief Minister's Office said.

"The Delhi Ridge is not only a part of the capital's natural heritage but also its green protective

shield. Protecting the Ridge is not limited to preserving trees and forest areas; it is directly linked to Delhi's clean air, biodiversity, temperature regulation and environmental security. The Government is working to provide permanent statutory protection to as many eligible areas of the Ridge as possible, while also giving special attention to the scientific restoration of degraded ecological areas," the chief minister said.

According to her, the process of final notification of various areas of the Ridge had been pending for a long time. Her Government has made it a priority and has accelerated the process.

The government's aim is to ensure the protection, scientific restoration and revival of the

Delhi Ridge so that this natural area remains protected for future generations as well.

The Southern Ridge is considered an important ecological link at the northern end of the Aravallis. According to the government, it functions as a green space and carbon sink while contributing to dust control, biodiversity conservation and local temperature regulation.

The Southern Ridge is an important ecological link at the northern end of the Aravallis and is also regarded as the capital's 'green lung' and a carbon sink.

The chief minister said legal protection would be accompanied by ecological restoration under the Ridge Working Plan. The focus will include restoring degraded areas,



promoting native species and managing invasive vegetation. She said the process of Ridge conservation will not end here.

The statutory process for notifying other eligible areas of the Ridge as Reserved Forest is also underway, and more and more Ridge areas will be brought under permanent protection in a phased manner.

The Delhi Ridge Management Board was also constituted in 2026 for the conservation, restoration and management of the Delhi Ridge. Its responsibilities include protecting the Ridge, scientific ecological restoration, afforestation and habitat conservation.

The chief minister said Delhi must not only move forward at

the pace of development but also protect its natural heritage alongside that development. The Ridge is a centuries-old natural heritage of Delhi, and protecting it for future generations is our responsibility.

Protecting nearly 13,000 acres of the Ridge is not merely about safeguarding a large tract of land; it is a commitment to protecting Delhi's air, biodiversity and environmental balance.

The Government wants development and environmental protection in Delhi to move forward together. Today's step is an investment in clean air, healthy lives and a secure future for generations to come. With the participation of Delhi's citizens, we will further expand this green campaign.

Over 31 lakh voters get notices over roll link discrepancies

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Chief Electoral Office of Delhi has issued notices to over 31.63 lakh voters who could not be linked to the electoral roll of the last revision and to those having logical discrepancies in their linking with the electoral roll of the last revision.

According to the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Ashok Kumar, the poll body has published online a list of around 31 lakh names with discrepancies and is sending notices to the persons named to present documents for verification. On August 31, the ECI published a draft electoral roll with 47 lakh of the city's 1.45 crore voters excised.

"As on date, 31,63,930 notices have been generated and are being delivered to electors concerned in Delhi. Notices are being issued to the electors who could not be linked with the electoral roll of last revision and to those having logical discrepancies in their linking with the electoral roll of last revision," a statement said. As per ECI instructions, the names of judges, public representatives, office holders, and well-known people from arts, culture, journalism, sports, and public service who were flagged earlier remain in the draft so their documents can be collected during the claims period.



The CEO Delhi released the draft electoral roll on 31 August 2026. People can file claims and objections until 30 September 2026. Notices are being sent and resolved from 31 August to 29 October 2026. The final list will be published on 4 November 2026. The draft roll includes 97,53,577 voters: 49,88,993 men, 47,64,137 women, and 447 people of the third gender. Booth Level Officers visited homes to check details and made a list of Absentee, Shifted, Dead, and Duplicate (ASDD) voters.

This list, which is shared with Booth Level Agents from recognised political parties, includes 43,32,775 people who have moved, are absent, or cannot be found; 2,82,412 deceased voters; and 1,41,535 people registered in more than one place. The draft list includes 47,56,722 ASDD voters in total. The draft list

divides voters into two groups: those who could link themselves or their family members to entries from the last revision in their states, and those who could not.

The draft rolls are available on the CEO Delhi website, at the offices of Electoral Registration Officers and Assistant Electoral Registration Officers, and at some polling stations. The Commission is sending notices to voters who could not be linked to the previous revision or whose information does not match. These voters need to respond and provide supporting documents to the Electoral Registration Officer.

The Commission will process these notices by 29 October 2026. Citizens who do not see their names in the draft but believe they are eligible voters can fill out Form 6 with supporting documents. Overseas voters

should use Form 6A. Use Form 7 to object to someone being added or removed, and Form 8 to change your address, correct details, replace your EPIC, or mark a disability. You can submit these forms in person to the ERO, AERO, or Booth Level Officer at designated locations, or online through the voters.eci.gov.in portal and the ECINET mobile app.

Special outreach efforts have already begun. After the demolition of Bela Estate in Assembly Constituency 20 (Chandni Chowk) made many former residents untraceable and placed them in the uncollectable ASDD category, the Commission set up a special enrolment camp that received 309 forms. More special camps will be held at all polling stations on 20 and 27 September 2026 from 10 am to 5 pm.

Extra evening camps on 23 and 24 September 2026, from 5 p.m. to 9 p.m., will be held at DUSIB night shelters and similar places for homeless voters, third-gender people, and sex workers.

The SIR process combines large-scale verification, a set period for claims and objections, targeted notices, and special steps to include vulnerable groups. Its success will be measured by how accurate and complete the final roll is when it is published on 4 November 2026.

Sood launches Seva-First innovation challenge with ₹2 crore prize pool

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood on Saturday launched the Seva-First Innovation Challenge 2026 and said it aims to build a strong innovation and start-up ecosystem in Delhi, where young innovators can learn from successful entrepreneurs, start-up founders and industry leaders.

The 100-day initiative was launched at the Delhi Technical University (DTU), offering a ₹2 crore prize pool, mentorship and Government support to encourage young innovators to develop technology-driven solutions to real-world problems.

With Delhi Technical University as the anchor university, the initiative will cover Haryana, Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Chandigarh and Ladakh. Students from universities, industries, start-ups, schools, ITIs and polytechnics across these states and Union territories will participate, according to a statement.

Addressing participants at DTU, Sood said the idea behind the challenge was simple — to serve society by finding solutions to real-world problems. The 100-day chal-



lenge will encourage students to work on agriculture, waste management, education and rural challenges.

Participants will identify national and local issues, generate innovative ideas, develop prototypes, get them validated and work towards implementing practical solutions, Sood said.

He said the initiative was not merely aimed at creating a few start-ups but at building a strong innovation ecosystem in Delhi, where young innovators can learn from successful entrepreneurs, start-up founders and industry leaders.

The Delhi Government will provide necessary handholding and support, while promising ideas will be mentored and, wherever required, funding support will also be facilitated through the start-up ecosystem and policies, Sood said.

Under the Delhi Start-up Policy, the goal is to create 10,000 start-ups and four lakh jobs in the national capital, he said, adding that the Seva-First Innovation Challenge was an important step towards creating an ecosystem where young people can turn their ideas into viable solutions and enterprises.

The challenge carries a prize pool of ₹2 crore and will provide young innovators a platform to bring forward their ideas, address real-world problems and develop solutions with social impact, the statement read.

Sood said a Viksit Bharat by 2047 cannot remain merely a Government initiative and must become a people's movement. He said the programme draws inspiration from Prime Minister Narendra Modi's governance model

and his people-first approach.

Highlighting India's start-up journey, Sood claimed the country had fewer than 500 start-ups before 2014 and has now become the "world's third-largest start-up hub". "The transformation also reflected a psychological shift among young people, who were no longer only looking for jobs but were eager to create them through initiatives such as Start-up India and Digital India," he said.

The minister placed special emphasis on agricultural upliftment and rural engineering, praising DTU's initiative to send engineering students to villages from the 2027-28 academic year to identify local challenges and develop practical technologies. "If a farmer around you is struggling, don't just notice it; solve it," Sood said, adding that addressing clean-energy and agricultural challenges was "Seva-First" and represented true service.

The event also witnessed the announcement of the Rural Technology and Community Engagement Programme (RTCEP) on Engineering, Entrepreneurship and Social Transformation for Rural India, it added.



BABA FARID UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES, FARIDKOT

Admission Notice - Postgraduate Degree(M.Sc.) & Postgraduate Diploma (P.G. Diploma) Courses 2026-27

Admission application forms are invited on prescribed performa available at www.bfuhis.ac.in for admission to Postgraduate Degree (M.Sc.) & Postgraduate Diploma (P.G. Diploma) courses in University Institute of Allied & Healthcare Sciences, Faridkot and various constituent/affiliated colleges. Online application form alongwith requisite fee+18% GST must online submit up to **24-09-2026** by 5p.m. The Counselling will be held on **28-09-2026**. Reporting time at respective college will be till **30-09-2026 05:00 pm**. For eligibility and other conditions visit on University website www.bfuhis.ac.in.

3108/12/2026-27/15385 Dated CHD :- 19/09/2026

Principal



BABA FARID UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES, FARIDKOT

Admission Notice - M.Sc. Nuclear Medicine Courses 2026-27

Admission application forms are invited on prescribed performa available at www.bfuhis.ac.in for admission to M.Sc. Nuclear Medicine at University Institute of Allied & Healthcare Sciences, Faridkot. Online application form alongwith requisite fee+18% GST must online submit up to **23-09-2026** by 5p.m. The entrance exam will be held on **25-09-2026** after that Counselling will be held on **28-09-2026**. Reporting time at respective college will be till **30-09-2026 05:00 pm**. For eligibility and other conditions visit on University website www.bfuhis.ac.in.

3108/12/2026-27/15384 Dated CHD :- 19/09/2026

Principal



BHAGWAN PARSHURAM INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY
A UNIT OF BHARTIYA BRAHMIN CHARITABLE TRUST (REGD.)
(Approved by AICTE, Affiliated to GGSIPU University, Delhi)
ISO 9001: 2015 Certified, NBA Accredited for CSE, ECE & EEE
PSP-4, Sector-17 (Opp. Sector-11) Rohini, New Delhi-110089
Tel :- 27571080, 27572900, email-bpitindia@yahoo.com

NOTICE FOR ADMISSIONS AGAINST VACANT SEATS

Applications are invited from the eligible candidates, registered with GGSIPU and also from those who were unable to register earlier with GGSIPU University but fulfill the eligibility criterion as laid down in University's Admission Brochure 2026-27, for provisional admission in B.Tech, B.Tech (L.E), BBA & MBA against vacant seats in the Academic Session 2026-27. Candidates can submit their application online at the portal of the Institute and also offline in Room No. 4 (G.F.) of the Institute w.e.f. **19.09.2026 to 23.09.2026**. Merit list of registered and unregistered candidates will be prepared separately and in the first round of counselling only registered candidates will be called for counselling. If the seats still remain vacant, vacancies will be filled up from unregistered candidates. Prescribed application form can be downloaded from the Institute's website www.bpitindia.ac.in. For details of vacant seats under the above categories, Schedule of Admission Process & Counselling, Notification for subsequent round or any other further updates, visit Institute's website www.bpitindia.ac.in



Asia-Pacific Institute of Management
Jasola, New Delhi
(Approved by AICTE. Affiliated to GGSIPU, Delhi)

ADMISSION NOTICE
For Vacant Seat for the BBA Program Code-125 Academic Session 2026-27

Applications are invited from eligible and CET/CUET qualified candidates, desirous of admission in BBA Course against seats earmarked for Vacant Seat for the BBA Program Code-125 in Asia-Pacific Institute of Management (AIM), New Delhi

Application form may be filled online on admissions@asiapacific.edu w.e.f. **19th September, 2026** onwards and the same will also be available OFFLINE at the Institute Reception from **19.09.2026 i.e. Saturday to 23.09.2026 i.e. Wednesday between 10:00 am and 3:00 pm**.

Last date for submission duly filled application form in the Institute along with the Registration Fees of **Rs. 2,500/- (Non-refundable)** is **23rd September, 2026 (3:00 pm)**. *Statutory Reservation as per Govt. Policy Applicable.

Director
Asia-Pacific Institute of Management
3 & 4 Institutional Area, Jasola
New Delhi 110 025, India, Ph: **91-11-42094800**
Website: www.asiapacific.edu

 We Shape Futures Since 1996



kotak
Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. SURESH KUMAR** having address at **GAGAN VILLA WZ-26 GALI NO 14 A,S SADH NAGAR PALAM COLONY ,DELHI-110045,India** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **Plot No-55, Sec-12 Dwarka-110075** remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. SURESH KUMAR** calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. SURESH KUMAR** 4 within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **December 19, 2026** at around 12p.m.



kotak
Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. RAVINDER CHOPRA** having address at **FLAT NO 162 , SECTOR 19 P K T 3 , PHASE-I DWARKA, NEW DELHI, 110045,INDIA** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075** remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. RAVINDER CHOPRA** calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. RAVINDER CHOPRA** within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **December 19, 2026** at around 12p.m.



kotak
Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. PAWAN AGARWAL** having address at **FLAT NO 534 CHANDAN WARI APTS., SECTOR-10 DWARKA, NEW DELHI, 110075, India** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075** remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 8 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. PAWAN AGARWAL** calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. PAWAN AGARWAL** within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **December 19, 2026** at around 12p.m.



kotak
Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. MAHESH SINGH** having address at **C8 8334 VASANT KUNJ , NEWDELHI, 110070,INDIA** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075** remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 8 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. MAHESH SINGH** calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. MAHESH SINGH** within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **December 19, 2026** at around 12p.m.



Indian Bank
इलाहाबाद ALLAHABAD

SALE NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION ON 28.10.2026

APPENDIX- IV-A" [See proviso to rule 8 (6)] Sale notice for Sale of immovable properties

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immoveable Assets/Movable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable properties/Movable Assets, mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Indian Bank, Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever there is" on **28.10.2026** for recovery of dues.

The specific details of the properties intended to be brought to sale through e-auction mode are enumerated below:

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES/ASSETS TO BE AUCTIONED ON 28.10.2026 (30 DAYS NOTICE FOR FRESH SALE)

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Branch Name	Contact Person & Mobile Number	Name of the Mortgagor(s) /Gurantor	Details of Immoveable Property/ies/ Movable Assets	Physical / Constructive Possession	Amount of Secured Debt as on	Reserve Price	Earnest Money Deposit
								Min Incremental Amount
(i)	(ii)	(iii)	(iv)	(v)	(vi)	(vii)	(viii)	(ix)
1	M/s Ritu Advertiser Prop- Mr Ganesh Khanna Branch: Hauz Qazi	Mr. Maharana Pratap 9525863076	(Guarantor) Mrs. Lata Khanna w/o Mr. Ganesh Khanna, 2392, chhipiwar kалан Bazar Guliyān, Delhi-110006 (Guarantor & Mortgagor) Mrs. Lata Khanna w/o Mr. Ganesh Khanna, 2392, chhipiwar kалан Bazar Guliyān, Delhi-110006	2392, Chhipiwar kалан Bazar Guliyān, Delhi-110006 admeasuring 51.83 Sq. meter in the name of Mrs. Lata Khanna w/o Mr. Ganesh Khanna Bounded by: East: Part property& other's property West: other's property North: Gali South: Other's Property Property ID:	Symbolic Possession	Rs.5,49,692.84 Lakhs + Interest & other expenses till realization of Bank's dues (as on 05.03.2025)	Rs.16 Lakhs	Rs.1.60 Lakhs Rs.0.10 Lakhs

Date and Time of e-Auction On **28.10.2026** between 11.00 a.m. to 5.00 p.m. with unlimited extensions of 10 minutes each. Minimum Bid incremental amount is as mentioned above.

Bidders are advised to visit the website (<https://www.baanknet.com>) of our e auction service provider PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd to participate in online bid. For Technical Assistance Please call 8291220220. For Registration status and for EMD status please email to support.baanknet@psballiance.com

For property details and photograph of the property and auction terms and conditions please visit: <https://www.baanknet.com> and for clarifications related to this portal, please contact PSB Alliance Pvt Ltd, Contact No 8291220220.

Bidders are advised to use Property ID Number mentioned above while searching for the property in the website with <https://www.ebkay.in>

Date : 17.09.2026 | Place: New Delhi

Authorised Officer



भारतीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान खड़गपुर
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY KHARAGPUR

IIT Kharagpur invites **Online Applications** from Indian Nationals for the following posts:
Advertisement No.: R/13/2026 dated August 20, 2026

Post:

- (i) Professor
- (ii) Associate Professor
- (iii) Assistant Professor
- (iv) Senior Resident

For details and any further updates, kindly visit:
<http://erp.iitkgp.ac.in/Jobs/auth/facapps.htm>
CBC 21255/11/0011/2627 कुलसचिव/ Registrar



PUBLIC NOTICE
LOST DOCUMENT

It is hereby informed to the general public that the original DDA Possession Letter of Property No. LIG FLATE NO. 70G, THIRD FLOOR, POCKET A-I, MAYUR VIHAR PHASE 3, DELHI-110096, The document was lost on 15th September 2026, in the area of C-BLOCK ROAD NEW ASHOK NAGAR, DELHI-110096 while carrying it for photocopying. A police complaint has been lodged at NEW ASHOK NAGAR under NCR No. 635651/2026. If anyone finds the said document, please return it to the undersigned or contact at the address/mobile number given below.

Shri Bhagwan Ram
Address: C-514, First Floor, New Ashok Nagar Delhi-110096
Contact No:- 7042448283, 9650270194

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Mrs. S. Ranganyaki is owner of Flat No.1-231, Area Measuring 60 Sq. Yds. Situated in Mariana Vihar, Delhi; Hereinafter referred to as "the said property", vide a Relinquishment deed dt.14.08.2014, registration No. 9764, in which registration details of conveyance deed was wrongly marked as 1824, instead of 16057. All Persons are hereby informed that above owner want to sale the said property to Mr. Uday Kumar Yadav or his nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client for purchase the said property. If anybody has any objection/s upon the ownership of above owner's sale/mortgage, and any other kind of objection / litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 10 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, 1st Flr, 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N. Delhi-110028
Ph: 9111411292-28



Pradeep Memorial Comprehensive College of Education
(NAAC Accredited, Affiliated to GGSIPU Dwarka, Recognised by NCTE Govt. of India)
Pratap Vihar Kirti Enclave, Nangloi, New Delhi-110086

GOLDEN OPPORTUNITY TO TAKE DIRECT ADMISSION IN

B.Ed.
AI PMCC

GGSIPU has issued guidelines for filling vacant seats As per eligibility criteria of GGSIP University, candidates must apply from 19th September to 23rd September 2026 at PMCC.

This Opportunity is Only for Those candidates who are CET/CUET/SET (B.Ed.) qualified but not registered with GGSIPU portal and also those registered with GGSIPU admission portal but not yet admitted.

For admission details & counselling guidance, contact us:-
7290037803, 7290037804
Email: pmc_coll@yahoo.com
Website: www.pmccc.in



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF WOMEN AND CHILD DEVELOPMENT

NOTICE

Applications are invited to fill up the existing vacant post of Chairperson in the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR), New Delhi.

2. The eligibility criteria, age, salary and other allowances, etc. and other details may be seen on the website of Ministry of Women & Child Development at <https://wcd.gov.in>. Persons, who are interested in applying for the post of Chairperson and fulfill the eligibility criteria for appointment to the post, may apply online on ncpcrvacancies.wcd.gov.in within **28 days** from the date of publication of the Advertisement in the Newspapers.

3. The persons who are serving under the Central/State Government or any other organization funded by the Central/State Government **should route their application through proper channel.**

Sd/-
CBC 46101/11/0014/2627 Under Secretary to the Government of India

Shah, Rajnath hail ABVP’s DUSU win as endorsement of nation first



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, BJP national president Nitin Nabin, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who was herself DUSU president in 1996-97 and several others congratulated the newly elected office-bearers after the ABVP won three of the four central panel posts in the Delhi University Students' Union election, calling it a "tight slap" on the face of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and an outright rejection of his "politics of falsehood."

Union Home Minister Amit Shah said the victory reflected the youth's unwavering faith in the ABVP's 'Nation First' ideology and its dedication to student welfare. "I am fully confident that, drawing fresh energy from this win and guided by the ideals of Swami Vivekananda, Parishad activists will continue to advance the cause of student welfare and nation-building," Shah said on X, congratulating ABVP activists on the "spectacular victory" of



their candidates. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh described the student outfit's victory as a "symbol of the youth's unwavering faith in the Nation First policy". "I am confident that the ABVP will continue to work with the same dedication for student interests, national service and nation-building resolve," Singh said on X. Several BJP leaders, including Union minister Kiren Rijju, hailed the ABVP's victory, describing it as a mandate against the Congress and other Opposition parties.

The chief minister congratulated Yash Dabas, Riya Chhabra and Lakshya Raj Singh on their victories for the posts of president, secretary and joint secretary respectively, saying their wins represented the youth's faith in the values of "Knowledge, Character, and Unity" and "Nation First" and the victory was a moment of "special joy" for her.

"My connection with Delhi University and DUSU is deeply personal. It was in this very campus that my journey — from student life to the responsibilities of DUSU President



was shaped. Therefore, today's historic victory is a moment of special joy for me," she said.

The chief minister said the support from the youth was a stamp of their unwavering faith in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership and the resolve for a developed India. She extended her best wishes to all the victorious candidates for a bright tenure ahead.

Congratulating the DUSU polls victory, BJP president Nitin Nabin said the ABVP's victory was rooted in the spirit of 'Nation First' and the youth's resolve to contribute to the vision of a 'Viksit Bharat'. "Congratulations to all my young friends at Delhi University on ABVP's historic victory in the DUSU elections!" the BJP chief said "My best wishes to the victorious candidates and everyone who worked tirelessly to make this victory possible," he added.

Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra congratulated all the victorious candidates, workers and supporters on the ABVP's victory in the DUSU election and said the



result was not merely an electoral victory but an expression of the youth's faith in nationalist ideology, youth power and the resolve for a developed India under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood, who was also DUSU president in 1988-89 from the ABVP, said the success was a result of the confidence of Delhi University's youth and their democratic participation.

He wished the newly elected representatives well and said they should strongly raise the voice of students and work meaningfully for education, student welfare and the development of the university. "Young power is the biggest strength of a developed India," Sood said.

Delhi Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra also congratulated the ABVP on its victory in the DUSU election, saying the country's youth was patriotic and committed to the goal of a developed India. He said the "echo of lies" would lose every time to the "call of truth".

International athletes win top DUSU posts, independent bags vice president

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An international-level tennis player, a basketball player and an international-level handball player are among the new faces who will represent the ABVP in the DUSU's three central panel seats, while the vice president post has gone to an Independent candidate — the son of a bus conductor — who pulled off a major upset after being denied a ticket by NSUI.

The Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) poll results were declared on Saturday after a closely fought contest between the RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), Congress-backed National Students' Union of India (NSUI) and the AISA-SFI alliance. Independent candidates were also in the contention.

ABVP's Yash Dabas, who hails from Delhi's Kanjhawala, was elected the DUSU president with 24,576 votes. He is an international-level tennis player who completed his graduation from Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Khalsa College and is currently studying in the Department of Buddhist Studies. Dabas participated in International Tennis Federation competitions in Spain, Australia and Serbia.

He was also selected for the CBSE Nationals, SGFI Nationals, Khelo India and the All India University Games in 2023. Dabas said the mandate reflected students' trust in social harmony, patriotism and student power, and their message to rise above caste

and divisive politics.

Delhi University's Gen Z has given a clear message that it believes in social harmony and nationalism, he said. ABVP's Riya Chhawdi, who won the secretary post with 21,650 votes, is from Modband village in Badarpur, Delhi, and comes from a family of farmers. An inter-college-level basketball player, Chhawdi is in the final year of her four-year BA programme at Sri Aurobindo College. Chhawdi said that the panel's focus would be on student safety, better facilities, equal opportunities and creating a positive academic environment.

Lakshya Raj Singh, who was elected joint secretary with 16,615 votes on the ABVP ticket, is from Churu district in Rajasthan. He completed his graduation in Political Science from Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Khalsa College. Singh is an international-level handball player and has represented India at the Asian Games and World Championship. He has also represented Rajasthan at the National Games and the University of Delhi at the National University Games. He is currently pursuing law at Campus Law Centre, Faculty of Law, University of Delhi. Singh said the victory reflected the unity of ABVP's workers and the trust of DU students, and the mandate brought with it a greater responsibility to remain accessible to students.

ABVP Delhi secretary Sarthak Sharma said the DUSU result demonstrated that



ABVP Yash Dabas, Riya Chhawdi and Lakshya Raj Singh celebrate with others as they climb atop Swami Vivekanand's statue after winning three of the four central panel posts in DUSU elections at the Faculty of Arts in New Delhi on Saturday

Congress's political machinery cannot deliver success in student politics. He said that despite the involvement of Congress, NSUI, the Aam Aadmi Party and other organisations, students gave a clear mandate to ABVP. Deepanshu Shokeen, who contested independently after NSUI denied to back him for the polls, was elected vice-president with 30,615 votes.

He is the son of a Delhi Transport Corporation bus conductor and an Anganwadi teacher, and a native of Peeragarhi village in West Delhi. A student of the Department of Buddhist Studies, Shokeen completed his graduation from Bhagat Singh College. He has said his

experiences as a student over the past four years shaped his decision to enter student politics.

Shokeen claimed he had been walking barefoot throughout his campaign following the Satya Niketan building collapse, in which seven people, including five DU students, were killed.

He has vowed not to wear shoes until justice was delivered to the students affected by the tragedy.

Shokeen defeated his closest rival, Ishu Maurya of the ABVP, by a margin of 13,705 votes to secure the vice-president's post. In an X post on the result day, Shokeen thanked students of Delhi University.

ABVP celebrates 3-seat DUSU win, rivals allege rigging and seek recount

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Cheers and slogans filled the area outside Delhi University's Arts Faculty on Saturday as ABVP supporters gathered to celebrate the outfit's victory in three of the four central panel posts in the DUSU elections. Supporters waved party flags and threw pamphlets into the air as groups gathered outside the faculty following the declaration of results, with celebrations continuing through the afternoon at the North Campus venue.

The ABVP prevailed over youth sentiments, registering an emphatic victory in DUSU polls on Saturday, deflecting the headwinds three months after the Gen Z protest at Jantar Mantar and more recently, the Satya Niketan tragedy that claimed the lives of five Delhi University students.

At the party's state office, Delhi BJP Yuva Morcha workers gathered to mark ABVP's win even as the court's no-procession order kept

them off the roads leading back to campus. BJP spokesperson Yaser Jilani struck the day's celebratory note early. "First of all, I congratulate and extend my best wishes to the three students from the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad who have won. This victory shows that the students have endorsed our Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a developed India by 2047," he said, folding a student council result into the party's national talking points within hours of the count closing.

Not every student organisation was in a mood to concede the mood, let alone the numbers. Members of the Samajwadi Chhatra Sabha, which had contested and lost every seat, staged a protest over the results, with joint secretary Vishesh Yadav demanding a full recount. "I demand a recounting. Fake voting was carried out in every college by members of the organisation, allegedly with professors forcing students to vote, and in some col-



Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad's (ABVP) Riya Chhawdi celebrates with others after winning the secretary's post in the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections at North Campus in New Delhi on Saturday

leges, organisation members themselves pressed the buttons," Yadav alleged, a charge that added a fresh, unresolved edge to a result that had already been tight enough to keep counters busy well into the afternoon. The student election at Delhi University has traditionally been a direct contest between the ABVP, covertly supported by the BJP, and the National Students'

Union of India (NSUI), the Congress's student wing.

NSUI's presidential candidate Vijay Shankar Meena refused to accept the loss in ordinary terms at all. "Look, we haven't lost the election; we have won. Every student of Delhi University who supported me so much, thank you very much. We filed a complaint yesterday as well regarding bogus

voting in colleges like Swami Shradhanand College, Ramjas College, and Shivaji College, where students were forced to vote and their ID cards were taken. We will take this to court and fight for it," Meena said, signalling the contest was headed off campus and into legal filings rather than ending with the count. He said he would NSUI's national president Vinod Jakhar, weighing in from outside Delhi, framed the loss as one fought against more than just ABVP. "Consider how the Prime Minister was acting like a star campaigner, visiting colleges during the university elections. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta was putting her full might into securing a victory. We lost by a narrow margin of votes but NSUI will fulfil the promises made to the students with great determination," he said, before turning reflective. "There were organizational issues; we will reflect on them, make improvements, and enter the fray once again."

NSUI faces fallout as rebels outshine official candidates in campus polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The NSUI's failure to win any of the four central posts in the DUSU elections has again put the spotlight on ticket distribution in the Congress's student wing, with one of its rebels winning by a landslide and another putting up a strong challenge.

Independent Deepanshu Shokeen, who had sought an NSUI ticket and was initially nominated by the organisation but was later asked to withdraw his nomination, won the vice-president's post with 30,615 votes, nearly twice the 16,910 secured by the ABVP's Ishu Maurya. NSUI's official candidate Veer Chhatrath — the son of senior Congress leader Manish Chhatrath — finished a distant third with 4,313 votes.

Similarly, Vishesh Yadav, another NSUI ticket aspirant who was initially told he had been given the joint secretary's ticket before it was withdrawn, eventually contested the post with the backing of the Samajwadi Chhatra Sabha and finished second with 15,778 votes, behind the ABVP's Lakshay Raj Singh who polled 16,615 votes. The NSUI's Gopal Chaudhary bagged 15,206 votes for this post.



At Panjab University in 2024, NSUI rebel Anurag Dalal contested for president as an Independent after a row over ticket distribution and won with 3,433 votes. NSUI's official candidate Rahul Nain managed just 501 votes and finished sixth.

The rebellion was preceded by the resignation of Chandigarh NSUI president Sikander Boora, who backed Dalal and accused the leadership of imposing decisions on the local unit. He was subsequently suspended by the organisation.

Panjab University saw another revolt a year later, when Kumar himself was blamed by a section of NSUI for the choice of candidate.

Buddhist studies emerges as unlikely kingmaker in DUSU polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In the annual churn of student politics in Delhi University, a department has emerged as an unlikely launchpad for leaders year after the year: Buddhist Studies, a postgraduate course devoted to Buddhist literature, philosophy and history.

This year, seven of the 10 candidates who contested the four central-panel posts in the Delhi University Student Union (DUSU) elections were from the Department of Buddhist Studies, including both presidential candidates — ABVP's Yash Dabas and NSUI's Vijai Shankar Meena.

Dabas won the president's post

with 24,576 votes on Saturday, defeating Meena, who secured 22,523 votes. Independent candidate Deepanshu Shokeen, who is also currently pursuing a Master's in Buddhist Studies, won the vice-president's post with 30,615 votes. The last time an independent candidate won a DUSU central-panel post was in 2009, when Manoj Chaudhury of the same department had assumed the role of union's president.

The department's footprint extended to the other three posts this year. NSUI's Namrata contested for the secretary's post, while Gopal Chaudhary of the NSUI and Samajwadi Chhatra Sabha's Vishesh Yadav — all from the Department of Buddhist Studies —



were among the three students running for the joint-secretary race.

However, this year's victory is not an isolated instance of the Buddhist Studies students making it to the DUSU central panel. A look at the results over the past few elections shows the department

repeatedly featuring among the winners. In 2025, NSUI's Rahul Jhansla, from the same department, won the vice-president's post, while Karan and Deepika Jha won the secretary and joint secretary posts, respectively.

Before that, in 2024, NSUI's Lokesh Choudhary, another MA Buddhist Studies student, won the joint-secretary's post. In 2023, ABVP's Tushar Dedha won the president's post in the first DUSU election after the three-year COVID interruption.

The question, then, is not merely why Buddhist Studies students contest elections, but why a department that is neither among DU's largest nor an obvious political training ground repeatedly

produces candidates for its most visible student offices. Professor Kamakhiya Narain Tiwary, head of the department, said the answer lies less in politics than in the nature of the course itself.

"Buddhist Studies is open to students from every stream. We have a comparatively larger number of seats, so students who may not find their way into other specialised departments can be accommodated here," he said.

The department has around 200 seats, with admission through CUET and selection based on the entrance-test score. The course does not require students to have studied Buddhist literature at the undergraduate level.

Barapullah Phase II flyover to open on September 29 after 11-year delay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The much-awaited Barapullah Phase III flyover will open to the public on September 29. According to PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma, Union Home Minister Amit Shah will inaugurate the flyover.

For more than a decade, Barapullah Phase-III became synonymous with delays, multiple missed deadlines and unanswered questions.

The minister has visited the Barapullah phase III corridor to take stock of the preparation for the inauguration. The Barapullah Phase III will provide a signal-free connection between Mayur Vihar Phase I in East Delhi and

Sarai Kale Khan, with connectivity further towards AIIMS and South Delhi.

It will connect with the existing Barapullah corridor at Sarai Kale Khan, taking the combined corridor to approximately 9 km.

This project aims to provide seamless connectivity between East and South Delhi, linking Mayur Vihar Phase I and AIIMS via signal-free carriageways.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Saturday visited the project site to review the final preparations and take stock of the completed infrastructure.

The foundation stone for Barapullah Phase 3 was laid in 2014, while construction began in 2015. The project

was originally scheduled for completion by 2017, but several hurdles delayed the work. As a result, the project remained pending for nearly 11 years.

However, it faced multiple delays and significant cost overruns, with the revised project cost now at approximately ₹1,635 crore.

The dispute over roughly 8.5 acres of land took nearly seven years, from 2016 to 2023, to resolve, primarily because of back and forth over compensation.

The land had been classified as 'riverine' for which the government-notified rate is ₹17 lakh per acre. The landowners demanded 17 times more — ₹3 crore per acre. A year into the dispute,



Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh inspects the Barapulla Phase-3 project during a site visit in New Delhi on Saturday

Ambedkar University was asked to conduct a social impact assessment to gauge the project's impact on local communities. All this while the work on a crucial 700 metres of alignment and a key pillar couldn't begin.

Fi-nally, in 2024 the compensation of ₹17.6 lakh per acre was accepted as the market value and paid.

Then came the surprises that should not have been surprises: Nearly a decade after the project was approved, project officials in 2023 identified nearly 300 trees along the alignment that needed to be transplanted, pruned or felled.

During the inspection, Singh said: "For more than a decade, Delhi has been

waiting for this project to become a reality. The project had remained delayed under the previous Government. After the formation of our Government, we followed up on the project, reviewed its progress at every stage and worked to complete the necessary permissions and clearances. With these efforts, the long-pending work has now been completed and the corridor is ready to be opened for the people of Delhi".

The inauguration comes during the month of celebrations marking the birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi with the Delhi Government undertaking a range of public-oriented initiatives during this period.

LG Sandhu joins cleanliness drive in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor of Delhi, Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, attended a cleanliness drive at Durlabh Nath Vatika in Shakurpur with MCD staff and young volunteers from the Vrikshit Foundation. Present were the local councillors Kishan Lal and Ajay Ravi Hans, the MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar, the Deputy Commissioner (North Zone), various MCD officials, and local citizens.

On Saturday, the Lieutenant Governor visited various Government departments and agencies, as directed by the LG Secretariat, to observe the *Swachhata Hi Seva Pakhwada* by launching campaigns to promote cleanliness, hygiene, and environmental awareness across the Capital.

The LG requested that senior officers supervise



Delhi LG Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu joins MCD staff and Vrikshit Foundation volunteers during a cleanliness drive in Shakurpur

PTI

cleanliness activities between 17th September and 2nd October. Furthermore, the LG Secretariat's communication mentioned that the LG would personally look at the campaign during the *Swachhata Pakhwada* and asked for photographs and bi-weekly reports on the activities carried out.

The LG praised the volun-

teers for their work, noting how encouraging it was to see children so aware of the importance of cleanliness and taking an active part in cleaning the park as part of Shramdaan, thus changing the area.

He said a cleaner Delhi starts with public involvement and called on the city's young people to take responsibility

for their neighbourhoods and turn Shramdaan into a people-supported movement. While speaking to residents, he stressed that keeping the park clean is now a joint responsibility of the community.

Sardar Sandhu stressed that although sanitation is the concern of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), citizens too should realise their responsibilities and emphasised the importance of giving up the habit of littering and making cleanliness part of everyday life, just as people clean their own homes.

He pointed out that today, since everyone has a phone with a camera, citizens can photograph civic problems and post them on social media, and said he personally reviews such complaints, with those prominently posted on social media resulting in immediate action.

LG asked people to avoid leaving food like rotis for

animals in the parks, pointing out that this habit attracts stray animals to these areas, and instructed MCD officials to take strict action on the stray-animal problem. To convey the importance of cleanliness, he swept the area himself.

He said every citizen has a role in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, describing it as a shared responsibility to keep Delhi clean, hygienic and developed. The company later planted a sapling as part of the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign, stating that just as a mother nurtures her children, so too does nature nurture us, and that it is every individual's responsibility to protect it.

He encouraged the citizens to plant as many trees as they could, saying that together they could create a cleaner, healthier and greener Delhi.

DUSU polls: NOTA beats AISA-SFI alliance on two key central posts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The AISA-SFI alliance's candidates finished with votes lesser than the NOTA tally in at least two of the four central-panel positions of the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections, the results of which were declared on Saturday.

The results came against the backdrop of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP)-led student mobilisation, which had emerged around alleged examination irregularities, paper leaks, unemployment and demands for greater institutional accountability.

AISA and SFI were among the Left student organisations that participated in the mobilisation at Jantar Mantar, with AISA activists also joining a prolonged hunger strike during the agitation. AISA-SFI's presidential candidate Ananya Raturi polled 5,377 votes, 1,067 more than the 4,310 votes recorded for NOTA. In the secretary's contest, Stanzin Deskyong secured 8,734 votes, against 7,884 for NOTA, a difference of merely 850 votes.

The pattern was reversed in the other two contests. For vice-president, AISA-SFI candidate Akshat Shikhar polled 2,383 votes, while NOTA received 4,359 votes; 1,976 more than the Left candidate. In the joint sec-



retary contest, B Parijaat secured 5,837 votes, compared with 7,389 votes for NOTA, leaving a gap of 1,552 votes.

The AISA-SFI alliance had subsequently made student welfare issues, including affordable accommodation, hostels, concessional Metro passes, fee hikes and academic freedom, central to its DUSU campaign.

The alliance had nominated Raturi for president, Shikhar for vice-president, Deskyong for secretary and Parijaat for joint secretary. Raturi's 5,377 votes put her behind ABVP's Yash Dabas, who won with 24,576 votes, and NSUI's Vijay Shankar Meena, who polled 22,523.

Deskyong finished behind ABVP's Riya Chhawdi, who won the secretary's post with 21,650 votes, and NSUI's Namrata Chaudhary, who secured 14,869.

Traditional Indian knowledge not religiosity, BSB preparing students to be what they want: NP Singh

PARITOSH KIMOTHI
■ New Delhi

Traditional Indian knowledge is often misunderstood as religiosity, though it factually entails the inventions and knowledge of Bharatiya civilisation in science, technology and various other fields.

Tackling this misconception, the Bhartiya Shiksha Board (BSB) is working to educate students to become anything from entrepreneurs and scientists to those appearing in competitive examinations, with at least 300 schools across India securing affiliation for classes up to XII during the past two years.

The BSB curriculum is aimed at enabling students to gain knowledge and find meaningful solutions to contemporary concerns, the BSB executive chairman NP Singh said in an exclusive interac-

tion with *The Pioneer*. Speaking about the board's activities during the past two years, Singh said, "I have held about 200 workshops across the nation with schools and other stakeholders, and have received an enthusiastic response. However, our nation is huge, so it will take time to make all Indians aware of the BSB and what it offers. A major challenge we face is the misconception that traditional Indian knowledge consists of religiosity.

The BSB is working to undo the fallacy that education is meant only to secure a job and focusing on enabling the student for knowledge creation and finding meaningful solutions to contemporary concerns. We were curators of knowledge at a global level till about 500 years ago. Since our mainstream education has become job-centric instead of inculcating innovation and entre-



preneurship, we must keep pace with the latest technology while retaining our roots.

We understand that education is a mutual enrichment and exploration which benefits both the teacher and the taught. We were innovators and knowledge creators who influenced the world after the 11th century.

The imperialists superimposed colonial ideas on our advanced systems, and for about 180 years now we have been following an education system constructed by European imperialists aimed at preparing servants for the colonialists. That is also why our bureaucracy still has a colonial mindset, with bureaucrats still not behaving like public servants," he said.

Singh clarified that the BSB is about merging the best of traditional knowledge with the latest developments to prepare stu-

dents to do what they want, from becoming scientists or entrepreneurs to appearing in competitive examinations. He said that since 70 per cent of traditional knowledge exists in Sanskrit, it makes sense to learn it. "It is the pragmatic ideas and approach of the BSB which has motivated 300 schools up to class XII and 1,000 schools till class VIII to affiliate with us so far. We aim to beautifully weave traditional wisdom into modern knowledge in a way which does not burden the students," Singh said.

Regarding the response received to BSB so far, he said that even in the Srinagar valley in Kashmir, his workshop was attended for hours by teachers who were not really aware of their own history. "They actually asked me to continue post-lunch too. Three schools in Srinagar

alone have applied to us for affiliation. We are training school teachers and are also aiming to address the guardians of the students. I can state with evidence that even the NCERT has oriented the content of its curriculum to some extent, whether it be influenced by us or not," the BSB executive chairman said.

About the board's future expectations, he said, "Factually, the creation of the BSB and its work so far has sown the seed of revival. It will take a few decades to practically bring Indian traditional knowledge back to its position while also merging it with modern education. However, the process has begun, and I am confident that we will attain the situation wherein the best of traditional knowledge and modern education are utilised to achieve what is best for the students and the nation," he added.

FROM PAGE - 1

India's per capital carbon emission half...

The number of electric vehicles sold has increased from 3,000 per year before 2014 to nearly 2.5 million last year. Metro networks have expanded from five cities and less than 250 kilometres to 20 cities and over 1,000 kilometres. The railways have been fully electrified. India's first hydrogen train, the world's longest, has begun operating."

"Efforts to conserve water have led to the creation of more than 70,000 Amrit Sarovars and 1.5 crore rainwater harvesting structures. Forest cover has increased by 22 per cent. The government has banned single-use plastic, and circular-economy initiatives recycle thousands of tonnes of waste each day, he said."

PM Modi based the current approach on earlier civilisation-wide concepts of coexisting with nature, saying India is now providing practical solutions to today's climate challenges while also calling for joint global action. The conference, organised by the NGT and attended by judges, scientists and policy-makers, aims to promote environmental justice and governance internationally.

During the first session, Modi also launched a mobile application for the NGT; the speech combined defence topics with elements of ambition.

Modi said India would not accept any blame that fails to account for per capita circumstances. At the same time, the country will continue to expand its solar, wind, hydro and nuclear power capabilities, will further open up the nuclear sector, and will regard clean energy as both a duty towards the environment and a national opportunity.

According to him, the country is showing that speed and sustainability do not have to be enemies, and that developing countries can set an example while also demanding a fairer distribution of responsibility for who emits the most.

India faces weakest monsoon in 17 years

However, the monsoon's retreat does not mean an immediate end to rainfall, as several parts of the country are expected to see rain over the coming days.

Of the 741 sub-divisional districts, 342 have recorded either deficit or large deficit rainfall so far. The current 15 per cent deficiency marks the most severe shortfall since 2009, which saw an 18 per cent deficiency, with 2015 being the last year to record a comparable weakness. The current season stands at 85 per cent of the long-period average, a sharp contrast to the above-normal 108 per cent recorded in recent years. India was entirely covered by the southwest monsoon on July 9 after its onset over Kerala took place on June 4.

The initial forecast was just a 10% shortfall back in May. If the deficit holds, this would be the weakest monsoon since 2009, when rainfall was 18% below normal.

In its monthly forecast on August 31, the IMD had noted that the last month witnessed a rainfall of 213.3 mm over India, which was the seventh lowest for August since 2001.

So far, July has been the only month this

monsoon season that received a surplus of rainfall. While the average rainfall in July is 280.5 mm, the country received 283.3 mm of rain during the month. In June, the overall rainfall deficit stood at 35 per cent. The average rainfall during the month is 165 mm, but it witnessed just 106.8 mm of rain. El Nino is one of the three phases of the El Nino Southern Oscillation (ENSO), a climate phenomenon characterised by changes in sea temperatures along the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean, accompanied by fluctuations in the atmosphere overhead. While El Nino is known to have a warming effect on the planet and less rainfall in India, its opposite phase, called La Nina, usually results in a cooling effect. ENSO also has a neutral phase.

The monsoon is critical to India's agricultural economy, with hundreds of millions of farmers relying on seasonal rainfall to irrigate their fields. India is among the world's largest producers of rice, sugar and cotton, while the June-September monsoon accounts for most of the country's annual rainfall. A prolonged rainfall deficit could affect both the current harvest and the following crop cycle, potentially adding to food-price pressures. Food inflation rose for a seventh consecutive month in August to 5.95%, its highest level this year, while rice, sugar cane and corn plantings are trailing last year's levels.

ABVP retains DUSU dominance

Left candidate Akshat Shikhar secured 2,383 votes and Aranya Singh Rathore received 2,274 votes.

"Our primary concern will be ensuring that a safety audit is conducted for every PG and hostel. We all witnessed the accident that occurred in Satya Niketan; we do not want such an incident to happen to anyone in the future," Dabas said, tying his mandate directly to the building collapse that had killed seven students earlier this month and reshaped much of this year's campaign conversation around housing safety. The Vidyarthi Parishad won 3-1 last time and has won 3-1 this time as well; next time, we will win 4-0," he added.

The Chief Minister congratulated Yash Dabas, Riya Chhabra and Lakshya Raj Singh on their victories for the posts of president, secretary and joint secretary respectively, saying their wins represented the youth's faith in the values of "Knowledge, Character, and Unity" and "Nation First".

ABVP also won the secretary's post, with Riya Chhawdi securing 21,650 votes. NSUI's Namrata Chaudhary finished second with 14,869 votes, followed by Left candidate Stanzin Deskyong with 8,734 votes. ASAP's Pankaj Kumar received 7,639 votes.

The joint-secretary contest saw a closer fight, with ABVP's Lakshay Raj Singh emerging victorious with 16,615 votes. SCS candidate Vishesh Yadav came second with 15,778 votes, while NSUI's Gopal Choudhary polled 15,206 votes. Left candidate B Parijaat received 5,837 votes.

ABVP's official account leaned into the score line with characteristic bluntness on social media. "ABVP 3-0 NSUI. Three seats. One organisation. Zero excuses. While ABVP delivered where it mattered, NSUI is left with ZERO. The verdict is out. The campus has spoken," the

party posted, tagging the result #ABVPWinsDUSU. Delhi University's electoral map itself remains a partial one. Of the university's 91 colleges spread across North and South Campus roughly 15 kilometres apart, only 52 directly participate in the DUSU vote, with several prominent institutions, including St Stephen's College, Lady Shri Ram College and Jesus and Mary College, sitting outside the process entirely, a structural quirk that shapes every DUSU result without ever appearing on the scoreboard itself.

The DUSU polls this year has been shaped not just by campus issues such as student housing and infrastructure, but also by aggressive social media outreach, caste-based mobilisation and extensive campaigning on the ground.

This year, elections are being held against the backdrop of students' protests at Jantar Mantar, which led to the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the Union Education Minister, and the Satya Niketan tragedy, which raised questions over the shortage of hostels and accommodation on the university campus. The result comes after NSUI sought to put ABVP on the defensive over issues including alleged paper leaks and the Satya Niketan building collapse. However, the Congress student wing could not convert those campaign issues into victories in any of the four central posts.

The election also exposed divisions around NSUI's ticket distribution. Shokeen, who had earlier been associated with NSUI, contested the Vice-President's election as an independent after not receiving the organisation's ticket and went on to win the post. Similarly, NSUI rebel candidate Vishesh Yadav contested the joint Secretary's election independently. His presence split the Opposition vote, with Lakshya Raj Singh eventually securing the seat.

FTAs, skilling incentives opening new...

"Among those such as yourselves, young people have an important role to play; when serving in the government, you should take every decision that helps to keep up the campaign for a developed and self-reliant India, and since you are young, you have a special responsibility, especially in relation to other young people," he said.

The prime minister said the idea of 'Nagrik devo bhava' (citizens are god) should guide public service and that 45 'Rozgar Melas' (job fairs) were held across the country.

According to a statement released by the Prime Minister's Office, the newly recruited candidates will be joining several ministries and departments of the central Government, such as the Department of Revenue, the Ministry of Railways, the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, the Department of Financial Services and the Ministry of Defence.

An official statement said the Rozgar Mela reflects the Government's ongoing emphasis on providing employment opportunities for young people and ensuring their greater involvement in the country's development journey.

It added that 12.75 lakh young people have

received appointment letters in various departments and Government organisations at the 20th Rozgar Mela.

Mamata camp's Rejinagar candidate back in race

However, about one and a half hour later, the picture changed completely after Chowdhury, in another hurriedly convened press meet, declared that following the announcement of his initial decision to withdraw candidature, the party's top leadership and Mamata Banerjee herself spoke to him, based on which he has reconsidered and reversed his earlier decision.

"I will be contesting the bypoll. We are in Didi's party and we cannot do anything outside her wishes. So, following Didi's instructions, I am retaining my candidature," Chowdhury said, stating that Banerjee directed him not to quit the poll fray.

Chowdhury also visited the local Beldanga police station and spoke to officers. Emerging from the police station, he claimed that the police administration had assured them of the safety and security of party workers.

"I have been assured of security by the police after the supremo (Banerjee) intervened. I have met officers of the Beldanga police station and they have also assured me and my cadre of security during campaigning," he said.

"Even if only 10 workers stand by me, I will take them along and begin a door-to-door campaign," Chowdhury added, expressing confidence that he would receive all necessary assistance for campaigning in accordance with Banerjee's instructions.

Interestingly, once the dominant political force in West Bengal, Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress is facing an unusual stretch of turbulence. Questions over the party's identity, leadership and organisational cohesion have all surfaced in the space of just 72 hours. For years, Mamata and the TMC have been almost synonymous in Bengal politics. But the past three days have brought one jolt after another, leaving the party dealing with a frozen identity, a new name and symbol, a candidate walking away in Nandigram and another nearly doing the same in Rejinagar.

The first shock came when the Election Commission froze the TMC's familiar party name and its traditional 'flowers-and-grass' symbol amid the battle between Mamata Banerjee and the rival faction led by Arup Roy. The move was more than a technical setback for a party whose name and symbol have been central to its electoral identity for years.

It also came after Mamata's stinging defeat at the hands of the BJP in the assembly polls, leaving the party vulnerable to rebellion and splits in both the state assembly and Parliament.

The rebel faction had sought to stake its claim over the TMC's identity after 15 straight years of the party's rule in Bengal.

The Election Commission has allotted the 'footballer' symbol to the Mamata faction of the Trinamool Congress and assigned it the name 'Mamata All India Trinamool Congress'

amid a bitter feud with the rebel grouping over the party's name and 'flowers-and-grass' symbol. The rival faction led by Arup Roy has been awarded the name 'Democratic Trinamool Congress' and the symbol of 'envelope'.

Sanchita Pradhan Dey, the TMC candidate in Nandigram, withdrew her nomination a day before the deadline after meeting Bengal chief minister Suvendu Adhikari, the BJP leader who had defeated Mamata in Nandigram. Dey, who had lost her job in connection with the teacher recruitment scam, met Adhikari along with her husband Satyajit before announcing her withdrawal. Her reasons were not immediately clear.

The development left Mamata scrambling for a candidate in a constituency that is considered a Suvendu Adhikari bastion. Mamata then backed Congress candidate Milan Pradhan and described Congress as a "sister party", a move that also brought the INDIA bloc back into the picture ahead of the October 6 bypolls.

End of an Era: 1965 war hero Cooke passes away

Paying tributes to the legendary air warrior, the IAF on Saturday said he died here on Friday. Settled in Australia post-retirement, he was in India to attend an event organised by his former unit, 14 Squadron.

He died at the Base Hospital. The war hero was born in 1939 in Agra.

In its tribute, the IAF said the dogfight remains a "masterclass in aggressive air combat". Recalling his heroics and supreme valour displayed during the war, the IAF said in a post, "All air warriors of the Indian Air Force extend their deepest condolences on the passing of Flight Lieutenant Alfred Tyrone Cooke, Vrc. A war hero whose courage is etched forever in the annals of military aviation, Flt Lt Cooke exemplified supreme valour during the 1965 Indo-Pak War." It also shared an old photo of him.

"His legendary dogfight over Kalaikunda remains a master class in aggressive air combat and unwavering resolve. For his conspicuous gallantry, tactical brilliance, and disregard for personal safety, he was awarded the Vir Chakra. His memory will continue to inspire generations of Air Warriors," it said. Vir Chakra is the third-highest wartime gallantry medal.

Kalaikunda Air Base is located in West Bengal, and fierce aerial combat had taken place over it between IAF pilots and Pakistani pilots flying PAF's Sabres during the 1965 war.

Cooke's fascination with aeroplanes began long before he joined the air force. He grew up in Agra during the Second World War, when military aircraft were a familiar sight in the skies around the city.

Hurricanes, Spitfires and Mustangs were among the aircraft he remembered seeing as a boy, and he later recalled wanting to become a fighter pilot from an early age. He went on to La Martiniere College in Lucknow, a school that would produce an unusually rich crop of IAF officers and fighter pilots. He was commissioned on 19 December 1961 with the 80th Pilots Course. Within four years, he was at war.

Rekha Gupta, Kejriwal, Sibal, Swamy issued notices over SIR

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta and her predecessor, Arvind Kejriwal and several other prominent voters, including former MP Subramanian Swamy, Kapil Sibal and Virendra Sachdeva, are among the 3.31 million electors who have been issued notices for discrepancies in the details of their enumeration forms submitted under the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise.

However, the entry for the chief minister has been “validated”, and her name will be included in the final electoral roll of Shalimar Bagh constituency, scheduled to be published on November 4, the CEO office said in a statement.

Rekha Gupta, a voter and representative of the Shalimar Bagh assembly constituency, was among those whose details were flagged during the claims and objections period based on details submitted in their enumeration forms. A notice was

issued to her, and a physical verification was conducted by the designated booth-level officer (BLO), the Shalimar Bagh electoral registration officer (ERO) said in a statement.

“Following verification of the facts and documents submitted by Gupta, her electoral entry has been validated and parked for inclusion in the final electoral roll of AC-14 (Shalimar Bagh), scheduled to be published on November 4,” it said.

The Chief Electoral Office of Delhi also clarified that the issuance of the notice was part of the SIR process and was not limited to the chief minister. “As per the Election Commission’s instructions issued on May 14, names of members of the judiciary, public representatives, holders of declared offices and personalities from fields including arts, culture, journalism, sports and public service, whose entries had earlier been flagged in the electoral database, were included in



the draft rolls so that necessary documents could be collected during the claims and objections period,” the Delhi CEO office said. The poll body said notices were being issued to electors whose entries had been flagged for “discrepancies and that the concerned ERO of the Assembly would dispose of the notices after examining their replies and requisite documents.

Former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal, a voter from the New

Delhi Assembly constituency, has received the notice for being “unmapped with last SIR”. His spouse Sunita Kejriwal, parents and son have also been issued notices for the same reason. Kejriwal lost the Assembly poll from New Delhi constituency in Delhi Assembly polls held in February last year.

According to Delhi Election Commission documents, Arvind Kejriwal and five members of his family are among 110 voters from

‘Part-51, KG Marg’ in the New Delhi assembly constituency who have been issued notices. The party questioned the move, saying, “Is everything happening in this country just to keep the Supreme Lord happy? @ECISVEEP, how is it possible that the names of three-time Delhi Chief Minister @ArvindKejriwal Ji and his family members are missing from the Delhi voter list?”

The Electoral Registration Office (ERO), New Delhi, has said notices were issued to former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and his family members as their submitted Enumeration Forms did not contain sufficient details to establish their linkage with the electoral rolls of the last revision in their respective States. The ERO said, “The submitted Enumeration Forms were not complete in terms of details which would have enabled linkage of themselves with the electoral roll of the last revision of the respective States, which were not

present in their submitted Enumeration Forms.”In a press statement, the ERO further said that notices were being issued in accordance with procedures established and communicated by the Election Commission to electors who could not be linked to the electoral roll of the last revision or whose linkage showed logical discrepancies.

Former Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva, Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal, former MP Subramanian Swamy and BJP leader Sudhanshu Mittal were also sent notices, they said.

Sibal, a New Delhi constituency voter, has also been issued a notice for the reason of being “unmapped with last SIR”, officials said. Former Delhi BJP president Sachdeva said he has been issued a notice due to some name-related mismatch, and will get it corrected through proper documents. He said his wife and brother are also listed among the people issued notices, and

added that necessary corrections will be made.

Former MP Subramanian Swamy also got a notice from the poll body. On his X, Swamy said: “It is surprising that Election Commission officials are under pressure to delete my name from the voter list. I intend to take it up, perhaps file a case in the Supreme Court”.

The list of all the 33 lakh voters being sent notices has been uploaded by the Delhi CEO office on its website. “The notices are being issued to the voters who could not be linked with the electoral roll of the last SIR, and those having discrepancies in their linking with the electoral roll of last revision,” the CEO office said.

The voters who have been sent notice are required to submit their replies and necessary documents to the electoral registration officers (EROs) of the Assembly constituencies concerned by October 29, it said.

System wants *andhbhakt* and unquestioning youth: Rahul

ASHOKE RAJ ■ Indore

Congress leader and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Saturday alleged that an entrenched “system” had captured the country and preferred unquestioning loyalty over young people who challenge authority.

Gandhi arrived in Indore after taking an Air India flight from Delhi at 12:10 pm. Travelling in business class, he was warmly received by Congress workers at the airport before leaving for the venue of the fifth edition of Chhatron Ki Goonj.

The student-focused programme, themed “System vs Students”, witnessed a large turnout, with a rush of people particularly around the entry points leading to some chaos. The atmosphere at the venue was charged, with Bollywood songs being played as the crowd waited for Gandhi’s arrival.

Ahead of Gandhi reaching the venue, Congress leaders from the central organisation as well as local leaders from Madhya Pradesh interacted with the media and spoke about the issues expected to be raised during the programme.



Gandhi, addressing the gathering, said students represented the country’s future and that India could not become a strong nation if the concerns of its young people were ignored.

He claimed that around 10 lakh teaching posts were lying vacant across the country and that nearly one lakh schools had been shut. He alleged that 55 per cent of these closures were in Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh.

Taking aim at what he described as the country’s existing power structure, Gandhi alleged that National Security Advisor Ajit Doval wielded extensive influence, including over social media and surveillance. He said young people had begun

questioning influential figures, including industrialists Gautam Adani and Mukesh Ambani and BCCI secretary Jay Shah, but faced resistance from what he referred to as “andhbhaks”.

The gathering also saw students raise a series of grievances concerning recruitment, examinations and education infrastructure in Madhya Pradesh.

One participant said 13 per cent of appointments arising from State Government recruitment examinations had been held up because of a legal dispute concerning the state’s 87:13 reservation formula and OBC quota. A woman candidate told Gandhi that many candidates who had cleared the examinations were still

waiting for appointments. A student from Dewas alleged that young people who had raised questions over alleged irregularities in Madhya Pradesh Public Service Commission examinations faced FIRs and imprisonment.

Gandhi said he would join an ongoing protest by candidates seeking teaching appointments in the State.

A tribal woman student also drew attention to the shortage of hostels for Adivasi students in Indore and urged Gandhi to raise the issue.

Gandhi’s black T-shirt also became a talking point among people at the venue. Some attendees linked his choice of black clothing to Saturday, which is traditionally associated by many devotees with Shani Dev. The discussion added a lighter element to an otherwise politically charged gathering.

The Chhatron Ki Goonj programme was marked by a mix of political speeches, student grievances and an energetic crowd, with the organisers seeking to present the event as a platform for young people to question those in positions of power.

Kumaraswamy accuses Karnataka Govt of failing to address drought-hit farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Bengaluru

Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy on Saturday accused the Karnataka Government of “failing” to provide relief to farmers affected by drought, saying crops had been damaged at the germination stage in several parts of the State.

The JD(S) leader said farmers had lost their hard-earned money due to crop damage and the Congress government should have announced compensation by now.

“Farmers’ hard-earned money has gone to waste. The Government should have provided compensation by now,” he said.

Speaking to reporters, he said the only relief so far was the State Chief Secretary holding a meeting and directing banks not to recover loans from farmers for the time being.

Kumaraswamy further alleged that the government was claiming a lack of funds to help distressed farmers while spending money on what he termed “unnecessary activities.”



Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy

“I had strictly instructed officials not to harass farmers for loan recovery when I participated in the district development coordination and monitoring committee meetings in Mandya and Mysuru,” he said.

The central minister also criticised Chief Minister DK Shivakumar for not declaring a farm loan waiver, saying the Government should account for the severe difficulties faced by people and livestock amid the drought. “Does the Chief Minister not know the situation in the State? There is no water for people and livestock, and cattle are not getting fodder,” he said.

Referring to loan waivers announced by him and

Siddaramaiah when they were CMs, Kumaraswamy said the CM is reportedly suggesting that he too announce a farm loan waiver. “If he wants to, the Chief Minister can waive the loans from his own money,” he quipped.

Regarding the Kasturirangan report on Western Ghats Eco-Sensitive Area (ESA), Kumaraswamy said all political parties in Karnataka hold a similar position and asserted that the report should not be implemented as it could adversely affect farmers.

The special session of the State legislature begins on Monday and the issue will be discussed during the session, he said.

Shah suffered food poisoning, now perfect: Pralhad Joshi



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Hubballi/Belagavi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who was visiting Karnataka to attend two events on Saturday, suffered from “food poisoning”, but was now “perfect”, senior BJP leader and central minister Pralhad Joshi said.

Shah, who was scheduled to inaugurate the new academic building of KLE Jagadguru Gangadhar Mahaswamigalu Moorusavirmath Medical College and the 1,200-bed KLE Hospital and Medical Research Centre at Gabbur in Hubballi, skipped the event earlier in the day. However, local leaders said he visited the campus in the evening before heading to the airport for Delhi.

Botswana Cheetah to be relocated to Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary in MP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Bhopal

Madhya Pradesh is set to take another step forward under Project Cheetah with the relocation of female cheetah CCB-2 from Kuno National Park to Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary.

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav will release the Botswana-born cheetah at Gandhi Sagar on September 20. The move is part of efforts to expand cheetah conservation beyond Kuno and develop additional suitable habitats in the state.

CCB-2 was born in Ghanzi, Botswana, and arrived in India on February 28 this year at around two-and-a-half years of age. She was initially brought to Kuno National Park, where she underwent the mandatory quarantine process.

After completing the quarantine period, the cheetah was released into the open



forest in May. During her stay at Kuno, CCB-2 adapted to the local environment and Indian climatic conditions.

Her relocation to Gandhi Sagar will mark the next phase of the conservation programme. Following her arrival, the sanctuary will have four cheetahs — two males and two females.

The addition of another female cheetah is expected to strengthen the prospects of developing a stable cheetah population at Gandhi Sagar and support future breeding efforts.

The relocation is also significant for the long-term strategy of establishing cheetah populations across multiple habitats in Madhya Pradesh instead of concentrating them at a single location.

Kuno National Park and Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary are being developed as key cheetah landscapes under the broader conservation framework. The long-term objective is to create a sustainable metapopulation across the Kuno-Gandhi Sagar landscape.

Parents claim caste discrimination in IIT Bombay student suicide

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

A 22-year-old student of Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay committed suicide in his hostel room after he was allegedly caught using his mobile phone during an examination, police said on Saturday.

Sahil Ravindra Wakode, a native of Maharashtra’s Yavatmal district, was found hanging from the ceiling fan in his room in Hostel Number 4 on the Powai campus on Friday evening, an official said.

Wakode’s mother alleged her son was tortured. “My son was killed, tortured. I want justice,” she told reporters.

A case was registered at Powai police station under section 108 (abetment of suicide) of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita along with relevant provisions of Scheduled



Police personnel stand guard as students protest following the death of a 22-year-old Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay student, who died by suicide in his hostel room on Saturday

PTI

Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act on the complaint of his parents, the official said.

The deceased student’s parents arrived in Mumbai from Yavatmal and claimed their son was subjected to institutional harassment and caste-based discrimination prior to his death, the official said.

No suicide note was found from the spot, the official said.

The police had initially registered an Accidental

Death Report in connection with the death. Wakode was a second-year BTech student in the Energy Science and Engineering department, he said.

According to a statement from IIT Bombay, the student had allegedly uploaded the examination question paper to ChatGPT to seek answers during the exam.

The official said Wakode’s death came to light after his hostel mates got no response from his room and alerted the authorities, who then informed the police.

Uttarakhand: SIT begins probe into fake certificates in MBBS admissions

DHRUV MISHRA

■ Dehradun

Dehradun police’s SIT has started an investigation into the case involving the alleged use of fake freedom fighter dependent certificates for MBBS admissions in Uttarakhand. Cases have also been registered at two separate police stations in the matter.

SP (Rural) Jaya Baluni said that documents related to the admissions where the alleged use of fake freedom fighter dependent certificates came to light have been sought from the officials and departments concerned.

Responding to a question about the possible involvement of an organised gang in this matter, she said the investigation is currently in its initial stage, so it



would be premature to draw any such conclusion.

Regarding the demand to investigate alleged fake domicile certificates, the SP (rural) stated that the two cases currently registered pertain to the alleged fraud involving freedom fighter dependent certificates and the admissions secured through them. The SIT is currently investigating this specific aspect, she said. (PTI)

NIA files chargesheet against 9 in online ISIS radicalisation case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) filed a chargesheet against nine people in an online radicalisation case at the Special Court for NIA cases in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh. The chargesheet names Mohammad Rehmatalullah Shariff, Mohammed Danish, Mirza Sohail Baig, Lucky Ahmad, Jishan Abdul Majid, Mir Ashif Ali, Abdul Salaam, Sharuk Khan, and Shaikh Faiz ur Rehman.

They are charged under several sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The case started as FIR No. 98/2026, registered on March 23, 2026 at

Vijayawada II Town Police Station in the NTR Commissionerate.

Local police received information that led to the arrest of one accused, who had been radicalised through social media. The NIA then took over the investigation and registered it as RC-01/2026/NIA/VSKP, known as the Online Radicalisation Case. The original FIR invoked additional provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Section 66F of the Information Technology Act, 2000, and several sections of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967. Investigation has established that the nine accused are members and supporters of the proscribed terrorist organisation ISIS. They entered into a larger conspiracy to support ISIS activities, using social media



platforms such as Instagram as their primary tool.

The objective, according to the findings, was to establish a

caliphate in India through violent jihad. These activities were intended to disrupt the country’s sovereignty and territorial integrity.

The accused encouraged and radicalised vulnerable young people, urging them to join violent terrorist activities. They also planned to make explosives and took part in weapons training. As part of their plan, they developed and tested a secure communication app for secret exchanges while preparing for terrorist operations. These actions show an organised effort that went beyond online propaganda and moved into real-world preparation for violence.

Eleven accused persons and one child. So far, the NIA has arrested eleven accused and one child in conflict with the law. The chargesheet includes nine of them, while the investigation

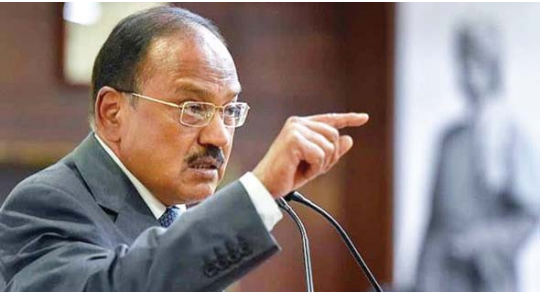
into the others is still ongoing. The NIA is still looking at digital evidence, communication records, and the network of contacts behind the alleged conspiracy. This case shows how online radicalisation lets terrorist groups use popular social media platforms to find, influence, and recruit vulnerable people. It allows rapid dissemination of extremist material and private coordination that can be difficult to detect in real time. The accused’s development of a custom secure messaging application further shows an attempt to evade conventional monitoring.

Filing the chargesheet is an important step in the investiga-

tion. It brings the collected evidence to the court and starts the judicial process for the nine accused. The agency has also said the investigation is still open, so more arrests or additional chargesheets could follow as it follows up on other leads.

This case highlights how important it is for local police and central agencies to work together to spot early signs of radicalisation. Registering the FIR quickly in March 2026 and handing the case to the NIA allowed a focused investigation into both the ideas and actions behind the alleged plot. The Special Court in Vijayawada will decide the legal outcome based on the evidence.

States Focus



INDIA'S GDP WILL RISE TO \$38 TRILLION IN 20 YEARS: DOVAL

National Security Advisor (NSA) Ajit Doval said on Saturday that India's GDP would increase from the current \$4.015 trillion to \$38 trillion in the next 20 years. Addressing the convocation ceremony of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Roorkee as the chief guest, Doval said that the students are fortunate to be living in a transformative era where their future holds great promise.

Citing the example of Lord Ram, the NSA urged students to be courageous in their lives. He said that sage Vishwamitra chose Lord Ram to annihilate demons because of his courageous nature. "Massive changes are taking place in India, and the country is moving towards a magnificent future," the NSA said. "As the prime minister has termed the period leading up to 2047 as 'Amrit Kaal,' it is truly a wonderful Amrit Kaal. India's current GDP stands at \$4.015 trillion, and it will reach \$38 trillion in the next 20 years," Doval added. He also shared an anecdote from his early career days while posted in Sikkim, recounting how he learned mantras for success from a Sherpa. (PTI)



BIHAR CM AIMS FOR 10,000 INDUSTRIAL UNITS IN 5 YEARS

The Bihar Government has set a target to facilitate the establishment of 10,000 industrial units over the next five years, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary said on Saturday. He said an industrial ecosystem has been created and land allotted to around 1,000 such units. Addressing a gathering under the National Innovation Challenge programme under the Seva Sankalp Abhiyan here, Choudhary said the State was promoting innovation, technology and entrepreneurship to accelerate its development. "The Government has set a target to facilitate the establishment of 10,000 industries in the State over the next five years," the CM said. (PTI)

Congress's Nandigram byelection candidate sent to judicial custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Haldia (West Bengal)

The Congress' Nandigram bypoll candidate Milan Pradhan was sent to judicial custody till October 3 by a local court on Saturday, a day after his arrest on multiple charges, including murder, that date back 19 years.

This effectively ends Pradhan's opportunity to canvass for himself as the campaign for the October 6 bypoll to the Assembly seat vacated by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari ends on October 4.

Adhikari resigned from the Nandigram seat in May, opting to retain Bhabanipur after defeating Mamata Banerjee in the Assembly poll held earlier this year.

Pradhan was produced before the Haldia Subdivisional Court on Saturday.

The West Bengal Police said Pradhan was arrested said Pradhan was arrested on four pending arrest warrants for his alleged involvement in non-bailable



Congress party workers participate in a protest rally against the arrest of party candidate Milan Pradhan in Kolkata on Saturday PTI

cases related to murder, attempt to murder, abduction with intent to murder, causing disappearance of evidence, house trespass, rioting with arms and deadly weapons, all of which were filed during the 2007 anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram.

He was also booked under relevant sections of the Arms Act, police said.

A counsel appearing for Pradhan said, "The court has remanded Milan Pradhan to judicial custody for 14 days in connection with the three

warrants associated with cases in Nandigram police station. He will be produced before the Contai court on Monday in connection with the fourth warrant issued in cases registered with the Khejuri police station. The prosecution maintained in court that Pradhan was absconding for the past 19 years and the police were unable to trace him. They have arrested him now because they have only now been able to find him."

The Congress candidate's arrest came within hours of

Four High Courts get 14 judges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 14 judges were appointed on Saturday to four High Courts, including Delhi. According to separate Law Ministry notifications, two judges and five additional judges have been appointed to the Delhi High Court, while one judge has been appointed to the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court.

Three judges have been appointed to the Jharkhand High Court and three additional judges to the Karnataka High Court. Judicial officers and advocates are appointed as judges of High Courts. Additional judges are usually appointed for a period of two years before being elevated as judges, or what is popularly called as permanent judges.



Seven judicial officers are appointed as judges of the Delhi High Court. Nivedita Anil Sharma and Nisha Sahay Saxena have been appointed permanent judges. Sanjay Sharma, Bharat Parashar, Aditi Choudhary, Dinesh Bhatt and Arun Bhardwaj have been appointed as additional judges. Arun Bhardwaj is the incumbent Registrar General of Delhi High Court.

Notably, the Supreme Court Collegium had on

September 10 recommended the names of eight judicial officers for appointment as Delhi High Court judges. Of these, only seven names have been cleared by the Central Government. Gurvinder Pal Singh is not among the names cleared for judgeship by the Centre today. The Delhi High Court, which has a sanctioned strength of 60 judges, is currently functioning with 44 judges, with a vacancy of 16.

Drought-like situation in several Maharashtra districts, says CM



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nagpur

A drought-like situation has developed in several Maharashtra districts, and the issue was discussed thoroughly in the Cabinet, after which ministers were instructed to carry out preliminary assessments in their respective areas and make preparedness arrangements, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis said on Saturday. A break in rains had caused damage to standing crops, he told reporters.

"In the cabinet meeting, ministers discussed this carefully. I have instructed them to carry out prelimi-

nary assessment in their districts and make preparedness arrangements. I think within the next week we will complete preliminary review. After that, we will conduct official crop surveys (panchnamas) and provide immediate assistance," the CM said.

Loan waiver work was also underway, with three lists being issued, he added.

"I have ordered that the remaining lists be completed quickly. Urgent assistance that farmers need will be provided by the Government. Drinking water and fodder arrangements will be made," the CM informed.

Zubeen's loss a permanent void: Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who donated blood on the first death anniversary of Zubeen Garg on Saturday, said that a year has passed without the singer and that it is a void one has to learn to live with but can never accept. Sarma, in a social media post, said that there are moments he expects Zubeen to walk in, and then the loss sinks in once more. "It feels surreal that a year has passed without Zubeen. There are moments I almost expect him to walk in, in that imitable style of his," the CM said.

"Then the loss sinks in once more. Perhaps this is what grief is: a void we learn to live with, but never truly accept," the CM said.

Sarma also attached a video of the singer in which he says, "I am a Zubeen fan. I love listening to his songs, as his songs are for the common man." He said that just as Jyoti Prasad Agarwala, Bishnu Prasad Rabha and Bhupen Hazarika are treasures of the state, Zubeen is also one such treasure.

"Zubeen's songs will keep inspiring people for a long time. Let his songs remain



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma pays tribute to singer Zubeen Garg on his first death anniversary in Guwahati on Saturday PIONEER PHOTO

a symbol reflecting people's joys and sorrows. He will forever remain in our memories," he added.

Mann opposes FIRs on farmers over stubble burning

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ludhiana

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann stated on Saturday that he does not 'favour' FIRs being filed against farmers for stubble burning, and emphasised that paddy growers should receive a cash incentive for not setting their crop residue on fire.

Mann made these remarks just days before the paddy harvesting season in Punjab begins.

Stubble burning in Punjab and Haryana is often blamed for increased air pollution in the Delhi-NCR region. Due to the short window for the Rabi crop (wheat) after the paddy harvest in October and November, many farmers burn their fields to quickly clear the crop residue.



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann

Paddy growers have been demanding a ₹3,000 cash incentive per acre for managing paddy stubble.

Addressing a gathering after inaugurating the two-day Kisan Mela of Punjab Agricultural University (PAU) here on Friday, Mann lament-

ed that Punjab farmers are always blamed for spreading air pollution in Delhi by burning paddy straw.

"The Centre says Punjab has contributed 180 lakh metric tonnes of paddy to the central pool. But they (Centre) do not consider how much of

that stubble comes from the 180 lakh MT. They (Centre) suggest registering FIRs," Mann said.

He mentioned that he has conveyed to the Centre that farmers do not wish to burn paddy stubble, as the smoke affects them directly.

Mann reiterated that he has informed the Centre that farmers should be given financial incentives for managing their paddy stubble.

Furthermore, he mentioned that Maryam Nawaz, Chief Minister of Pakistan's Punjab, had said that she would write to him regarding smoke affecting Lahore. "Is it only our smoke in the air? Do the emissions from Haryana and Uttar Pradesh not contribute? They are merely trying to defame Punjab," he asked, expressing displeasure with the blame directed toward Punjab for air pollution.

CM Rekha Gupta flags off Nasha Mukh Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Fatehgarh Sahib/New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday flagged off the second phase of the Bharatiya Janata Party's 'Nasha Mukh Punjab Yatra' from the historic and sacred land of Fatehgarh Sahib in Punjab. She also addressed a large public gathering on the occasion. Before the yatra began, the Chief Minister paid obeisance at Gurdwara Sri Jyoti Saroop Sahib and paid tribute to the martyrdom of the younger Sahibzadas and Mata Gujri Ji.

Speaking on the occasion, Rekha Gupta said that the sacred land of Fatehgarh Sahib is a land of courage, sacrifice and martyrdom. The younger Sahibzadas had refused to bow before oppression. Today, the youth of Punjab too will neither stop



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta meets families affected by drug addiction at the old grain market in Sirhind, Punjab PTI

nor bow before the menace of drugs and the drug mafia. From this sacred land, the strong voice of the people of Punjab must reach the system that has failed to take decisive action against drugs. Today, Punjab has risen and raised its voice against drugs.

Before the programme, the Chief Minister also interacted with families affected by drugs. She said the pain of these families was not the

pain of one household alone, but the suffering of society as a whole. There are tears in the eyes of mothers; fathers are struggling to bring their children out of the grip of drugs, and the social and economic lives of many families have been affected.

The fight against drugs is not the Government's alone; it is a fight for every family, every village and society as a whole. Protecting Punjab's

youth from drugs and connecting them with opportunities in education, employment, sports and development is a collective responsibility. She said the people of Punjab had been promised action against drugs for years, but the problem remained serious. In 2022, promises were made to eliminate drugs within three to four months.

The chief minister targeted the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) Government in Punjab, alleging that its failure to stop the drug network had broken the trust of Punjab's families. If drugs are openly reaching streets and neighbourhoods, accountability must be fixed. She alleged that the system under the Aam Aadmi Party, led by Arvind Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann, had failed to deliver results in line with the promises made to the people of Punjab.

TN POC SO case: Police probe reveals decades of minor abuse by granite baron

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

In the high-profile POC SO case involving well-known granite businessman R Veeramani (85), the Central Crime Branch has come to know that more minor victims were subjected to alleged sexual harassment before 2003 or even earlier, police said on Saturday.

In addition, as many minors were victims in the case, the Child Welfare Committee (CWC) was waiting to get a detailed report from the police to take its own course of action.

"We have not yet received the report from the police side. Once we receive it, we will definitely take action accordingly," a senior CWC member said.

The member added that the CWC, the final authority to dispose of cases for the care, protection, treatment,



development and rehabilitation of children, is closely monitoring the case and discussing it with the official concerned.

A senior police official, who declined to disclose the total number of victims, said that investigators suspect that the systemic sexual exploitation of young girls from impoverished backgrounds may span more than two decades. Providing vital information on the ongoing investigation, the senior officer

revealed that a retrieved text message sent by a co-accused to Veeramani directly referenced a 2003 incident involving the alleged suicide of a minor girl who was allegedly sexually assaulted by him.

"This evidence led the probe team to suspect that the abuse spans over two decades or more," he added.

According to the case history, the Central Crime Branch (CCB) registered the original FIR in 2025, after receiving a USB drive containing footage of a minor girl being "sexually assaulted" at a guest house at Teynampet in the city.

The primary survivor from the 2019 video clip was established to be a minor at the time of the offence. However, after police attempted to file a closure report citing an inability to identify the victim, the special POC SO Court rejected it and mandated a reinvestigation.

Maharashtra TET leak: Question papers smuggled out in shoe insoles for ₹8,000, says chargesheet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

Question papers for the Maharashtra Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) were smuggled out of an Agra printing press hidden inside shoe insoles by two employees for a mere ₹8,000, a nearly 3,500-page chargesheet filed by the Thane City police stated.

The chargesheet, submitted before a local court in Bhiwandi on Friday, names 18 accused, including alleged mastermind Bijendra Gupta, who was previously implicated in an Odisha paper leak, with 16 suspects already arrested and two key accomplices, Ashok Sav and Prakash Misal, remaining absconding as investigations continue.

A senior police official said that a supplementary chargesheet will be submitted as further investiga-



Representative image

tion progresses.

The racket unravelled a day before the examination scheduled on June 28 after Deputy Commissioner of Police (Zone II) Pavan Bansod received a tip-off about three men attempting to sell exam papers to a Bhiwandi resident.

Police laid a trap using decoy personnel in the Kongaon area, detained the suspects, and seized four sets of question papers. Subsequent verification with Maharashtra State Council of Examination

(MSCE) officials confirmed that the seized material matched the actual question paper.

The accused have been charged under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) related to cheating, criminal breach of trust, and criminal conspiracy, along with Maharashtra State laws on examination malpractices and unfair means.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) is probing the case.

According to the

chargesheet, the source of the leak was traced to Mahim Patran Pvt Ltd, an Agra-based printing press tasked with printing the confidential TET examination materials.

Between June 15 and June 17, two employees and a former staffer of the press allegedly concealed folded question papers in their shoe insoles to bypass security guards, who frisked their clothes but neglected the footwear.

To maintain exam integrity, the State had prepared four separate sets across two TET papers so that one could be randomly selected on exam day. But the perpetrators managed to sneak out all four sets past the security safeguard.

The press workers were paid a mere ₹8,000 each and promised land plots in Agra in exchange for stealing the exam materials, the chargesheet stated.

8 killed as car falls into swollen drain in MP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Agar Malwa (MP)

Eight people, among them three children and two women, were killed after their car fell into a swollen drain in Madhya Pradesh's Agar Malwa district in the early hours of Saturday, police said.

The accident occurred near the Bagulamukhi temple in Nalkhed town, around 30 km from the district headquarters, Nalkhed police station in-charge Shashi Upadhyay said. He said that the car with devotees from Odisha fell into the drain, which was overflowing with rainwater, and the occupants, including three children, two women and three men, were killed. The Nalkhed police launched a rescue operation, retrieved the bodies and sent them for post-mortem, the official said, adding that a case has been registered and further details are awaited.

State emerging as semiconductor investment destination: Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma urged investors and industry stakeholders to explore the emerging opportunities in Assam's semiconductor ecosystem, particularly with the Tata Electronics semiconductor assembly, testing and packaging (OSAT) facility at Jagiroad scheduled for commissioning in December this year. Interacting with industrialists and other stakeholders on the sidelines of SEMICON India 2026 at Yashobhoomi in the national capital on Friday, the Chief Minister said the State Government was making every effort to ensure the success of the Tata OSAT facility through enabling policies, institutional support and investor-friendly frameworks. Assam emerging as a semiconductor investment destination Sarma said the semiconductor ecosystem was expanding rapidly, opening up new avenues for innovation, investment and economic growth. The sector,



he said, was no longer confined to chip design and assembly, but was expanding into fabrication, advanced packaging, equipment, materials, research and talent development. He said the Tata OSAT facility at Jagiroad, once operational, would have the capacity to produce 48 million chips a day and generate around 27,000 direct and indirect employment opportunities. The facility, he added, would play an important role in positioning Assam, as well as India, as a major hub for semiconductor and electronics manufacturing. Gateway to Southeast Asia and ASEAN

markets Highlighting Assam's strategic geographical location, the Chief Minister said the State enjoys a unique advantage as the gateway to Southeast Asia and the wider ASEAN consumer markets. With the right ecosystem and investment, Assam could build a full-stack semiconductor industry spanning chip design, fabrication, packaging and testing, he said. Sarma said the State Government was working to create an investor-friendly environment and provide the policy and institutional support required to make Assam a preferred destination for investment and long-term

growth. Assam proudly part of India's semiconductor journey In a post on X, the Chief Minister said that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India's semiconductor mission was entering a new phase. Referring to SEMICON India 2026, Dr. Sarma said the conclave was showcasing the future of India's semiconductor industry and "Assam proudly is part of it." Sarma said the event reflected India's growing capabilities across chip design, manufacturing, research and the wider electronics ecosystem. "From building capacity to creating a globally competitive semiconductor ecosystem, India is steadily strengthening its position in the technology landscape", he said. He described the developments as 'a significant step towards a stronger, self-reliant and technology-driven Bharat'. SEMICON India 2026 showcases global semiconductor ecosystem The three-day SEMICON India 2026 was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday.

Indian tech industry bodies call for joint work to achieve national goals at Semicon India 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Technology industry bodies representing electronic components, semiconductor, IT hardware and mobile device companies have called for a unified approach to achieve goals set by the Government. This is the first time major industry bodies, semiconductor groupings Semi and Indian Electronics and Semiconductor Association (IESA), mobile device makers body Indian Electronics and Cellular Association, IT hardware body MAIT and electronics components grouping Elcina came together at the event to explore mechanisms to work together. Union Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw appealed to industry bodies to work together to develop a complete electronic product, designed and manufactured in India. Semi India and IESA President Ashok Chandak said he reached out to all the fellow associations, and all of them very respectfully agreed to extend their logos and join hands in the exhibi-



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw addresses Semicon India 2026 meeting in New Delhi
Pioneer photo

tion. "I think there is always room to grow and room to improve. We have to look at how we do this better next year. I want to highlight here that, though each of the associations has evolved in its own way and has its own strong positioning. We need to look at each other through a non-competitive approach and more as a collaborative approach," Chandak said. He said industry associations don't compete, but sometimes people view it as a competition from outside.

"It is not a question of competition among the associations here. Don't look at us as if we are competing with each other. We are collaborating, and we need to collaborate. Maybe our collaborations are not fully visible so far. "We need to work together, perhaps evolve some mechanisms for collaboration because finally, from a national agenda perspective, various associations are like dots. They must be connected properly," Chandak

NTPC terminates ₹400 crore storage project awarded to GR Infraprojects



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NTPC on Saturday said it has terminated a contract awarded to GR Infraprojects for a 400-MWh Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) project at Mouda Super Thermal Power Station in Maharashtra. The contractor had failed to meet obligations and achieve the required progress in the project, the power giant said in a statement. "NTPC has terminated the contract awarded to GR Infraprojects for the 400-MWh BESS project at Mouda Super Thermal Power Station due to the contractor's failure to meet its contractual obligations and achieve the required project progress," it said. The project, awarded in March 2026 at a total contract value of ₹413.37 crore, is a strategically important BESS project and was scheduled for completion within 15 months in line with national energy objectives; however, the project witnessed significant delays in critical activities. A contractual notice was issued to GRIL calling for immediate corrective action, but GRIL failed to undertake the required remedial measures. Accordingly, NTPC has terminated the contract with immediate effect and, in line with contractual provisions, encashed available securities amounting to approximately ₹91 crore. NTPC has already initiated action for re-tendering the project at the risk and cost of GRIL, in accordance with the applicable contractual provisions.

GDA undertakes strengthening of roads to improve connectivity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

With the objective of improving the city's traffic management and ensuring smooth connectivity between major areas, the Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) is undertaking the strengthening and development of several important roads. As part of this initiative, road strengthening work is underway on an approximately 900-metre-long and 45-metre-wide road from the international cricket stadium to the Outer Ring Road junction. An amount of approximately ₹5 crore 60 lakh 99 thousand 777 is being spent on the project. The road strengthening work has been targeted for completion within approximately three months. In this regard, GDA Vice-Chairman Nand Kishore Kalai conducted a site inspection yesterday evening along with the Chief Engineer, concerned Executive Engineer and other officials. During the inspection, he reviewed the progress and quality of the ongoing road



strengthening work. The Vice-Chairman directed the concerned officials to ensure complete compliance with prescribed technical standards and quality norms and to complete the work within the stipulated timeframe. The road will eventually be connected to the proposed Outer Ring Road and is expected to serve as an important link route. It will facilitate smooth movement of traffic from the internal areas of the city towards the Outer Ring Road. At the same time, the road will play an important role in providing improved and convenient connectivity to the proposed international cricket stadium,

which is located adjacent to the Outer Ring Road. Once the Outer Ring Road is developed, traffic heading towards the outskirts of the city will be able to reach its destinations through the Outer Ring Road instead of passing through densely populated areas. This will help reduce traffic pressure on major city roads and is also expected to significantly ease the traffic congestion currently experienced in the Rajnagar Extension area. To make the road safer and more convenient, the Authority is also undertaking the installation of streetlights on the central verge at an estimated cost of approximately ₹45 lakh. The lighting will

provide better illumination on this important road during night hours, making travel safer and more convenient. In addition, installation of street lights on both sides of the road has also been proposed. The GDA is currently preparing an estimate for the work, which will be approved after completion of the necessary procedures, following which the work will be taken up at the earliest. During the inspection, the GDA Vice-Chairman directed the officials to ensure that all road strengthening and lighting-related works are carried out in proper coordination. He also emphasised that special attention must be given to the quality of work and that all activities should be completed within the stipulated timeframe. He further ordered that the road should be developed keeping future traffic requirements in mind so that, apart from providing improved connectivity to the Outer Ring Road and the proposed international cricket stadium, it can also contribute effectively to smooth movement of traffic across the city.

Manoj Kumar Sharma assumes charge as Director (Projects) of GAIL India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Manoj Kumar Sharma on Saturday assumed the charge as Director (Projects) of GAIL (India) Limited, India's integrated energy major. Prior to assuming charge, Sharma served as Executive Director and Regional Head, Eastern Region Pipelines, at Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL). He was responsible for operations and maintenance, construction and City Gas Distribution (CGD) businesses across five States, overseeing a pipeline network spanning more than 5,700 km. With a Master's Degree in Mechanical Engineering (Production & Industrial Engineering) from Delhi College of Engineering (DCE) and a Post Graduate Diploma in Business Management from Xavier Institute of Management, Bhubaneswar (XIMB), Sharma brings extensive experience of over three decades across the entire value chain of hydrocarbon infrastructure, encompassing design and engi-



neering, project management, procurement, construction management, and operations and maintenance of crude oil, petroleum products, LPG, and natural gas pipeline networks, as well as strategically significant crude oil terminal projects. Earlier, Sharma has also served as Executive Director (Projects), Pipelines Division, IOCL, where he was responsible for engineering, procurement and construction management of major oil, LPG and natural gas pipeline projects in India and overseas. He served on the Boards of GSPL India Transco Limited (GITL), GSPL India Gasnet Limited (GIGL), and

Kochi Salem Pipeline Private Limited (KSPL) as Nominee Director representing IOCL, contributing to strategic governance and the development of energy infrastructure. With extensive leadership experience and a proven track record in board-level governance, project execution, business development, operational excellence and cost optimisation, Mr. Sharma brings a comprehensive understanding of the energy infrastructure sector along with his focus on innovation and emerging energy initiatives that will contribute to GAIL's continued growth and transformation in the evolving energy landscape.

SRM University promotes UNITES as global platform for science, innovation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Seeking to bring global scientists, academia, industry, Government, and young researchers onto a common platform to address complex challenges, SRM University-AP, Amaravati, has launched UNITES Global Innovation Society—United Network for Sustainable Development Solutions on Saturday in association with Andhra Pradesh State Council of Higher Education (APSCHE). The Centre for Interdisciplinary Research

(CIDR), SRM University-AP, will serve as the Founding and Host Institution of the new society, which is envisioned as a sustained platform for collaborative research, innovation, scientific exchange and public engagement. The central philosophy of UNITES is "problems first, disciplines second", bringing together expertise based on the challenge being addressed rather than limiting collaboration to traditional disciplinary boundaries. Professor Sarangam Vijaya Bhaskara Rao, Chairman In-

charge, APSCHE and Chief Guest of the Society's launch highlighted the importance of strengthening the connection between scientific research, higher education and society, emphasising multidisciplinary collaboration to address complex societal challenges. Addressing the gathering, Professor Achanta Venu Gopal, Director, CSIR-National Physical Laboratory & President, UNITES Global Innovation Society, stressed the need to transform India's scientific capabilities into practical solutions, calling



for greater collaboration among experts across disciplines to develop indigenous technologies and solutions for both local and global challenges. Professor Ch Satish Kumar, Vice-

Chancellor, SRM University-AP said, "Societal problems do not exist in silos, and neither should our solutions. UNITES seeks to break academic boundaries and bring diverse minds together to

create meaningful solutions for society." Professor Vijaya Mohanan Kunjkrishna Pillai, IISER Thiruvananthapuram emphasised the need to equip India's young scientific talent to tackle emerging global challenges, particularly in areas such as clean energy, water, sustainability and environmental protection, through interdisciplinary approaches. Dr Kiran Mangalampalli, Associate Professor, CIDR & General Secretary UNITES Global Innovation Society said, "UNITES aims to create

a challenge-oriented scientific ecosystem where researchers can find collaborators, emerging technologies can progress towards application, and scientific innovations can ultimately reach society." The first major gathering under UNITES, UNITES 2026—Uniting Interdisciplinary Trends in Emerging Science, announced at the Society's launch, will be held from December 27-29, 2026, at SRM University-AP, Amaravati, on the theme "Physics at the Interfaces of Matter, Light and Life."

HUDCO organises painting competition for underprivileged children to mark World Habitat Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Housing and Urban Development Corporation Ltd. (HUDCO), a Navratna NBFC-IFC under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), organised its annual painting competition for children from underprivileged and vulnerable communities at India Habitat Centre, New Delhi, as a run up to World Habitat Day celebrations. For over three decades, HUDCO's Painting Competition has been an integral part of its World Habitat Day observance, providing children from underserved communities a creative platform to express their aspirations and ideas about the places they call home. The initiative seeks to

sensitise young minds to the importance of safe, inclusive and sustainable habitats, while nurturing creativity, confidence and self-expression. The competition witnessed enthusiastic participation of around 260 children from various NGOs and orphanages, who competed in two categories—Junior Group (8-11 years) and Senior Group (12-14 years). The theme for this year, "Adequate Housing for All", encouraged the participants to look beyond the idea of a house as merely a physical structure and reflect on what makes a home safe, secure, healthy, accessible and dignified. Through their paintings, the children were encouraged to portray their vision of housing that is inclusive and responsive to the needs of people across

different social and economic backgrounds, and contributes to resilient and sustainable cities. Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & Managing Director, HUDCO, along with the Directors and Chief Vigilance Officer of HUDCO, interacted with the participating children and appreciated their enthusiasm and creativity. Addressing the children, Kulshrestha encouraged them to become torchbearers of an inclusive and sustainable future, observing that their paintings offered a glimpse into their vision of tomorrow's cities—cities that are safe, resilient, inclusive and sustainable. He further emphasised that the initiative goes beyond a painting competition, as it provides children with a space to dream,



express their aspirations and inspire others. HUDCO remains committed to nurturing such young voices and promoting the values of inclusive and sustainable urban development.

Adding a vibrant dimension to the celebrations, a Live Talent Show was also organised, giving the participating children an opportunity to showcase their talents in singing, drama, poetry

and dance. The programme provided a platform for children to express themselves beyond the canvas and underscored the importance of recognising and nurturing diverse talents among chil-

dren from underserved communities. In a new initiative aimed at fostering greater social inclusion and interaction, children of HUDCO employees also participated in the event alongside the children from NGOs and orphanages. The initiative was conceived to provide an informal and inclusive environment where children from diverse social and economic backgrounds could interact, participate and enjoy the celebrations together. By bringing children together without distinctions, the initiative seeks to encourage mutual understanding, friendship and a sense of belonging, reinforcing the broader message that inclusive communities begin with inclusive spaces for children. The award-winning paintings will subse-

quently be exhibited at Vigyan Bhawan as part of the World Habitat Day celebrations in October and winners will be felicitated by the chief guest. Through initiatives such as the annual Painting Competition, HUDCO continues to use its World Habitat Day platform to engage with children from underserved communities, encourage their creativity and aspirations, and promote awareness of the values of adequate housing, inclusivity and sustainable urban development. The initiative reflects HUDCO's broader commitment to contributing to inclusive growth and creating opportunities for young voices to participate in shaping the vision of future habitats and cities.



Denmark cautiously optimistic over US Greenland agreement

JAMES BROOKS/
KIRSTEN GRIESHABER
■ Copenhagen

Denmark's Government was cautiously optimistic on Saturday about Donald Trump's announcement of a deal on Greenland to bolster US military presence there but keep the island under Danish control, following months of threats by the US president to seize the semi-autonomous territory of a NATO ally.

In Greenland, the Arctic island's top leaders echoed that stance and said the deal had been long in coming. Trump said that the agreement would give the United States "permanent control over security, and all other needs, in Greenland, completely addressing ALL of our many US concerns." Denmark and the US already have a long-standing security agreement that has allowed the US to deploy forces in Greenland and it was not immediately clear how this deal was different from that.

The deal is expected to be signed at the UN

After Trump's announcement Friday, the office of Denmark's prime minister, Mette Frederiksen, said the deal will be signed by all three Governments next week during the United Nations General Assembly, but parliamentary action is still needed by the Danish and Greenland Governments before it can be



Denmark's Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen, Greenland's Government leader Jens-Frederik Nielsen and President of the European Commission Ursula von der Leyen visit Qorooq, Greenland

enforced. "Next week could be a good week ... for Greenland, Denmark, and the United States alike," Danish Foreign Minister Lars Løkke Rasmussen wrote on Instagram on Saturday morning.

"A period of uncertainty will hopefully be replaced by a binding agreement that strengthens security in the Arctic and the North Atlantic - and thus also our shared security within NATO and Europe - while respecting the Kingdom's red lines," he added.

Greenland's Government leader Jens-Frederik Nielsen said he was happy about the deal which he said "benefits not only our collective security, but also the continued development here in the country."

The foreign minister of Greenland, Mute B Egede,

said he was pleased that "we now have an agreement within reach." "It has taken some time," he told Denmark's TV2 broadcaster. "I'm pleased that we finally have an end product within reach. And it's about time." Trump said that with the agreement, the US would "immediately" begin the process of developing a larger military presence on the mineral-rich Danish territory.

The US had long held several bases and installations on the Arctic territory through the Cold War, before dialing back its presence.

It still operates the remote Pituffik Space Base in northwestern Greenland, built after the US and Denmark signed the Defense of Greenland

Treaty in 1951.

It supports missile defense and space surveillance operations for the US and NATO. A US State Department official said the agreement bans any non-NATO base in Greenland, limits adversaries from being able to make investments in Greenland, and guarantees that China and Russia cannot have a base on the island.

The official was not authorised to comment publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity.

US, Greenlandic and Danish officials had quietly negotiated for months behind the scenes, searching for solutions to address some of Trump's security concerns about a territory of roughly 56,000 residents.

With the announcement of the pact, Trump is able to tout a foreign policy achievement ahead of the midterm elections in the US.

After his return to the White House, Trump had called on Denmark to sell the island to the US, while insisting Greenland is crucial for US security. He pointedly wouldn't rule out taking the island by military force, even though Denmark is a NATO ally of the US. Denmark and Greenland repeatedly said the island is not for sale and condemned reports of the US gathering intelligence there. (AP)



Taiwanese President Lai Ching-te and delegates from national disaster prevention organisations posing for a group photo at the International Forum of the Whole-of-Society Defence Resilience Committee in Taiwan

Army chief Seth concludes Russia visit, holds talks on defence cooperation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moscow

Chief of Army Staff General Dhiraj Seth has concluded his three-day official visit to Russia, during which he interacted with senior military leadership of the country and visited key military institutions, Indian military officials said on Saturday.

The visit, which concluded on Friday, provided fresh impetus to India-Russia defence cooperation, with engagements focused on capability development, training exchanges, artillery modernisation and sharing of operational experience, the officials said.

Seth's visit comes days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin met



Chief of Army Staff General Dhiraj Seth

on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in New Delhi.

The two leaders reviewed bilateral cooperation across political, economic, defence, energy, space and other sectors during their meeting last week.

In Moscow, Seth interacted with General Yunus-Bek

Yevkurov, Deputy Minister of Defence of the Russian Federation. The discussions covered joint capability development, professional military exchanges and avenues for expanding military-to-military engagement, the officials said.

At the headquarters of the Russian Land Forces, Seth exchanged perspectives on contemporary military developments and discussed measures to deepen cooperation between the two armies, particularly in training, capability development and sharing of professional experience, they said.

During his visit to St Petersburg, Seth visited the Mikhailovskaya Military Artillery Academy and interacted with its faculty on training methodologies and modernisation of artillery.

United State lifts sanctions targeting Eritrea's ruling party and military

SAMUEL GETACHEW ■ Addis Ababa

The United States lifted sanctions against Eritrea's ruling party and the military that the former Biden administration imposed, according to the US Department of the Treasury.

The sanctions were issued in 2021 over humanitarian and human rights concerns during a violent conflict in the northern Ethiopian region of Tigray. Eritrean forces backed Ethiopian troops against fighters loyal to the regional government of Tigray in the conflict that ended with a peace accord in November 2022.

Many people in northern Ethiopia, including the neighboring regions of Amhara and Afar, were uprooted from their homes and tens of thousands of were believed to have been killed.

The Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control said in a Friday statement that sanctions against some Eritrean individuals, including Hagos Ghebrehivwet, a key financial official, were removed. The Red Sea Trading Corporation, linked to the ruling party, also had sanctions lifted.

Eritrean Information Minister Yemane Gebremeskel said the sanctions were unwarranted and caused considerable



damage to his country. "In this respect, we welcome the gesture and remedial measures by the Trump Administration," Gebremeskel told The Associated Press.

The sanctions delisting comes as concerns have risen about security in the Red Sea.

Recent Houthis advances in Yemen have increased threats to shipping through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, while Eritrea's southern coast and the port of Assab lie near the strategic passage connecting the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden. (AP)

Early warning system for disasters Nepal's top priority: PM

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

An early warning system for disasters will be implemented as a "top priority" in Nepal, said Prime Minister Balendra Shah on Saturday.

The Bhotekoshi flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal, killing over 1,400 people and leaving over 6000 missing as of Friday.

Experts believe many lives would have been saved if they had proper warning. Speaking at a Constitution Day programme at Tundikel Open Ground on Saturday, PM Shah said: "Special emphasis will be laid on risk reduction, preparedness, and response. The disaster early warning system will be implemented as a top priority." PM Shah also expressed gratitude to all



friendly nations, the international community and organisations, private sector, civil servants and the people of the country who assisted in disaster management, noting that the "loss and damage caused by the Bhotekoshi flood were

unimaginable and irreparable for us."

Speaking about the country's economy, the Prime Minister said that the Government would work to promote innovation and entrepreneurship and the creation of a knowledge-

based economy by integrating artificial intelligence, digital technology and cyber security.

Citing the Digital Governance Action Plan, the Shah said that the good governance demanded by the youth would also be ensured through technology.

Stating that good governance, development, prosperity and social justice are the aspirations of citizens, he said, "The Government's each step is, and will remain, directed towards realising these very aspirations." The Prime Minister said that competitive multi-party democracy, human rights and the rule of law are the foundations of national life. "This Constitution has made one promise before the Nepali citizen that is building an equitable society based on unity amidst diversity, an end to all forms of discrimination, on development, prosperity and social justice," he said. (PTI)

Russia holds parliamentary vote in areas seized from Ukraine during war

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russia's parliamentary election for the first time includes residents of regions that Moscow illegally annexed from Ukraine after the start of its full-scale invasion more than 4 1/2 years ago, part of Kremlin efforts



to cement its gains.

Officials in Kyiv vigorously denounced the action as illegal, and a human rights activist described residents there as being coerced to participate in the election.

While the vote across Russia lasts until Sunday to help boost turnout, balloting actually has been underway in the annexed parts of Ukraine and some areas on the Russian side of the

CARLOS VALDEZ/
ISABEL DEBRE ■ La Paz

Bolivian lawmakers approved a \$1.9 billion loan agreement with the International Monetary Fund (IMF), delivering the conservative Government a key victory in its efforts to ease the country's deep economic crisis as unions threatened renewed protests.

Just hours after Congress approved the loan, President Rodrigo Paz announced an immediate end to subsidies for the diesel powering Bolivia's trucks, buses and



President Rodrigo Paz

tractors — a step toward meeting IMF demands. Gasoline, used mainly in private cars, would remain subsidised for now, though Paz had already scaled back

that support in recent months. The Senate ratified the IMF agreement a day after the lower house approved it, clearing the final legislative hurdle for the three-year financing

program aimed at replenishing dwindling foreign reserves and stabilising the ailing economy marked by high inflation and weak growth.

The IMF first announced the staff-level agreement in July after months of negotiations with Paz's market-friendly Government, which took power last year after nearly two decades of socialist rule as part of a wave of new Latin American leaders allied with the Trump administration.

The program still requires approval from the IMF's executive board before funds can

be disbursed. Economy Minister Christian Morales told senators that the deal would give other lenders, including the World Bank and the Inter-American Development Bank, greater confidence in the Government and help it secure about \$5 billion in additional financing.

But the assistance is conditioned on tough economic measures, including the elimination of fuel subsidies, that threaten to reignite unrest in Bolivia, where weeks of road blockades in June and July paralysed much of the South American nation. (AP)

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on @SCRRailwaysIndia
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C. Railway can be seen on our website: www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

**Open e-Tender Notice No. :
DRM/Works/SC/141-149/2026/
OT, Dated : 16-09-2026.**

PUB/658

For and on behalf of President of India, the undersigned invites e-tender for the following works up to 14:00 hours on 16-10-2026.

SI.No. : 01. e-Tender No. : 141.CO.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : BPO-KZJ, MAGH-GDCR, PDPL-NZB, KZJ-MTMI, DKJ-MUGR, BDCR-STPL, MTMI-JNPD, PGDP-VUNP, WD-SC, WD-FC, SC-KZJ, SNF-MLY, KHNP-HMBD, VKB-PLLI Sections : Reconditioning of worn out CMS Crossing by using Robotic Welding Machine under Sr.DEN/Co-ord/SC of entire Secunderabad Division.

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 1,04,25,972/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 2,08,600/- Completion period in Months : 24. Maintenance period in Months : 80 GMT or one year whichever earlier.

SI.No. : 02. e-Tender No. : 142.CR.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : SC-KZJ sections : Repairs and improvements to RUB No.251, 251A & 251B at Km 194A/25-27 between Secunderabad Jn. and Lallaguda stations.

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 79,30,443/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 1,58,600/- Completion period in Months : 06. Maintenance period in Months : 06.

SI.No. : 03. e-Tender No. : 143.S.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : Annual Zonal Contract - Khammam (Excluding) to Kondapalli (Excluding) and Motamari to Janpahad (Excluding) section (for the period from 01-07-2026 to 30-06-2027

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 74,53,000/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 1,49,100/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : Nil.

SI.No. : 04. e-Tender No. : 144.N.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : KZJ-BPO Section : OPL - Improvement to Uppal Goods shed.

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 9,40,75,771/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 18,81,500/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : 36.

SI.No. : 05. e-Tender No. : 145.N.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : KZJ-BPO Section : Odela - Upgradation of Passenger amenities at Odela Railway Station as per NSG-4 category norms (Building portion).

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 6,37,97,428/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 12,76,000/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : 36.

SI.No. : 06. e-Tender No. : 146.N.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : SW 1) Manchiryal - Provision of additional facilities at Manchiryal Goods shed. SW 2) Manchiryal - Development of Manchiryal Parcel office. SW 3) Signal arrangement in connection with Interlocking of Three (3) number of LC gates (LC No. 42-24 & 15) of NZB- PDPL section (Construction of Relay hut for LC 15 & 24).

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 1,63,28,682/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 3,26,600/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : 36.

SI.No. : 07. e-Tender No. : 147.N.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : Construction of New Running Room at PRPI with 30 beds.

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 3,48,00,761/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 6,96,100/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : 36.

SI.No. : 08. e-Tender No. : 148.N.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : Proposed construction of Limited Height subway as precast RCC Box of size 1x2.6x2.60m by Air Pushing Method using 20.4m RH girder at 1.1km 147/27-29 and 2.1km 148/10-12 b/w MAGH - WHIRGOAN stations for wildlife crossing under Sr.DEN/North jurisdiction.

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 5,56,39,703/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 11,12,800/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : 48.

SI.No. : 09. e-Tender No. : 149.NW.SC.26.OT. Name of the Work : SC-WD section : SW 1) Lingampally : Construction of New Running Room at LPI with 40 beds. SW 2) Lingampalli : New TTE Rest House with 30 Beds (24-M, 06-F TTEs with separate toilets), ACs, Kitchen, Store, R.O water and Furniture provision. SW 3) Lingampalli: Provision of CC pathway 200x1.5m from C&W office to Station platform, Provision of 4x3 m room for R&D staff on PF 4 & 5 under FOB and provision of Rolling in huts & lights on PF3 side SC end.

Approximate Tender Value in Rs. : 6,49,39,051/-. Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : 12,98,800/- Completion period in Months : 12. Maintenance period in Months : 36.

1. Tenderers should participate through e-tendering only and no manual offers may be considered.

2. Tender conditions / other particulars are available in the Tender documents on IREPS website at ireps.gov.in which can be downloaded, can be participated and can view any modifications if any.

Sr. DEN / Co-ordination / Secunderabad.

Notice Inviting e-TENDER (through http://ireps.gov.in)

CE/C-1/SC Construction Organization, South Central Railway, Secunderabad, respectively, invites e-tender on behalf of the President of India for the following works :

SI.No. : 1. Notice Inviting Tender No. : 47-CAO-C-SC-2026, Dated : 11-09-2026. Name of work : South Central Railway Construction Organization - Nanded Division - Proposed yard arrangements at Dinegaon yard from Km. 167.500 to 170.200 (2.70 Kms) and Jalna yard at Km. 174.975 to 177.450 (2.475 Kms) (Total : 5.175 Kms) in connection with Proposed Doubling of Track from Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar to Parbhani stations and as a part of Jalna - Jalgaon Newline : Execution of earth work in formation, Construction of Minor bridges, FOB, Station building, RBG rooms, Goomties, Staff quarters, High level Platform, collection of Ballast, transportation of P.Way materials, laying and linking of track and other connected miscellaneous works etc.

Details : Estimated Cost : Rs. 54,70,73,441.25. Earnest Money Deposit : Rs. 1,09,41,500.00. Completion Period : 24 (Twenty Four) Months. Date of Opening : 13-10-2026 15:00 hours.

i) For bid document and other details, please login to website http://ireps.gov.in

ii) Tenderers can submit their offers online during tender submission period which is the Fifteen days period prior to closing of tender.

iii) Tenderers should watch for any Corrigenda (issued online only) up to the date of commencement of the Tender submission period.

Chief Administrative Officer, A763 (Const.), Secunderabad.

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

Re: Built-up Third Floor with roof rights (i.e. the said floor), Built on front portion of Property bearing No. B-3, measuring area of Plot 104.51 sq. mtrs., out of total area measuring 226 sq. yds., out of Rectangle No. 17, Killa No. 16/2, situated in the abadi of South Anarkali, Village Khurji Khas, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi-110051; hereinafter referred to as "said property". NOTICE is hereby given to general public that our client, Mrs. Meenal (hereinafter called the "owner") is the absolute owner of the said floor vide a Sale Deed dated 08.05.2025 executed by Mrs. Mamta Bansal, Mrs. Poonam Arora & Mrs. Mamta Gupta (hereinafter referred as "sellers"). It has been also informed that Mr. Kishan Dutt was the owner of the said property vide Sale Deed dated 23.11.1968. Thereafter, the said property sold to Mr. Chander Bhan vide Sale Deed dated 11.12.1968 and further he had executed a Will dated 14.03.2001 in favour of Mrs. Shashi Kala Wadhwa. Thereafter, Mrs. Shashi Kala Wadhwa executed a Sale Deed dated 19.05.2023 in favour of sellers in proportion. And finally, sellers have sold the said floor to our client as mentioned above. The said owner has also informed that the said floor is not mortgaged anywhere and there is no dispute or any litigation pending upon the said floor. Any person including Banks, Financial Institutions, relatives having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the said floor is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the owner in respect of the said floor shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our client/owner, in any manner whatsoever. Shivkant Arora, Advocate For Ms/Intelligence Law Offices A-74, LGF, Defence Colony, New Delhi-110024

Saudi warns of aerial threat, blast heard in Riyadh

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Saudi Arabia warned of a "hostile aerial threat" after issuing emergency alerts, and at least one explosion was heard in Riyadh.

The alert in Riyadh was the first for the Saudi capital since the latest escalation with Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels.

No casualties or damage were reported after the alerts were lifted. Saudi authorities didn't say what prompted the alerts or the cause of the audible explosions, but they previously reported intercepting incoming Houthi missiles and drones.

The UN's most powerful body said late Friday that



the Houthis' military escalation, attacks and threats "risk further expanding the conflict, threatening maritime security and interna-

tional trade," while undermining regional and international efforts to secure peace in Yemen.

It warned that continued

escalation would exacerbate the already dire humanitarian situation in the country.

The council's 15 members called for "practical cooperation" to prevent the Iran-backed Houthis from acquiring arms, military training, financing and other military-related assistance needed to carry out their attacks.

They stressed that all countries must enforce the UN arms embargo against the rebel group. Iran executives man accused of spying for Israel Iran's State TV reported on Saturday that a man identified as Hossein Pedram was executed after being convicted on charges of spying for Israel's intelligence agency Mossad.

The report said Pedram passed on to Israel classified information on "sensitive military sites" in Iran's Isfahan province. It didn't say how he accessed the classified information. Pedram was reportedly arrested after those sites, which included missile bases, were targeted in the 12-day air war by the US and Israel against Iran in June last year. A recent surge of executions in Iran prompted an international outcry by human rights groups.

Iran's State TV reported Saturday that the Tehran prosecutor's office filed charges against race organisers after women participated without covering their hair because "legal and Islamic

Sharia" wasn't observed.

The country's ruling theology requires women to wear scarves that cover their hair and loose-fitting clothes that hide their entire bodies.

Footage circulated online showing many women running the 10-kilometre race without the mandatory hair covering. Habib Sotoudehnejad, head of Tehran's sports department, said Saturday that about 5 per cent of participants violated race rules.

The race was run separately for men and women.

Hard liners in Iran seek harsh penalties against women who appear in public without covering their hair.

World's largest folk festival Munich Oktoberfest begins



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Munich

Munich's Oktoberfest kicked off Saturday with the city's mayor tapping the first keg of beer and opening the 191st edition of the world's largest folk festival.

Mayor Dominik Krause put the first keg on tap with only two strokes and the traditional cry of "O'zapft is" – or "It's been tapped."

Thousands of revellers – the women dressed in Bavarian dirndls, the men in lederhosen – stormed the beer tents on Munich's Theresienwiese fairground in the morning to get a good spot on the benches. To the sounds of brass music and the taste of freshly tapped beer, they soon started singing, dancing and swaying.

Besides beer, pretzels, pork roast and sausages were also sought-after delicacies. Over the course of 16 days, through October 4, some 6

million visitors are expected at the Oktoberfest. The majority of them come from Munich and southern Germany. However, millions of guests also travel from other parts of Germany and from around the world.

German authorities tightened security measures, after the festival last year had to close temporarily due to overcrowding. AI-powered cameras were installed for this year's fest to detect large crowds early on, the German news agency dpa reported.

A ban on knives and flying objects – especially drones – was also in effect. There are entry checks, large bags are prohibited – and smoking marijuana is not allowed. About 600 police officers are on duty around the festival in addition to Bavarian riot police, specialised pickpocket investigators, and international task forces from eight countries, dpa reported. (AP)

Pakistan, Iran discuss energy supply, safe passage for ships

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Pakistan's Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar discussed uninterrupted energy supplies and safe passage for commercial ships during a telephone call Saturday with his Iranian counterpart Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi.

Pakistan's Foreign Ministry said in a statement that Dar underscored the importance of ensuring that ships pass safely and quickly, citing the potential effects of disruptions on developing countries and global supply chains.

The statement did not provide details of Araghchi's response.

Pakistan has faced rising energy prices as the tensions spiked, increasing pressure on Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's Government. An Islamist party has threatened to march on the capital,

Islamabad, unless the Government lowers fuel prices. On other hand Turkiye's banking watchdog, the Banking Regulation and Supervision Agency, revoked the operating license for the Istanbul branch of Iran's Bank Mellat.

The agency said on Saturday that it made the decision to protect depositors or the stability of the Turkiye's financial system.

The announcement comes as the United States is demanding other countries tighten economic measures against Iran.

Bank Mellat has been subject to Western sanctions for years and was named in 2019 as having links to the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard Corps. The US Treasury Department earlier this month imposed sanctions on a Turkish investment bank and two subsidiaries over alleged ties to Iran.



Pakistan's Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar and Iranian counterpart FM Abbas Araghchi

Security forces kill 11 terrorists in Pakistan's Balochistan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Eleven terrorists were killed during intelligence-based operations in Pakistan's Balochistan province on Saturday, a day after security forces killed seven terrorists in the restive province.

In Panjgur's Gowargo area, security forces killed five terrorists and recovered a large quantity of weapons and ammunition from their possession. Six terrorists were also killed during operations in the Aminabad and Siah Chang areas of Chagai district.

Nepal forms seven-member panel to probe cause of flash floods that killed over 1,400

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal Government has formed a seven-member expert panel to investigate what triggered last month's devastating floods, which killed more than 1,400 people and left over 6,000 missing, an official said on Saturday. The panel would also examine the possible role of climate change in the disaster.

Flash floods originating near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26 devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal. The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydropower projects.

The Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation has formed



the panel comprising experts in hydrology, glaciology, remote sensing, geology, hydropower infrastructure and disaster risk reduction, according to Tika Ram Baral, joint secretary-rank officer at the ministry.

The panel, headed by water policy and governance expert Debesh Belbase, comprises hydrologist Narendra Man Shakya, glaciologist Rijan Bhakta Kayastha, remote-sensing expert Uttam Babu Shrestha,

hydropower infrastructure expert Hari Pandit, geologist Meghraj and disaster-risk reduction specialist Anil Pokhrel.

The panel will seek to determine what exactly caused the devastating flash flood in the Bhotekoshi river on August 26, how the disaster unfolded and whether climate change played a role, Baral said.

There had been speculation that the flood was triggered by a collapse of ice and rock in the high Himalayas, followed by an avalanche.

However, a preliminary assessment has found insufficient scientific evidence to conclusively establish the origin and sequence of the disaster. The expert panel will conduct a detailed scientific investigation to establish the cause and sequence of events and examine the possible links among glacial, geological and hydrological hazards. (PTI)

ISRAELI STRIKES KILL TWO PEOPLE IN GAZA

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Gaza's Health Ministry and Shifa Hospital officials said one man was killed in the Shijaiyah neighbourhood of Gaza City. Another man, identified as the son of the ministry's director general, was killed as he walked in the Jabaliya refugee camp in northern Gaza. The Israeli military did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the strikes.

The heaviest fighting between Israel and Hamas has subsided since a ceasefire took effect last October, but Israeli fire has killed more than 13,780 Palestinians in Gaza since then, according to health officials in the territory. The UN agency for Palestinian refugees (UNRWA) says more than 280,000 children in Gaza are attending school in tents and heavily damaged classrooms after years of war.

At a UNRWA-run school in Nuseirat, some classrooms have no desks, leaving children to sit on blankets on the floor. Still, some families say that a return to school brings back a familiar sense of routine that was upended by war.



PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Simran who is purchasing Property Situated at Out of Kharsa No 359, Gali No.3, J-Block, Colony Known as Swareop Nagar, Near Kushal Road, Village Siraspur, Delhi, 110042, from Mrs. Veena who had owned the subject property on the basis of Notarized GPA, ATS & Will dated 27.08.2019 executed by Mr. Tushar Kumar, now Mrs. Simran intend to mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LIMITED. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client, Smt. Jawitri, wife of Late Shri Ramesh Kumar, resident of House No. 73, Balmiki Mohalla, Badli, North West Delhi-110042, has disowned her sons, namely 1. Parveen Kumar, son of Late Shri Ramesh Kumar, and 2. Naveen Kumar, son of Late Shri Ramesh Kumar, on account of their bad conduct and disobedience, and has excluded them from her movable and immovable property and severed all relations with them. Henceforth, they shall be solely responsible for all their acts/dealings. My client and her family shall bear no responsibility whatsoever for the same.

Surender Singh Shekhawat (Advocate) Ch. No. M-14, Civil Side, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi-54

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Faizan who is the owner of Plot No. 58 land area measuring 50 sq. yards, i.e. 41.80 sq. mtrs. out of Kharsa No. 239 situated at Kala Enclave Kharsa, Loni Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh, on the basis of Regd. Sale Deed Dated 30.12.2025 bearing Document No. 15868, Book No.1, Volume No. 23274, Pages No. 353-372, regd. on 30.12.2025 (SRO-Ghaziabad-2). That Sale Deed Dated 30.12.2025 executed by Mr. Aman and Mrs. Rakhi in favour of Mr. Faizan S/o Mohd. Annuddin in respect of Plot No. 58 area measuring 50 sq. yards, i.e. 41.80 sq. mtrs. out of Kharsa No. 239 as Document No. 15868, Book No.1, Volume No. 23274, Pages No. 353-372, regd. on 30.12.2025 (SRO-Ghaziabad-2), now Mr. Faizan intend to mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LIMITED. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN that our client, M/s Ganesh Real-Estate Developers InfraTech Private Limited, intends to purchase and mortgage the property described in the Schedule below. The said property is currently owned by the surviving legal heirs of the late absolute owners, namely: Late Mr. Kallash Mandhan (deceased 14.12.1991), Late Mr. Naveen Mandhan (deceased 29.03.2011), Late Mrs. Rukmani Devi Mandhan (deceased 04.05.2013), Late Mr. Mandhar Lal Mandhan (deceased 22.10.2020), and Late Mrs. Chitra Kapoor (deceased 22.01.2026). The respective legal heirs are namely: Mr. Gajender, Mr. Jitender, Mr. Janender, Mrs. Sunita Rani, Mrs. Paresah, Ms. Gajwani Mandhan, Ms. Devanshi, Mr. Gohar, and Mr. Ajay Kapoor. Our client has applied for a financial loan from ICICI Bank Ltd. against the security of this property by way of a mortgage. Any person having any claim, right, title, interest, or objection to the proposed sale or mortgage of the said property must submit their objection in writing along with supporting documents to the undersigned within seven (7) days of this notice of his/her share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to the public at large that Mr. Shahid had acquired Commercial cum Residential House area measuring 122.66 sq. mtrs. Kharsa No. 164, Situated at Village Nawabganj Majra Sardhana, Pergana and Tehsil Sardhana Distt. Meerut, U.P. vide Gift Deed dated 18.02.2026 executed by Mr. Alauddin, Regd. Doc. No. 3978. Now Mr. Shahid is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with CFCFL.

OR

Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance whatsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.

Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi -110024

DIRECTORATE Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board Mandi Bhawan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph:05944-250056 Fax: 05944-50059

Ref: U.K.A.P.M.B.2026/1566 Date: 19.09.2026

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is Inviting Auction of 13.70 acre land & Floriculture Mandi in Bhurarani Rudrapur and to be given on lease rent. Auction of Selected Bidders to be Carried out on 22.09.2026 (Tuesday) from 12:00 pm to 6:00 pm on <https://www.procfax.com> for further necessary action. General Manager (Finance)

DIRECTORATE Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board Mandi Bhawan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph:05944-250056 Fax: 05944-50059

Ref: U.K.A.P.M.B.2026/1565 Date: 19.09.2026

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is Inviting Auction of 17.51 acre land in Bhurarani Rudrapur and to be given on lease rent. Auction of Selected Bidders to be Carried out on 23.09.2026 (Wednesday) from 12:00 pm to 6:00 pm on <https://www.procfax.com> for further necessary action. General Manager (Finance)

DIRECTORATE Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board Mandi Bhawan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph:05944-250056 Fax: 05944-50059

Ref: U.K.A.P.M.B.2026/1567 Date: 19.09.2026

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is Inviting Auction of godown, Cold Storage in Vikasnagar & Manglore Mandi and to be given on lease rent. Applying process and other related information and condition may be seen on <https://www.procfax.com> from 21.09.2026 on 12:00 noon to 01.10.2026 till 5:00 pm. Interested persons and firms may visit at <https://www.procfax.com> for further necessary action. General Manager (Finance)

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Corporate Off. : 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051. Regd. Off. : Commertzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY [(Appendix IV) Rule 8(1)]

WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. a Housing Finance Company (duly registered with National Housing Bank (Fully Owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Secutisation and Reconstruction of Financial Asssets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has Taken Possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned here in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Date of Possession
1.	610839211785696 & 61083951794889 1. Shilpa Chaudhary S/o. Mahender Singh 2. Prashant Kumar S/o. Rajkumar	A Residential Flat No 308, At Third Floor, Covered And Super Area 133.3 Sq. Yard Or 111.48 Sq.mtrs Consisting Of Kharsa No 79/2 And 80, Majra Harishchandra Royal Apartments, Rev Vill - Poshanpur Dauri, Pargana - Daurala, Teh - Sardhana, Dist - Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, East > Pvt. Flat No. 307, West > Open Space, North > Pvt Flat No. 316, South > Open Space	23.06.2026 Rs. 34,39,124.95/- (Rs. Thirty Four Lakh Thirty Nine Thousand One Hundred Twenty Four & Paise Ninety Five Only) as on 16.06.2026	15.09.2026

Place : Meerut, Uttar Pradesh Sd/-
Date : 15.09.2026 Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

Office of the Superintending Engineer 3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh Email: sepdwdph@rediffmail.com

Letter No. : 3570/984C(Yata A)-03/2026 Dated : 18/09/2026

National Competetive E-Tender Notice

The Superintending Engineer, 3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh, invites e-tenders through the Two Bid System on behalf of the Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand for the "Improvement and widening of the Pithoragarh-Chandak motor road from single lane to 1.5 lane in Pithoragarh constituency of district Pithoragarh under the Honorable CM announcement No. 525/2025 (Length 6.00KM)" from contractors/firms registered in Class 'A' or above for road works and who are permanent residents of Uttarakhand.

Detailed tender documents, specifications, amendments, corrigendum, etc., can be viewed on the e-procurement portal <https://uktenders.gov.in> after 24.09.2026.

kotak Kotak Mahindra Bank NOTICE Locker Hired by MR. KAPIL SHARMA having address at WZ-10 GALI NO-16 SADH NAGAR, PALAM COLONY, NEW DELHI, 110045, INDIA with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. KAPIL SHARMA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable. It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. KAPIL SHARMA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 19, 2026 at around 12p.m.

kotak Kotak Mahindra Bank NOTICE Locker Hired by MR. JAIBIR having address at RZH 824 34,35 PALAM COLONY TOP,FLOOR NEAR KENNEDY PUBLIC SCHOOL RAJ NAGAR PART 2, NEW DELHI, 110077,INDIA with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. JAIBIR calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable. It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. JAIBIR within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 19, 2026 at around 12p.m.

kotak Kotak Mahindra Bank NOTICE Locker Hired by MR. GARVESH SHARMA having address at E-72 MOHAN GARDEN UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI, 110059 INDIA with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. GARVESH SHARMA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable. It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. GARVESH SHARMA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 19, 2026 at around 12p.m.

BRIEFLY

Pranavi Urs moves into top 10 at La Sella Open



Pranavi Urs strengthened her position among the leading players at the La Sella Open, moving into the top 10 at the halfway stage after a battling 1-under 71 in the second round which took her total to 4-under 140.

The Hero-backed Indian, who opened with a 69, is currently seven shots behind halfway leader Charlotte Heath of England, who surged to 11-under 133 after a spectacular 65. Play was again disrupted by weather conditions, with the second round yet to be completed.

Pranavi has been the standout Indian in the field and produced a gritty round in difficult conditions, mixing four birdies with three bogeys. She made an early move with back-to-back birdies on the third and fourth holes before dropping a shot on the ninth to make the turn at 1-under.

The back nine proved more eventful. Pranavi slipped to consecutive bogeys on the 13th and 14th holes.

But she showed composure late in the round, finishing strongly with birdies on the 17th and 18th to return to the clubhouse with a round under par.

Her current position puts her in contention for another strong finish after her best result of the season so far came at the Dutch Ladies Open, where she finished tied fifth.

Among the other Indians, Avani Prashanth is currently tied 49th at 2-over 146 after rounds of 74 and 72 and remains around the projected cut line, which stood at 2-over when play was suspended. (PTI)

GOVT. OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (ROADS), ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/STBR/II/14/2026-27/02

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Chief Engineer. PWD (Roads), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3, invites Bid on behalf of the Governor of Assam from eligible contractors registered with Assam PWD (Roads) or registered in Central GoI./any State Government/ Semi Govt. Organization / Central or State Public Sector Undertakings for "Construction of ROB at Kakoti gaon in Replacement of Railway LC Gate No ST-34 at Railway KM 104/7-8 on Raha Kampur Road under Construction of ROB S on 50:50 Cost Sharing Basis (Balance Work)" for an amount of **Rs. 3569.80 Lakh (Rupees thirty five crore sixty nine lakh eighty thousand) only** (Approx.).

Details may be seen at website <http://assamtenders.gov.in>.

Amendment/Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWD. Assam website <http://assamtenders.gov.in>.

Sd/-

Chief Engineer. PWD (Roads) Assam.

DIPR/CF/PIO/1661/20-Sep-26 Chandmari. Guwahati-3

The Pioneer

Classified

LOST & FOUND

I, Nishtha Wadhawan D/o Sanjeev Wadhawan, R/o 2/57 Old Rajinder Nagar Delhi – 110060 have Lost My Original migration Certificate from Shobhit University, Aadhar Card, Pan Card, DrivingLicense. Finder please contact 9013222273.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Aishwarya Thakur D/o Sh. Arun Kumar, R/o- Flat No. 310, Block-F, Sector-17, Vasundhra, Ghaziabad-201012 (UP), declare that in PAN and Aadhar card my name is mentioned as Aishwarya Thakur. Through this affidavit, I declare that Aishwarya Thakur and Aishwarya are the names of the same person for all purposes.

I, hitherto known as MOHD. JAVED S/O JAMIL BEG R/O 1350, Madrsa Shah Abdul Aziz, Kalan Mahal, Daryaganj , District Central Delhi, Delhi -110025 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as JAVED BEG.

I, hitherto known as VIKAS S/O OM PRAKASH R/O H.NO. 229, GALI NO. 4, ASHOK MOHALLA, NANGLOI, WEST DELHI, DELHI-110041 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as **VIKAS SINGH**.

I, MANOJ SINGH BHANDARI S/O RANJIT SINGH R/O H. NO. 1076, TYPE-2, DELHI ADMIN FLATS, NEAR SAFAL DAIRY, GULABI BAGH, PO: MALKA GANJ, NORTH DELHI, DELHI-110007 have changed the name of my minor daughter SHURTI BHANDARI aged 14 Years and she shall hereafter be known as **SHRUTI BHANDARI**

Aichi-Nagoya

Asiad opens with colourful ceremony

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ Nagoya

Japan showcased its technological and industrial might alongside its deep cultural moonings on Saturday during a frugal yet colourful Asian Games opening ceremony, offering a silver lining after organizational and logistical troubles significantly marred the build-up.

The next 15 days will see around 11,000 athletes from 45 nations competing in 43 sports, 71 sub-events, and a total of 469 gold medals till the closing day on October 4. Competitions for basketball, football, cricket and some other events have already started. With the concept theme 'Harmonic Heart Beat', Japan welcomed the Asian athletes for the third time in its history after 1958 Tokyo and 1994 Hiroshima.

The centrepiece of the ceremony was the heart-shaped main stage which was chosen to visually anchor the theme of 'One Asia', symbolizing athletes and people from across the continent connecting 'heart to heart'.

The spectacular show at the 30,000-capacity full-to-the-brim Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium seamlessly blended local Aichi industrial technology with classical art, featuring a traditional

Japanese Kabuki stage element paired with a massive industrial robot arm waving a flag.

Japanese Emperor Naruhito declared the 20th Asian Games open midway into the two-hour long opening ceremony in the presence of Empress Masako, Olympic Council of Asia President Sheikh Joaan bin Hamad Al Thani and International Olympic Committee chief Kirsty Coventry.

With the Toyota Motor Corporation headquartered in the Aichi prefecture, the show would not have been complete without showcasing some marvellous innovation connected with it. An Accessible People Mover (APM), which became famous as a specialized, low-speed mobility vehicle developed by Toyota for the Tokyo 2020 Olympic and Paralympic Games was a prominent part of the show.

The build-up to the massive multi-sport event was, however, hit by a string of operational gaffes, logistical issues and cramped accommodations, putting the beleaguered organising committee and the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) on the defensive.

The organisational chaos did dent Japan's reputation,



Members of India's contingent walk during the opening ceremony for the Asian Games in Nagoya, Japan on Saturday

which has otherwise hosted major global events, including the FIFA World Cup (2002) and Olympics (1964, 2021) in the past with fair amount of success. Led by ace shooter Manu Bhaker and kabaddi player Pawan Sehrawat, India entered the Athletes Parade to a round of applause. Dressed in navy blue Saree and bandhgala-style ceremonial jacket, Bhaker was seen waving to the crowd as she entered the arena, leading the 150-strong Indian contingent along with Sehrawat.

The Indian male participants also wore navy blue bandhgala style ceremonial jackets with matching trousers for the ceremony. Olympic Council of Asia's

with heart-shaped wings floated sparkling through the air, transporting the arena into a world of hearts for the opening ceremony's welcome dance.

As Hakase's violin solo began, 240 citizen dancers, grouped into four different colours, from Nagoya and other parts of Aichi emerged from below the stage. They converged and diverged repeatedly, expressing the interconnectedness and pulse of life in various formations. Finally, the dancers formed the word 'WELCOME', conveying hospitality.

After the Japanese flag raising ceremony and rendition of host country's national anthem, the Athletes Parade began.

In his address, OCA President Al Thani lauded Japan for its sporting pedigree and hoped for another successful Games.

"Tonight, the eyes of Asia - and indeed much of the world - turn to Japan. What we will see over the next days will inspire us. It will move us. And it will remind us of what we are capable of when we come together for Asia. Kokode hitotsu ni (Imagine One Asia)," he said.

Talking about the power of sport, he said, "It does not ask where you are from, or what you believe. It asks only what are your limits? How far can you push beyond them? The 11,000 athletes who represent every NOC of our continent at these Games have answered those questions countless times, in training centres, in sports venues, in stadiums.

"While the world is too often divided by conflict, they remind us that sport remains a powerful force for peace, understanding, and friendship among nations."

The second segment of the ceremony showcased Aichi-Nagoya's culture and tradition with the theme of 'Heart Beat of Tradition', centered on Nagoya Castle.

The most spectacular show of the second part of the opening ceremony on Saturday was the high-tech act involving lasers, showcasing Aichi-Nagoya's manufacturing excellence.

Titled 'Harmony connecting to the Future', it reflected on the history of manufacturing (clock-making, mechanical floats dashi) evolving into futuristic light-based entertainment. The performance featured mechanical dancers, work-wear dancers, business suit dancers, LED dancers, rhythmic gymnastics, roller dancers, and child dancers, concluding with the HONOHON dance. (PTI)

Manu, Neeru and India's shooting stars ready to hit bullseye in Nagoya

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

India will enter the shooting competition of the Asian Games on Sunday with China likely to pose the biggest challenge to a formidable 30-member squad led by two-time Olympic medalist Manu Bhaker. Indian shooters produced a record 12-medal haul—seven gold, nine silver and six bronze—at the Hangzhou Asian Games. Their consistency this season, particularly in rifle and pistol, has strengthened the belief that the squad can make another significant contribution to India's campaign in Nagoya.

The contingent combines established Olympians and world-class performers with emerging talent, many of

whom have already experienced the pressure of Asian Games and Olympic competition. But the spotlight will inevitably fall on Manu, who will chase her first individual Asian Games gold after a historic double-bronze outing at the Paris Olympics. She won bronze in the 10m air pistol before teaming up with Sarabjot Singh for another bronze in the mixed team event.

This will be Manu's third Asian Games. She made her continental debut as a teenager at the 2018 Jakarta Games, alongside fellow air pistol shooter Saurabh Chaudhary, under the guidance of junior national coach Jaspal Rana.

Much has changed since then. Rana, her mentor and coach during those formative



India's formidable 30-member shooting squad, featuring Olympic medalist Manu Bhaker and other top talents

years, died earlier this year and his absence will be deeply felt. For Manu, a return to the Asian Games carries an added emotional significance, taking her back to the competition where her journey on the continental stage began with

multi-round competition. India can even contemplate a rare podium sweep. The 10m air pistol trio of Manu, Esha and Suruchi Inder Singh brings together a multiple World Cup gold medalist in Suruchi and two of India's most accomplished young stars.

In the 25m pistol, Manu and Esha will be joined by the immensely experienced Rahi Sarnobat, who created history by winning gold in the event at the 2018 Asian Games. After missing the 2022 Hangzhou Games due to a debilitating illness, Sarnobat appears to have put her prolonged health struggles behind her and is back in the right space to challenge for a return to the top of the podium.

With individual and team

medals on offer, the two pistol events will be among the biggest points of interest in the programme.

Before the pistol stars take centre stage, however, the competition will open with the women's 10m air rifle, where Elavenil Valarivan, Sonam Uttam Maskar and Vidarsa K Vinod will carry India's challenge.

Elavenil, 27, is most experienced of the trio and has been in outstanding form. The Olympian won a world championship medal last year and followed it with individual gold at the Asian Championships in Shymkent in 2025 and Delhi in 2026. Her consistency throughout the season makes her one of the leading names to watch when competition begins on Sunday. (PTI)

India face Japan threat in Asian Games team events

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya

India will look to go one better than their silver-medal finish in the men's team event at the previous edition as they begin their badminton campaign, with the men taking on Bangladesh and the women facing Kazakhstan in the opening round at the Asian Games here on Sunday.

The team competition will be followed by the individual events from September 25.

India won a historic men's doubles gold through Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty at Hangzhou in 2023, besides taking silver in the men's team event and bronze through HS Prannoy in men's singles.

The Indian men will be aiming to upgrade their silver to gold, while the women's side will be chasing a second team medal after winning bronze at Incheon in 2014.

India are expected to



progress against Bangladesh but could face Japan in the quarterfinals. A potential tie could see world No. 14 Lakshya Sen take on world No. 5 Kodai Naraoka, who won his second World Championships silver at the New Delhi event last month.

World No. 20 Ayush Shetty could face Swiss Open winner and world No. 18 Yushi Tanaka, while world No. 5 Satwik-Chirag, who won two titles at Singapore and China this season, could meet world No.

9 Takuro Hoki and Yugo Kobayashi.

Japan could prove a difficult opposition on slower courts, with Naraoka's retrieving ability and physical style posing a significant challenge, particularly with Lakshya coming into the tournament after a series of early exits. Lakshya remains India's highest-ranked men's singles player but has endured an inconsistent run since finishing runner-up at the All England Championships in

March. He suffered an early exit at the World Championships and lost in the opening round of the China Masters. India's side of the draw also includes China and Korea, meaning either could potentially await in the semi-finals. Malaysia, Indonesia, Thailand and Chinese Taipei are in the other half.

The Indian team has a lot of depth in singles, with Ayush emerging as another option after registering an upset win over world No. 1 Shi Yuqi at the World Championships. He has also beaten several leading players so far in his career but will need to produce consistently in a team format.

Third singles responsibility could fall on Kidambi Srikanth, who reached the final of the US Open and recently defeated Canada's Victor Lai. Prannoy, the 2023 Asian Games bronze medalist, also remains an important option for India despite a difficult recent season.

Missed Jaspal sir: Bhaker after Asian Games opening ceremony

ANKIT SHRESTHA ■ Nagoya

Olympic medalist Manu Bhaker on Saturday said she missed her late coach Jaspal Rana during the Asian Games opening ceremony, making an already special occasion an emotional one as she carried the Indian flag alongside kabaddi star Pawan Sehrawat.

"Missed Jaspal sir a lot today. It was indeed an emotional day without his presence by my side," Bhaker said after the ceremony here.

Rana, a celebrated shooter and coach, died on June 11 at the age of 49. He played a key role in Bhaker's career and guided her to two bronze medals at the 2024 Paris Olympics.

The 24-year-old shooter

had earlier recalled how Rana's influence had shaped her approach to opening ceremonies at multi-sport events. The legendary shooter-turned-coach had told once Bhaker that she could attend such ceremonies only if she was the flag-bearer, otherwise she should watch them on television, considering her competitions usually began soon after the opening ceremony.

Bhaker, who is competing in her third Asian Games, missed the opening ceremony at her first Games in 2018 as she was based in Palembang, away from the main athletes' village in Jakarta.

She later attended the 2018 Commonwealth Games ceremony and recalled Rana's advice to prioritise her competition.

Prannoy says Aichi-Nagoya likely his last Asian Games, keeps LA 2028 door open

ANKIT SHRESTHA ■ Nagoya

Veteran Indian shuttler H S Prannoy says the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games is most likely his last, but he will give himself another year to assess whether he has enough left to make a realistic bid for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

The 34-year-old, a bronze medalist at the last edition, is part of India's 20-member badminton squad for the 20th Asian Games, which begins with the team championships on Sunday. "This is probably my last Asian Games. I don't think I will be able to play at this level after four years. I only want to play at that level, not lower," Prannoy said.

Prannoy who competed at the Vietnam Open last week, said he was in good physical



and mental shape as he prepared for what could be his final appearance at the continental showpiece.

"I am in a good place physically and mentally. I played the Vietnam Open last week and had a decent run after some time," he said.

Prannoy, who was part of India's silver-medal winning team at the previous Asian Games in Hangzhou, said the

narrow miss would serve as motivation as the team targets gold in Nagoya.

"We missed gold by a whisker last time. Hopefully, we can reach the final and win gold this time," he said.

The former world No. 6, however, has not completely closed the door on another major assignment, with the Los Angeles Olympics still a possibility if he feels he can

remain competitive. "My aim is LA 2028. I will push for the next one to one-and-a-half years. If I feel there is a realistic chance of making it to LA, I will continue. Otherwise, I will decide later," he said.

Prannoy's preparations for the Paris Olympics were disrupted after he contracted chikungunya around 15 days before the Games.

The veteran also credited fellow senior shuttler Kidambi Srikanth with giving him the motivation to continue playing at the highest level, describing him as "probably the best men's singles player" India has produced. "Seeing him still play is encouraging and motivating. His results have given me confidence that if he can play, so can I," Prannoy said.

He added that Srikanth's

commitment to training, irrespective of outside opinions, was something younger players could learn from.

Doubles specialist Chirag Shetty has called on the Indian men's badminton team to go all out for gold at the Asian Games and "be raging tigers on the court" as it looks to improve on its silver-medal finish in Hangzhou. India had taken a 2-0 lead against China in the previous edition's final before losing 2-3, but Chirag said the team is ready for another shot at the top prize.

"We want to win a medal. Last time we won silver and we were so close to winning gold. We were leading 2-0 against China," Chirag said.

The Indian team has retained much of its core over the past few years, with several players having fea-

tured together at major team competitions.

"We have been playing together for quite some time now. We have had the Thomas Cup gold, Asian Games silver and the Thomas Cup bronze this year. We know each other well, so hopefully we can do well."

Chirag, who partners Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, said the team is not dwelling on the result at the previous edition. "It's a new tournament. Whatever happened last time is done and dusted. We have to go all out and be raging tigers on the court."

The Indian shuttler said competing at a multi-sport event carried a special significance, particularly because of the opportunity to represent the country and wear the national colours. (PTI)

Agarkar's exit: Rohit future fiasco, difference of opinion with Laxman

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

The drama surrounding the future of former skipper Rohit Sharma and the ever growing differences with Centre of Excellence head VVS Laxman became the main reasons for chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar and the BCCI to part ways ahead of the 2027 ODI World Cup.

Perhaps the straw that broke the camel's back was Agarkar not even remotely joining the all important review meeting in Mumbai to

discuss the England series debacle and the road ahead. BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia defended him but at one level, many in the board thought that Agarkar should have attended such an important meeting.

While he wasn't averse to continuing till end of ODI World Cup in South Africa, the BCCI over the last month dropped enough hints that they would be looking at a fresh face. Normally, the BCCI, wouldn't like to let go of someone whose panel picked squads that reached



four ICC white ball tournament finals in last three years, winning three trophies (two T20 WC title and one CT).

But then relation between Agarkar and the current BCCI regime turned frosty mainly due to couple of reasons.

It was just before the white ball series against England when the selection committee headed by now former chairman Ajit Agarkar in consonance with Indian team management and the key decision makers in the BCCI decided to move on from veteran opener Rohit Sharma

after the Lord's ODI. Accordingly a collective decision was taken and South Zone selector Pragyan Ojha, who happens to be one of Rohit's closest friends, was asked to "communicate" the decision to the two-time ICC Trophy winning former skipper. Rohit, who wants to play the 2027 ODI World Cup, wasn't exactly happy when the message was conveyed. He spoke to a very powerful administrator and expressed his misgivings about how he was being treated by the chairman of selectors. Those

who know Agarkar confirmed that when BCCI officially "issued" a statement backing Rohit and dismissing talks of his retirement post Lord's, he was left slighted and angry.

"That was perhaps the day when Ajit knew that it would be very difficult for him to continue. In fact, he had no inkling that a media statement was issued by the BCCI. He understood that going forward, the call on big names won't be his prerogative," a senior BCCI official privy to development said on conditions of anonymity. (PTI)

Asiad: Quimcy Dsouza loses in Teqball semis; to play for bronze next



AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

Quimcy Dsouza was within touching distance of the Asian Games final before the Indonesian comeback swept away her advantage, as the Indian went down to Sumaya in a gruelling three-game Teqball women's singles semifinal here on Saturday.

For a while, the lanky 24-year-old from Mumbai seemed to have the contest firmly in her hands. She took the opening game 12-7, exploiting the curved table brilliantly with sliding serves and a barrage of sharp diagonal smashes, her footwork and body feints virtually immaculate.

But Sumaya had another weapon — sepak takraw muscle memory — and the Indonesian used it to turn the match on its head, winning the next two games 9-12, 12-7. Quimcy's medal dream, however, remains alive. She will play the bronze-medal playoff with a chance to turn a painful semifinal defeat into a podium finish. Teqball is being played for the first time at Asian Games.

The defeat was particularly hard to swallow after the Indian — who had previously competed in state-level football and 1,500m running and was introduced to

Teqball after watching Brazilian football great Ronaldinho showcase his skills on Instagram — had made such a commanding start. Using her height to full effect, Quimcy repeatedly found the angles with her smashes, while her low, sliding serves from the curved table kept Sumaya under pressure. She raced through the opening game 12-7 with little sign of the fightback that was to come. The second game was a different story.

Sumaya stepped up the intensity and matched Quimcy point for point, gradually forcing the Indian into longer rallies and making her work harder for every point. Quimcy varied her serving — using her knee when close to the table and her foot from farther away — in an attempt to keep the Indonesian guessing.

At 3-3, she began finding success with diagonal smashes from the right side and a sequence of such winners helped her make it 6-6. A well-judged header followed, but Sumaya refused to relent.

At 9-9, two deft drop shots from the Indonesian put Quimcy under pressure. The Indian then sent a smash wide and Sumaya had levelled the match. (PTI)

India in transition but Australia would expect to face against strong team: Voges

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai

Former Australian batter Adam Voges expects India to field a strong Test team even without retired stalwarts Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, and foresees a tough battle in the five-match Border-Gavaskar Trophy early next year.

Neither Kohli nor Rohit will be a part of an Indian Test side for the first time in a decade when the hosts take on the Aussies from January 21 at Nagpur.

"Well, it's a changing of the guard as well isn't it, two absolute legends of the game who have just been the pillars of the Indian Test team for a long period of time, so there's a transition for the Indian team as well," Voges told PTI in an exclusive interaction at an event to announce a new partnership between Perth

Scorchers and the Roger Cook's Western Australia Govt. State of Energy campaign. But Voges was under no illusion about India's strength at home.

"There's some young exciting talent that's coming through and the thing that I've always seen every time I've come to India, is how much talent there is here. I know the Australian team will be expecting a very strong Indian team to come up against, and it's going to be a great challenge, so I'm sure we're looking forward to it," he added.

Voges believed Australia will have a staggered retirement plan for some of the "absolute legends" of the game that the team currently has.

"Australia learned a really good lesson when (Shane) Warne, (Glenn) McGrath and (Justin) Langer all retired at the same time, and it took a



little while to be able to rebuild from that," he said.

"So, I would imagine that there will be staged retirements for some of the absolute greats of Australian cricket, but equally those guys probably have the right to continue playing until they have decided that their time is up. "I would imagine that there will be some planning to stage those retirements so that we don't lose a whole heap of great players at the same time," Voges

said. Voges, who played 20 Tests, 31 ODIs and 7 T20Is for Australia, garnered most of his reputation as the batter to have the second best Test average — 61.87 — after Sir Donald Bradman at the time of his retirement.

The 46-year-old said Australia would have had a good run in Test cricket by the time they arrived in India for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy. "Australia has got so much Test cricket coming up, about to embark in a Test series in

South Africa, have New Zealand at home in Australia before we get to Border-Gavaskar Trophy," he said. "I don't think there's any secret that the Australian team is ageing and that there will be some transition at some stage, but I think in terms of new players, we see someone like Cooper Connolly, who is now in the Test squad in South Africa.

"He has got a skill set that could be really successful. We've seen him do well in the IPL, that's a skill set that could be really successful over here in Test cricket, so I'm certainly hoping Cooper is one of those, but Australia have got eight or nine Test matches before the Border-Gavaskar Trophy," Voges said. Voges admitted Australian batters, especially Marnus Labuschagne, will have to deliver more.

"There has been a lot of talk publicly about Marnus' posi-

tion in the team, he's on that tour to South Africa, and it's another opportunity for him, he would probably be the first to admit performance wise hasn't been where he would like it to have been over the last 12-24 months," Voges said. "He has got another opportunity as does the rest of the Australian top order to try and make an impression in South Africa. I know there's been a lot of talk about the Australian top order, but Australia's still winning games at Test cricket, and so you try and put that into context, but I'm sure all of them would love to have a bigger output over the next 12 months," he added.

Meanwhile, Voges hoped that Big Bash League contest in Chennai in December between Perth Scorchers and Melbourne Renegades will contribute to the long-lasting relationship between India and Australia. (PTI)

India face Bangladesh in Asian Games semifinal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nisshin (Japan)

Defending champions India will look to carry their dominant run against Bangladesh into the women's Asian Games semifinal here on Sunday.

The Women in Blue hardly broke a sweat as they began their title defence with a facile eight-wicket win over hosts Japan, chasing down the target with 15 overs to spare on Friday.

Bangladesh, on the other hand, advanced to the semifinal on the basis of their higher ICC ranking after their quarterfinal against China was abandoned due to a wet outfield.

India have dominated the



rivalry, winning their last nine meetings, including a 40-run victory over Bangladesh at the Asia Cup last week. Their last T20I defeat to Bangladesh came three years ago.

India made the most of a pitch offering turn and bounce against Japan, with

let-arm spinner Shree Charani carrying on her impressive run from the Asia Cup.

She was ably supported by part-timer Shafali Verma, seasoned all-rounder Deepti Sharma and Shreyanka Patil, who returned to action after a three-month injury layoff.

Opener Smriti Mandhana and skipper Harmanpreet Kaur did not bat against Japan, with Shafali single handedly overhauling the 58-run chase. The two senior batters are expected to return to the middle against Bangladesh, who will be banking on their spinners to put India under pressure.

Nahida Akter and Rabeya Khan will be key to Bangladesh's plans against an Indian batting unit. They will look to exploit any assistance from the surface and keep India's aggressive top order in check.

With a place in the final at stake, India will be wary of complacency despite their recent dominance over Bangladesh. (PTI)

Rachin in doubt for India T20Is after injury



New Zealand all-rounder Rachin Ravindra

FILE PHOTO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Auckland

New Zealand all-rounder Rachin Ravindra is a doubtful starter for the T20I series against India after dislocating his shoulder while attempting a diving catch during a promotional shoot earlier this week.

While medical assessments conducted on Friday found no major structural damage, Ravindra's return to competitive cricket will depend on how he responds during the initial stages of his rehabilitation. New Zealand will host India in a multi-format series beginning with five T20Is from October 22 to November 1. New Zealand Cricket said it was still "unclear" whether Ravindra would be available for the series. "It was a really unfortunate injury," Black Caps performance manager Mike Sandile was quoted as saying by Cricinfo.com.

"We're gutted for Rachin

and our key priority is making sure he recovers well and gets back on the field as soon as he can. As with all commercial shoots involving our players, the activities were agreed in advance by all parties, with appropriate safety measures in place.

"It was a bit of a freak accident, and we'll continue to review our processes around events like this in the future," he added.

New Zealand head coach Rob Walter also said the team would not rush Ravindra back given its demanding schedule.

"With a heavy schedule of Test cricket in the next six months, we don't want to rush Rachin back sooner than we need to," Walter said.

"He's in great hands in terms of his rehab and we look forward to welcoming him back soon."

Post the T20Is, the teams will then play five ODIs followed by two Tests, all in November. (PTI)

India begins TT campaign with atleast a medal in mind

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Nagoya

A confident Indian table tennis team, led by the men's doubles pair of Manush Shah and Manav Thakkar, begins its Asian Games campaign here on Sunday with a target of winning at least one medal.

The Indian men's team faces Indonesia in its first match of Group F against Indonesia and plays against Iran in its second match on Sunday. The women's team is also placed in Group F and starts its campaign against Indonesia before taking on Singapore in its second match of the day.

India had won an unexpected bronze in the last edition through the women's

doubles duo of Sutirtha Mukherjee and Ayhika Mukherjee.

The Manush-Manav pair is currently ranked third in the world, and with both of them in top form, they are the best bet for a medal in the continental mega event. The mixed doubles pair of Manush and Diya Chitale is also in good form and can go deep in the competition.

Syndrela Das' rapid rise has also added a mixed blend of youngsters and experienced players. The 17-year-old, currently at 99th in the ITTF women's singles' rankings, has been rewarded for her impressive form on the domestic circuit with a call-up to the senior side in the Asian Games. The other



members of the 10-member team — five male and five female — include the experienced G Sathiyam, Sreeja Akula, Y D Ghorpade, Sutirtha, Payas Jain and Harmeet Desai. Sathiyam is

the most experienced player in the team, and he has a bronze in the 2018 Asian Games men's team event and several medals in the Commonwealth Games.

The table tennis team

arrived here on September 16 and the players had got a bit accustomed to the conditions, particularly the tables and balls being used at the Asian Games. "This is my third Asian Games, and the

preparations have been really good. The whole team has been playing very well in the past one month. Yes, we are going a little early to get used to the weather over there. Our event starts from 20, so hopefully we try to do our best and try to take the medal home," Manav said.

Manush, meanwhile, said the pair would not be weighed down by expectations and would focus on maintaining the level they have shown over the past year. "Yeah, I mean expectations are high from me and Manav. We are one of the best in world right now. We will try to play our best, of course. The focus will be to take it step by step, match by match," he said. (PTI)

Hockey: India men eye fresh start after WC disappointment

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kakamigahara (Japan)



placed in Pool A alongside hosts Japan, Korea, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Indonesia, while Pool B consists of Pakistan, Malaysia, China, Oman, Uzbekistan and Thailand. India will open their campaign against Indonesia, a match which they are expected to win handsomely.

Being the highest ranked team in the competition at eighth, the Indian men are overwhelming favourites for the gold but to achieve that they will have to iron out the flaws which put paid to their World Cup hopes.

Since 2016, India has not lost to Pakistan in any competition, winning 14 of the last

16 meetings, including a 10-2 rout at the Hangzhou Asian Games and a 5-3 victory over their old rivals at this year's World Cup. The record against Japan (86 wins from 97 meetings) and Malaysia (89 from 127) also tells a story of historical dominance.

But it won't be easy as chief coach Craig Fulton's team's real test would be against Japan and Korea in the pool stages.

The Harmanpreet Singh-led side will look to draw on its experience from recent international experiences with an eye to make a fresh start in Japan.

Coach Fulton has already emphasised the importance of converting the lessons learnt from the World Cup

into action rather than dwelling on the result.

"These (World Cup outing) are lessons, and the only way to treat them as lessons learned is to turn that learning into action. That's what we've got to do now. We've discussed everything, gone through everything and highlighted areas needing improvement. At the same time, it's now about action," said Fulton.

For some of the Indian players, like veteran Manpreet Singh, skipper Harmanpreet, defender Amit Rohidas and striker Mandeep Singh it is likely to be their last Asian Games and they would be desperate to finish with another gold medal around their neck.

Men's cricket team dealing with clothing issue ahead of departure for Asian Games

BHARAT SHARMA
■ New Delhi

Members of the Indian men's cricket team are awaiting right size kits ahead of their departure for the Asian Games in the wee hours of Sunday.

PTI has learnt that there has been plenty of back and forth between BCCI and Indian Olympic Association's kit supplier JSW Inspire regarding the jersey of the players. The Shreyas Iyer led-side is scheduled to depart from the national capital early morning on Sunday.

India players will wear their standard kit for the one



off T20I against Japan on September 22 before donning the official Asian Games jersey for the competition beginning on September 28.

"There was a sizing issue in kits of cricketers, majority of them have been recti-

fied. There are a few left and they will be delivered to the team shortly. With players needing two different jerseys there (one for bilateral and another for Asian Games), this can happen," an IOA source said. (PTI)

SHEESH MAHAL

Quiet corner of history

Far away from Delhi's familiar landmarks, Sheesh Mahal quietly keeps a rich, layered piece of the city's old Mughal past, still waiting to be noticed

neglect nearly erased those memories completely until a coordinated rescue effort by the Lieutenant Governor, DDA, and ASI brought the ruins back to life.

The physical transformation of the Sheesh Mahal is remarkable. Standing inside the pavilion offers a direct look into Mughal elite life. Restorers rebuilt the solid red sandstone base and bright white plastered walls using period-accurate materials. Sturdy traditional stone brackets anchor the wide, overhanging eaves against the sky. Down the shaded corridors, the architecture shifts into a quiet rhythm of elegant scalloped arches resting heavily on deeply carved pillars. Sturdy iron grilles secure the historic doorways. Inside, traditional recessed niches break up the flat white plaster beautifully. The rooms connect through perfectly aligned archways, creating sweeping sightlines across the entire floor plan.

The main attraction sits right overhead. Original painters worked deep maroon and earthy green pigments directly into the vaulted ceilings. Those swirling flower shapes

somehow survived the elements. The artwork is flaking off in a few corners now, and that peeling paint really shows the true age of the structure. Liddle states the garden was laid out in the 17th century, possibly commissioned by Aizzabadi Begum as a walled formal space spanning three hundred yards square. The master builders understood the location perfectly.

The builders lined up the doorways perfectly to catch the evening wind, giving you a straight view out over the fresh Charbagh garden. Back then, a central water channel ran right through the middle, spilling over terraced pools. The real beauty of the Sheesh Mahal is the fact that it even exists today. There are no massive tourist groups to navigate around. Walking these halls feels like finding a piece of history left just for you, providing an authentic look into Delhi's royal heritage.

"The formal garden can be found today in the area known as Sheesh Mahal, though its dimensions are not what the historians of Shahjahan's time described. The original surrounding walls have disappeared, and the wall enclosing the space is a modern one."

- Swapna Liddle, author of *Gardens of Delhi*

HOW TO GET THERE

Catch the Yellow Line to the Haiderpur Badli Mor metro station. Once you step outside, grab a local auto or e-rickshaw for a quick ride straight to the gates.

Kathak's requiem for earth

Kathak master Shovana Narayan turns the stage into a striking, physical call to fix our broken planet and cultural heritage

TEAM VIVA

Nature possesses no voice to mourn its own ruin, leaving humanity to decipher the silent, staggering cost of a warming planet. To see Kathak Guru Shovana Narayan's latest work at Kamani Auditorium is to watch that climate crisis laid completely bare on stage. *In Fractured Harmonies: A Call for Renewal*, the Kathak master and her Asavari Repertory abandon safe, expected routines to confront the audience directly. Supported by ReNew, the show feels raw and immediate. Dressed all in white, the performers circle a dead tree set on the stage. Their heavy steps hit the floor with real force, standing out against the bold red and blue lights.

Narayan anchors the ensemble in textured, earthen fabrics, guiding the narrative through four acts of escalating crisis. It is a work that fiercely refuses the forced silence so often imposed upon heritage artists today, offering instead a deeply relevant critique of our modern decay. The choreography vividly renders the suffocation of plastic-laden oceans in 'Lament of the

Azure' before exposing the wider consequences of deforestation, including exploitation, inequality and the marginalisation of women, in 'Dishantar'.

Yet, the production avoids the trap of pure fatalism. As the narrative gazes upward in 'Echoes in the Void' to confront space debris, it reveals a poignant intersection: the survival of our natural ecosystems and the sustainability of traditional performing arts are inextricably linked. Physical and cultural heritage spaces are vanishing rapidly, yet here, the classical form reclaims its absolute authority. Concluding with a luminous vision of collective healing, the evening proved that classical masters possess not only the vocabulary to document our ruin but the vision to choreograph our survival.

BREAKING HER FORCED SILENCE, SHOVARA NARAYAN DANCES FIERCELY ON STAGE TO PROTEST AGAINST CLIMATE DECAY AND THE VANISHING OF CULTURAL HERITAGE SPACES

Seven hands, one faith

SEVEN ARTISTS TURN ANCIENT MEMORY INTO STONE, COLOUR, AND DEVOTION

TEAM VIVA

It is hard to find room for the sacred in a city that never stops moving. The noise usually drives it out. At Bikaner House, Kalakriti Art Gallery sets out to stop the city rush with its new group show, *Standing on Sacred Ground*. Instead of common religious icons, it asks a question: how do we keep the everyday moments that define our memories? As gallerist Rekha Lahoti notes, these works are designed to become part of our everyday lives rather than remaining distant objects. These works quietly ask us to make room for beauty and reflection in our daily routines.

Mayadhar Sahu anchors the physical space with *Ancient Steps-1*. Drawing on his memories of temples in Puri and Konark, he presents a profound meditation on the interdependent stones of Odia temple architecture. The dense gravity of his woodwork finds a delicate counterpoint in Keerti Pooja's *Things that remain*.

Goud's turquoise Krishna gazes out in metallic acrylic and ink, an old idea of divinity recast as bold, oversized sculpture

Through her gentle water-colour washes on wasli paper, she suspends fading everyday routines in a permanent state of visual grace. Further along the walls, the heavy bronze of Bolgum

Nagesh Goud's *Lord Rama* reimagines the flat dimensions of Telangana leather puppetry as robust contemporary sculpture. Providing a necessary visual breath, Sachin S Jaltare's acrylic canvases dissolve physical form entirely, pulling the observer into jewel-toned modulations of pure thought.

Bratin Khan weaves childhood rhythms into his *Memory series*, where lush Bengal landscapes merge flawlessly through masterfully layered tempera. Meanwhile, R Giridhara Gowd brings classical mural sensibilities into the present with *Surya Vandita Hanuman*, balancing dynamic energies in acrylic. Dhruvi Mahajan strips time down to its bare essence in her paper pinpricks, demanding deep contemplation.

The careful curation invites a slow, deliberate gaze. It offers no simple conclusions, leaving the viewer with the sense that ancient spirituality still breathes perfectly well here today.

ART CORNER

Glow over glam this festive season

TEAM VIVA

Anyone glancing at the beauty archives knows exactly what 2016 looked like. Getting ready meant burying real skin under thick foundation, a dark eye and a bold lip all at once. Today, that heavy approach is a massive misstep. Modern aesthetics desire a much lighter touch. While the celebratory calendar brings its usual rush of weighty silks and crowded parties, nailing the current look requires letting natural skin show through.

To master this effortless finish this festive season, Vaishnavi Jain, Beauty Expert and Head of Product Development at PAC Cosmetics, shares her insight: Well-balanced festive look is about looking polished and elevated without over-whelming the face. Choose one statement feature eyes, lips or glow and keep the rest refined. Start with a fresh, skin-like base using lightweight, buildable products. Add colour or shimmer gradually where needed to create a natural, dimensional finish. The key is selective intensity rather than drama everywhere.

STYLE BALANCE

Everyone knows perfectly balancing an outfit, statement jewellery, and makeup remains crucial. "Follow the one-focal-point rule. If the jewellery or outfit is making a statement, makeup should complement it. Choose either defined eyes or a bold lip. Coordinate through complementary tones; blush helps create a cohesive transition between skin, makeup and styling."

KEY FESTIVE BEAUTY AND MAKEUP TRENDS FOR 2026

This season, everyone's hunting for the freshest look — and beauty itself is shifting shape. She notes, "In 2026, festive makeup moves toward skin-first glam, focusing on healthy, radiant skin rather than a heavily covered base. Flushed cheeks and softer, diffused finishes are important. Expect statement eyes and modern metallics; metallic accents and softly blended shimmer add impact while keeping the look fresh."

MISTAKES

We all know long parties demand makeup that actually lasts. Jain notes, "One common mistake is overdoing every element at once; heavy base, strong eyes, bold lips feel overwhelming. Festive makeup needs a clear focus. Another mistake is overlooking skin preparation. Good prep, thin layers and strategic setting make a significant difference."

READING ROOM

THE FUTURE OF WORK

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

One discussion about AI never seems to stop: Will it take my job? The answer is mixed. Yes, it may, but it may also create new jobs. The irony is that the software engineers who built these systems have their own jobs on the line. That's the blunt premise: as much as 35 per cent of jobs could vanish over the next 15 years, with software development topping AI's hit list, followed by operations, customer support and knowledge-heavy fields such as law, investment banking and consulting. Nitin Seth's book, *AI in the Age of AI*, discusses this at length. In fact, it goes beyond this to explore the relationship between humans and AI. This became a heated discussion at a forum organised to discuss 'AI for Bharat' at the launch of the Hindi version of the book. Seth's response isn't alarm — it's reframing. "The AI age marks the end of the era of jobs," he says, "but, more importantly, the beginning of the era of entrepreneurship."

The survival mantra is simple: stop defending against AI and start building with it. In India, he argues, that matters more than any sovereign AI push — capital is no longer the constraint for young founders; technical and industry depth are. He is most optimistic about geography: AI, he says, could give someone in a small town the same opportunity as someone in a big city, without requiring an elite, English-medium education. Seth's bottom line is: "The future is not to be feared. The future is to be created. Replace fear with hope, and hope with action."

FOR SUGGESTIONS, FEEDBACK OR ADDITIONAL INFORMATION, PLEASE WRITE TO US AT FEATURES@DAILYPIONEER.COM

Although every possible care and caution has been taken to avoid errors or omissions, this publication is being sold on the condition and understanding that information given in this publication is merely for reference and must not be taken as having authority of or binding in any way on the writers, editors, publishers, and printers and sellers who do not owe any responsibility for any damage or loss to any person, a purchaser of this publication or not for the result of any action taken on the basis of this work. All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent court and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only. Readers are advised and requested to verify and seek appropriate advice to satisfy themselves about the veracity of any kind of advertisement before responding to any contents published in this newspaper. The printer, publisher, editor and any employee of the Pioneer Group will not be held responsible for any kind of claim made by the advertisers of the products & services and shall not be made responsible for any kind of loss, consequences and further product-related damages on such advertisements.

Printed and published by Kushan Mitra for and on behalf of CMYK Printech Ltd., Regd Office:- 201-205, 208-210, 2nd Floor, Pratap Bhawan 5, B.S.Z. Marg, New Delhi-110002 Phone: 011-46035729, and printed at The Indian Express Ltd., A-8, Sector 7, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) Noida-201 301, Ph: 01202470700. Managing Editor Vijay Prakash Singh, Executive Editor Deepak Kumar Jha. AIR SURCHARGE of ₹ 2.00 East: Calcutta, North: Leh West: Mumbai & Ahmedabad South: Bangalore & Chennai. Central : Khajuraho. Lucknow Office: 4th Floor, Sahara Shopping Centre, Faizabad Road, Lucknow-226 016. Phone:- 9415089265

The Pioneer AGENDA

Money cannot
buy peace of mind.
It cannot heal ruptured
relationships, or build
meaning into a life
that has none.
— Richard M DeVos

India's hugely successful UPI ecosystem is entering a new phase, with a framework that keeps person-to-person payments free while introducing capped charges on a small share of high-value merchant transactions. The move seeks to balance affordability with the long-term sustainability of digital payments — but it also raises an important question: who ultimately pays for keeping UPI free?



UPI is the cornerstone of India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) and the largest real-time payment platform globally. It accounts for nearly 49 per cent of all real-time digital payment volume globally.

UPI WHO PAYS?

Keeping UPI free and sustainable



SAURABH SANYAL

Every successful public utility eventually faces the same question: who pays to keep it running? For the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), run by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), the answer now carries a date. From October 15, a small Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), the fee a merchant pays to accept a digital payment, will apply to specified merchant payments above ₹2,000, ending more than six years of zero MDR.

UPI processed a record 24.51 billion transactions in August, about 791 million a day, worth ₹29.82 lakh crore. Zero MDR, in force since January 2020, helped it get there by making digital payments affordable for shoppers and shopkeepers alike. But zero MDR did not make costs disappear. Servers, fraud monitoring and rural connectivity must be paid for, and those costs rise with volumes. The Centre has offset part of the burden, providing ₹3,631 crore in incentives in 2023-24 under its scheme for RuPay debit cards and low-value UPI payments.

The Finance Ministry's framework, announced on September 15, should be read against that backdrop. All person-to-person transfers remain free, whatever the amount; they account for 70 per cent of UPI's transaction value. Merchant payments up to ₹2,000 stay free, as do payments to small merchants receiving up to ₹1 lakh a month through QR codes. Above ₹2,000, specified merchant transactions attract 0.4 per cent, capped at ₹300 for payments of ₹75,000 and above. Sectors such as railways, telecom, insurance, fuel and agricultural inputs pay a flat

₹5; capital-market payments pay 0.02 per cent, capped at ₹300. The government estimates that about 96 per cent of merchant transactions are untouched.

Does UPI's dominance concentrate too much power? Its position reflects acceptance, convenience and accessibility: people and businesses chose it. Concentration among apps is a fair concern: PhonePe and Google Pay handle roughly 80 per cent of volume, and NPCI's 30 per cent cap on any single third-party app's share is due for compliance by December 31, 2026. But the more pressing question is whether banks, fintechs and payment service providers have the financial strength to keep investing in technology and security as the network grows. A system that cannot recover part of its costs on its larger merchant payments will struggle to keep upgrading itself.

So who should pay? Not the consumer, and not the small shopkeeper: the charge falls on larger merchants for larger payments. MDR is not a tax, and neither the government nor NPCI collects it; it is shared among banks, payment providers and app providers. Banks have been advised to ensure merchants do not pass it on, and UPI apps are barred from levying platform fees. The rate is modest: a ₹10,000 payment costs the merchant ₹40, against as much as ₹90 at the debit-card ceiling for larger merchants and ₹150-250 at typical credit-card rates. Because of the cap, a ₹1 lakh payment costs ₹300, a third of what the debit-card ceiling would allow. Affordability survives where it matters most, and sustainability enters where it can be borne. Security is where the case for sustainability is strongest. At nearly 800 million payments a day, even a vanishingly small rate of fraud or failure touches a great many people. Fraud detection, cybersecurity and infrastructure need continuous investment, and revenue from larger merchant transactions gives the institutions

responsible a firmer base. Money alone is not enough: regulatory oversight, strong security standards and greater user awareness must grow with volumes, so that neither growth nor safety runs ahead of the other.

Should the government have reconsidered UPI's business model? In effect, it has, and with restraint. The framework keeps consumer welfare at the centre, shields street vendors and neighbourhood shops, and earmarks 5 per cent of MDR collections for a fund to bring more small merchants onto UPI. MPs, mostly from the Opposition, voiced concern over the levy at a Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance meeting on 16 September. Such scrutiny is welcome, and the framework's safeguards give the government a clear case to make.

UPI is no longer an experiment; it is national digital infrastructure, and infrastructure needs long-term financing. The government deserves credit for striking a calibrated balance rather than choosing between affordability and viability. What remains is delivery: enforcing the rule against passing charges on to customers, keeping apps free of hidden fees, investing revenue in security and reach, and making sure the small-merchant fund reaches the merchants it is meant for. If that happens, UPI's next chapter can be as inclusive as its first.

The writer is Secretary General ASSOCHAM



A major step for long-term payment viability



DR S P SHARMA

India's digital payments story has just reached another major milestone. The newly notified UPI framework delivers a clear win for the common citizen as UPI stays completely free for all person-to-person transactions and for 96 per cent of merchant transactions, while introducing a small, capped charge only on the highest-value merchant payments. This is a framework built to protect the many while strengthening the ecosystem for the future.

The new UPI framework has been introduced under the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, following detailed discussions by the UPI Steering Committee. It is a progressive, thoughtful and forward-looking step that supports both consumer interests and the long-term growth of India's digital payments ecosystem. It protects the interests of ordinary citizens while also supporting the long-term sustainability and growth of India's digital payments ecosystem.

The key message in this framework is simple: UPI will continue to remain completely free for individuals. Person-to-person (P2P) transactions, regardless of the amount, will continue without any transaction fee, platform fee or hidden charge. This covers around 70 per cent of the total value of transactions on UPI, ensuring that the core of India's digital payments system remains free and accessible to the common person.

There are also no monthly quotas, volume restrictions or tiered limits on free usage. The daily transaction limits set by banks and NPCI, ranging from ₹1 lakh to ₹5 lakh depending on the category, are meant as security measures and are not limits linked to charges.

Even for merchant payments, the framework goes out of its way to protect smaller transactions. Payments up to ₹2,000 to any merchant remain entirely free. Small merchants and street vendors receiving up to ₹1 lakh a month via UPI QR codes under the Person-to-Person-Merchant category continue to enjoy zero charges on all their transactions. Together, these provisions mean that roughly 96 per cent of all merchant transactions will see no impact whatsoever, shielding street vendors, neighbourhood shops and other small businesses from additional costs.

For the remaining 4 per cent of merchant transactions above ₹2,000, a nominal Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) of 0.4 per cent will apply. This will be capped at ₹300 for transactions of ₹75,000 and above. This is not a tax, and the money is neither collected by the government nor by NPCI. It is a small contribution that is shared among banks, payment app providers and other participants who support and maintain the UPI ecosystem.

Essential and low-margin sectors such as railways, telecom, insurance, fuel and agricultural inputs will also get special treatment. They will have a simple and predictable charge of just

₹5 per transaction to be paid by the merchant, helping businesses manage their costs better.

For capital-market transactions such as mutual funds, securities and stock-broking, an even lower rate of 0.02 per cent will apply, capped at ₹300. This will help support continued participation of retail investors in formal financial markets.

Importantly, it is a charge within the merchant ecosystem and not a charge on customers. Banks have been directed to ensure that merchants do not pass this cost on to customers.

UPI application providers are also not allowed to impose any platform fee or hidden charges. This ensures that consumers remain fully protected under the new framework.

One of the most encouraging features of the new framework is the creation of a dedicated fund to promote UPI adoption among small merchants. The fund, supported by an amount equivalent to 5 per cent of total MDR collections, will help more small businesses adopt and continue using UPI. It can further expand digital payments across rural and semi-urban areas, bringing more small businesses into the formal digital economy and strengthening financial inclusion. This is also in line with the recommendation of the Standing Committee on Finance in its 32nd Report, which highlighted the need for a sustainable revenue model.

Overall, the framework takes a balanced and forward-looking approach by protecting individuals and small merchants while giving UPI the financial sustainability it needs to grow, innovate and expand its reach. It is a framework truly built to further strengthen India's digital payments ecosystem and contribute to the vision of a Viksit Bharat.

Dr S P Sharma is a distinguished economist, policy strategist and thought leader with nearly three decades of experience across government and apex industry institutions

The Exponential growth of Unified Payments Interface

APRIL 2009: NPCI is established by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Indian Banks' Association (IBA).
NOVEMBER 2010: NPCI launches the Immediate Payment Service (IMPS).
2014-2015: The government introduces the JAM Trinity (Jan Dhan accounts, Aadhaar, and Mobile connectivity), establishing the essential digital identity layer required to scale retail fintech.
11 APRIL 2016: The pilot phase of UPI is officially launched by the then RBI Governor, Dr. Raghuram Rajan, in Mumbai with 21 participating banks.
25 AUGUST 2016: Banks begin uploading UPI-enabled

apps onto public application stores, officially opening the interface to retail customers.
30 DECEMBER 2016: Prime Minister Narendra Modi launches the government's dedicated BHIM App (Bharat Interface for Money) to foster digital payments.
LATE 2016-2017: India's demonetisation move and the entry of cheap telecom mobile data trigger a massive surge in peer-to-peer (P2P) transfers.
2018: NPCI launches UPI 2.0, introducing advanced capabilities such as overdraft account linking, one-time mandates, invoice-in-inbox features, and QR codes.
2019: The widespread rollout of interoperable QR codes

by platforms like Google Pay, PhonePe, and Paytm.
OCTOBER 2019: UPI crosses the milestone of 1 billion transactions in a single month.
JANUARY 2020: The government introduces the Zero MDR (Merchant Discount Rate) policy, waiving transaction fees for merchants and triggering a massive surge in retail adoption.
2020-2021: NPCI launches UPI AutoPay to streamline recurring e-mandates for subscriptions, utility bills, and EMIs.
MARCH 2022: UPI 123PAY is introduced to enable voice-based and offline transactions.

SEPTEMBER 2022: UPI Lite is launched, allowing users to make lightning-fast, PIN-less on-device wallet transactions for small amounts under ₹500.
2023: RBI permits the integration of RuPay Credit Cards
2024: NPCI International Payments Ltd (NIP) partners with cross-border frameworks
MID-2026: Features like UPI Circle (delegated payment limits for family members) and Aadhaar-based face authentication roll out to prevent fraud.
AUGUST 2026: UPI completes 10 years of public functioning. The network records an incredible 13,000-fold expansion since its inception.

The imposition of a UPI transaction fee: How far is it justified?

The country's payment regulatory body, the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), has recently introduced a 0.4 per cent Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI (Unified Payments Interface) transactions above ₹2,000, effective October 15, 2026. Under this change, transactions up to Rs 2,000 are completely free for both customers and merchants.

Therefore, person-to-person (P2P) transactions remain completely free. However, merchant payments above ₹2,000 shall be subject to a 0.4 per cent MDR, which is capped at ₹300 for transactions above ₹75,000. Three spe-



ATUL SEHGAL

cific services — fuel, rail and telecom — attract a flat transaction fee of ₹5.

The matter has hogged the limelight and generated controversy for quite the right reasons.

UPI commands a share of 84 per cent

in India's digital payments by volume and a 49 per cent share of global real-time payment volumes, as per government figures. These are big numbers. PhonePe, acquired by Walmart, and Google Pay, owned by Alphabet, had approximately 80 per cent market share by value in UPI transactions in August 2026. Therefore, the change is loaded with wide ramifications.

The following observations are clearly borne out by an analytical study of the matter.

There is no free lunch on earth. Every value-carrying item of goods and services carries a cost. Hence, to expect and keep harping on the continued

availability of a free UPI payment system for all is not fair.

The issue has attracted controversy because it is logical to see that the hidden digital fee could, in the course of time, hurt savings and burden common citizens. Although the ruling of NPCI retains free P2P transactions and common persons shall remain exempt from transaction fees even on items of important day-to-day requirements — fuel, rail and telecom — it is unlikely that the merchants will not surreptitiously pass on this burden to the common man. This cannot occur legally but could occur through itemised increases in costs of inputs for

the goods or services in question.

Since the proceeds of the transaction fee levied on merchants will go to banks and fintech companies and app owners which facilitate these payments, it will increase their bottom line and make the UPI owners self-sustainable.

This will understandably boost microfinancing business in rural and semi-urban areas, thus helping to enhance economic growth. This will particularly give a fillip to the growth of the MSME sector, beset by stagnation over the last many years.

Concern has also been expressed on social media that this change could prompt merchants to prefer cash pay-

ments. Yes, there will be nothing to stop them from doing it. This could generate more black money, which has already increased to significant levels following a decline upon demonetisation of high-denomination currency notes in 2016. This would fall upon the GST as well as Income Tax collections of the government. But the government machinery will have to show its efficiency in tax collection.

We may also look at how fintech companies like PhonePe or Paytm have been surviving thus far. PhonePe's net losses widened from ₹1,727 crore in FY 2024-25 to ₹2,791 crore in FY 2025-26.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

"IN ASIA, PERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS ARE IMPORTANT,
BUT YOU CANNOT PERSONALISE DIPLOMACY"
— ANANDA KRISHNAN

BRICS: The long arc of Indian diplomacy



MD AFSHAR ALAM

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi rose to When Prime Minister Narendra Modi rose to close the 18th BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on September 13, the applause in the hall carried a meaning larger than protocol. India had done what few expected of a grouping this large and this divided. Eleven member states, spanning continents and clashing interests, had put their names to a 140-point declaration. The New Delhi Declaration was adopted by consensus, and that word carried the weight of the entire summit.

For anyone who has watched India's diplomatic evolution over the past decade, the moment was instructive. It told a story about method as much as outcome, about patience as much as power. The summit brought together Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the UAE, a bloc that now speaks for close to half of humanity and roughly two-fifths of world output. Holding such a coalition together long enough to agree on anything is difficult. Getting it to agree on West Asia, terrorism, trade and the reform of global institutions, all in one document, was a genuine achievement of chairmanship.

Consensus amidst division

The hardest test of the summit lay in the geopolitics of the moment. Sharp differences ran through the membership on the conflict in West Asia, and the days before the leaders met were filled with intensive negotiations. That the declaration emerged unanimously, with no member registering an objection, was described in New Delhi as a diplomatic breakthrough. The text called for a ceasefire in Gaza, backed Palestinian statehood and full UN membership, and expressed concern over attacks on civilian and nuclear infrastructure, all while avoiding the naming of individual states on the most contentious questions. This restraint is worth pausing on. Indian diplomacy under Modi has increasingly favoured a language of moderation that keeps channels open with rivals rather than forcing a choice between camps. The declaration also carried a condemnation of the Pahalgam terror attack and a broader call for stronger international cooperation against terrorism. For India, embedding that concern into a BRICS consensus document was a quiet but pointed win, one that folded a national security priority into a multilateral position endorsed by states that do not always see the issue the same way.

From files to real-life impact

Modi's own framing at the summit was characteristically practical. He told the assembled leaders it was time to move from files to real-life impact, warning that rising geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions and climate stress were pressing hardest on ordinary people across the developing world. He cautioned against what he called the weaponisation of technology and critical minerals, a phrase aimed squarely at the anxieties of smaller economies that fear being squeezed in a contest between larger powers. The substance behind the rhetoric was considerable. India's year-long chairship produced more than fifty concrete outcomes, from action plans to institutional mechanisms, built through more than four hundred meetings and engagements held across some thirty Indian cities. Modi outlined four fresh initiatives during the leaders' session. He proposed a BRICS Troika mechanism to give the grouping continuity between summits. He called for a roadmap on global governance reform to make the international order more representative. He floated a seafarer emergency support network to help crews in distress. And he pushed a Global South negotiation support scheme to train officials and young professionals from developing countries in technology and rule-making, areas where they are too often absent from the table.

India also set up a Centre for BRICS Industrial Competencies, intended to help manufacturing firms and small and medium enterprises adopt advanced digital technologies and the tools of Industry 4.0. Taken together, these are not grand gestures. They are the plumbing of cooperation, the kind of unglamorous machinery that determines whether a bloc actually delivers for its members or lapses into ceremony.

— FROM AGENDA COVER —

The UPI transaction...

It was established in 2015. But the company is surviving and subsisting on big Financer and Investor Funds buying into its equity. These businesses run on a discount based, revenue driven model of growth followed by a public issue of equity shares (IPO) which in a buoyant share market gives the Investors and Promoters a grand opportunity to liquidate their holdings with profits, leaving the small equity holders in the lurch to suffer losses due to the inevitable crash of the share value of Fintech companies. The IPO of PhonePe has not yet come but the chain of events before and after the IPO of another Fintech company Paytm has shown exactly the above as borne out by the following factual details.

Paytm incurred a net loss of ₹663 crores in 2024-25 and swung into net profit of ₹552 crores in 2025-26. But over the 10 years of its operation, it suffered a cumulative loss of about ₹15000 crores. Driven by severe regulatory crackdown by RBI in 2024, the Company's stock price plummeted by more than 70 percent thus causing a huge loss to shareholders. The recent change will serve to discourage the above type of activities. Thus, in the final analysis, we could say that the NPCI notification is fundamentally fair and in the larger national interest provided the government takes action as appropriate to check evasion of direct and indirect taxes due to likely increase of cash payments in the country's economy after the notification takes effect.

The author is a management consultant and policy analyst

IRCTC DELHI OFFICE
Launches Exclusive Religious Tour of
SRILANKA

SCAN • EXPLORE • BOOK
NDO37 Tour Package



Scan/visit

https://www.irctctourism.com/package_description?packageCode=NDO37



acteristically practical. He told the assembled leaders it was time to move from files to real-life impact, warning that rising geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions and climate stress were pressing hardest on ordinary people across the developing world. He cautioned against what he called the weaponisation of technology and critical minerals, a phrase aimed squarely at the anxieties of smaller economies that fear being squeezed in a contest between larger powers. The substance behind the rhetoric was considerable. India's year-long chairship produced more than fifty concrete outcomes, from action plans to institutional mechanisms, built through more than four hundred meetings and engagements held across some thirty Indian cities. Modi outlined four fresh initiatives during the leaders' session. He proposed a BRICS Troika mechanism to give the grouping continuity between summits. He called for a roadmap on global governance reform to make the international order more representative. He floated a seafarer emergency support network to help crews in distress. And he pushed a Global South negotiation support scheme to train officials and young professionals from developing countries in technology and rule-making, areas where they are too often absent from the table.

India also set up a Centre for BRICS Industrial Competencies, intended to help manufacturing firms and small and medium enterprises adopt advanced digital technologies and the tools of Industry 4.0. Taken together, these are not grand gestures. They are the plumbing of cooperation, the kind of unglamorous machinery that determines whether a bloc actually delivers for its members or lapses into ceremony.

It is worth recalling how far this represents a shift in temperament. For much of its history, India approached multilateral summits with a certain wariness, protective of its autonomy and sceptical of entanglements. The BRICS chairship showed a different India, one willing to invest political capital in building shared institutions and to spend a full year in the granular work of negotiation. The theme India chose for its presidency, building for resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability, was not decoration. It described a way of working, and the summit's output suggests the description held.

The reform agenda

Running through the declaration was a theme India has pressed for years: that the institutions built after the Second World War no longer reflect the world as it is. The document called for reforms to make the international system more just, equitable, representative and accountable. It reiterated support for reform of the United Nations and of the international financial architecture, and it pointedly referenced UN Security Council reform alongside the candidature of India and other BRICS members.

This is the consistent line of Indian foreign policy. New Delhi has argued that a Security Council frozen in 1945 cannot claim legitimacy in 2026, and that a global economy in which developing nations generate a growing share of growth cannot be governed by voting weights fixed decades ago. The declaration's insistence on shareholding realignment in international financial institutions, correcting the historic underrepresentation of developing countries, is the economic expression of that same conviction. India did not invent these demands at this summit, but it used its chairship to write them firmly into the record of a bloc that carries real heft.

The question of balance

Economic cooperation ran as a steady current beneath the political headlines. Member states criticised unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures, warning that protectionism threatens global trade and supply chains. The declaration reaffirmed support for reform of the World Trade Organisation and for a rules-based multilateral trading system that protects special and differential treatment for developing members.

The numbers give the argument its force. Speaking at the business forum on the eve of the leaders' session, Russian President Vladimir Putin noted that BRICS had accounted for more than forty per cent of global output over the preceding five years, against about twenty-nine per cent for the G7, and had generated close to half of global economic growth. Whatever one makes of the

framing, the underlying shift is real. The centre of economic gravity has moved, and a grouping that speaks for that shift can no longer be waved away as a talking shop. India, as this year's host, stood at the head of that argument.

Yet India's handling of the technology and governance questions revealed the balance it has tried to strike. The declaration engaged de-dollarisation and financial autonomy without allowing the summit to harden into an anti-Western front. India's presidency worked to keep the grouping cohesive and development-oriented rather than letting it become a polarised bloc. That is a deliberate posture. India trades and talks with the West even as it builds alternatives with the South, and it has resisted every attempt to force BRICS into a purely oppositional identity. The New Delhi Declaration bears the mark of that discipline.

A health and heritage dimension

One outcome drew notice beyond the usual circles of trade and security. The declaration gave its strongest endorsement yet to traditional, complementary and integrative medicine, dedicating a full paragraph to it. For a country that has long sought international recognition for its systems of traditional medicine, the acknowledgement inside a BRICS leaders' statement was a meaningful marker. It reflected a broader Indian effort to bring questions of health cooperation, and of civilisational knowledge, into the mainstream of multilateral conversation rather than leaving them at the margins.

The larger meaning

What, then, does the summit tell us about Indian diplomacy at this juncture? First, that India has grown comfortable as a convener. Hosting a fractious grouping and steering it to consensus is a different skill from advocacy, and New Delhi displayed it with some assurance. Second, that India has settled on a distinctive voice, one that speaks for the Global South without renouncing its partnerships elsewhere.

There is reason for caution too, and honesty demands stating it. Declarations are easier to draft than to implement, and Modi's own appeal to convert commitments into impact was an implicit acknowledgement that BRICS has often promised more than it has delivered. The value of the New Delhi Summit will ultimately be measured by whether the fifty-odd outcomes take root, whether the payment systems function, whether the reform demands gain traction in the institutions they target. Still, judged against the moment, India's chairship stands as a serious diplomatic accomplishment. It produced consensus amid division, folded national priorities into a shared text, and pushed the reform of a global order that no longer fits its own century. For a country that once occupied the outer edge of these conversations, hosting eleven leaders in New Delhi and sending them home with a signed declaration is a statement of arrival. The applause at Bharat Mandapam was earned.

The writer is former Vice Chancellor of Jamia Hamdard, New Delhi

Exploring the role of Parliament in the making of India's foreign policy

SANTHANAM PRABHAKAR

In this well-researched book, veteran journalist KV Prasad focuses on the initiatives of the Indian Parliament. It is not merely a rumination on the author's vast exposure and long journalistic journey; he painstakingly brings out how the apex legislative body played a prominent role in the framing and reinforcing of the foreign policy of the country since 1947.

It offers deep insights into the vast arena of foreign policy, tracing the role of Parliament. Indeed, the book provides a rigorous account of how successive governments and prime ministers navigated challenging times within Parliament.

The introduction delineates succinctly the devices available to the Members and the parliamentary processes involved in shaping foreign policy and the elaborate committees set up. It provides a clear picture of what readers can expect from the book.

Written in a perceptive way about how the executive plays a decisive role in foreign policy as provisioned by the Constitution, the author's stress on the 'minimalist' role of Parliament is elaborated. This leitmotif is a recurring theme in the book.

It demonstrates the evolution of debates and how MPs were taken into confidence by the executive, and the book traces the origins of foreign policy to 1921. It explains how Jawaharlal Nehru played a prominent part in steering foreign policy and building consensus in Parliament until his death in 1964. He brought out a rather difficult debate, explained in a candid and simple way, and observed: "Nehru injected a level of transparency, a much-required trait in democracy."

The book deals with three specific debates: IPKF in Sri Lanka, the World Trade Organisation, and the India-United States Civilian Nuclear Deal. It underscored how, during 1991 and 2003, Parliament, through its unanimous resolutions during the Gulf War, asserted itself and called for a peace-



ful resolution to the conflict, expressed India's non-aligned position, and reflected India's refusal to join the US-led coalition against Iraq later.

In the backdrop of domestic politics, opposition and the perspective of the Left parties, the book decodes parliamentary debates for the reader and explains how the governments of the day succeeded. The book explores how, on different occasions, the Indian Parliament played a significant role and how the government of the day handled opposition from states and how states prevailed upon the Centre to safeguard its terrain.

Offering a deep dive into the nuclear debate, the book tracks the evolution of the nuclear policy since 1948, facing 'nuclear apartheid' from 1974, 'Pokhran-II' in 1998 and how it culminated under the UPA government. In the chapter on Civil Nuclear Cooperation, Prasad reminisces on the role of Parliament and the debates that shook the government of the day. He surmises aptly that the "India-US Civil Nuclear Cooperation" remains a watershed moment in the country's quest for nuclear energy.

The author breaks down some of the most complex Government-Opposition battles fought in Parliament during the coalition era in an effective way, with a free-flowing exposition of ideas and views and how governments manoeuvred foreign policy in difficult times.

Prasad's book provides an authoritative account and a ringside view of what transpired in Parliament. He brings a fresh perspective on the subject, explains unequivocally the policy parameters and how the government faced the pulls and pressures from the opposition. This is one of the reasons why this book stands apart.

The content in each chapter is richly and meticulously crafted and written in a lucid manner. The author dealt with the subject with scrupulous honesty and abounds with references to debates and tactics deployed by both the government and opposition in Parliament.

A comprehensive and valuable guide to engage and educate scholars in international relations to know how important and complex matters are dealt with by the Indian Parliament. It is a masterly exploration of the impact of Parliament on foreign policy.

The big takeaway from this book is the diligent record of how, with its limited role, the Indian Parliament reinforces itself in every conceivable way and perspective in the framing of foreign policy. Overall, the book is outstanding.

The book reviewer is a former Joint Director, Lok Sabha, and Delhi-based researcher and scholar

DAIV ASTRO

Ancient Wisdom. Timeless Guidance.
<https://daiv.co>

This Week's Zodiac Insights

Profession • Money • Family • Relationships • Health • Travel



Mesha | Aries: The week ahead brings movement in pending tasks, and your communication can draw positive attention. Greater responsibility may come at work, while support at home remains steady. Expenses could rise despite otherwise positive progress, so keep priorities clear and avoid stretching yourself too thin. **Watch out for:** Delays, overspending and lack of rest.



Vrishabha | Taurus: As the week unfolds, business and money matters look encouraging, with new agreements or unexpected gains possible. Your ideas may earn respect, but close relationships could feel unusually distant. Friends remain helpful, while an elder in the family may need greater care. **Watch out for:** Emotional withdrawal, digestive discomfort and unnecessary worry.



Mithuna | Gemini: The early part of the week may feel demanding, but confidence improves as things begin turning in your favour. Strong communication can support career growth, while disciplined spending helps rebuild financial stability. Family matters, especially around children, need more patience and attention. **Watch out for:** Overwork, family tension and irregular eating habits.



Karka | Cancer: During the week, a cheerful mood helps you stay engaged even when results take time. Your communication can make a strong impression, and business matters may show growth, but ready cash could remain tight. Family and friends bring useful perspective during personal uncertainty. **Watch out for:** Borrowing pressure, joint discomfort and difficult choices.



Simha | Leo: This week favours partnership work and negotiations, especially in business, where gains may improve your confidence. Professional matters look positive, but personal relationships may suffer if arguments continue. Family demands could feel heavy, though friends remain dependable when support is needed. **Watch out for:** Unnecessary disputes, overspending and acidity or digestive irritation.



Kanya | Virgo: The week gives you space to reassess priorities and seek the recognition you deserve. Partnership ventures and extra income prospects look encouraging, while marital understanding can improve after earlier strain. Old contacts may also return with support, and healthier routines bring relief. **Watch out for:** Excessive travel spending and slipping into unhealthy habits.



Tula | Libra: As the week progresses, early pressure can gradually turn into progress if you stay flexible. Workload may rise when team support is limited, while careful spending helps strengthen savings. Personal relationships and family respect can improve through mature communication and responsible choices. **Watch out for:** Rigidity, mental strain and unusual physical symptoms.



Vrishchika | Scorpio: Over the course of the week, incomplete work can finally move towards completion, even if progress remains slow. Business and income prospects improve, with stalled financial matters showing movement again. Personal relationships may need quicker decisions, while differences at home call for patience. **Watch out for:** Indecision, physical strain and avoidable disagreements.



Dhanu | Sagittarius: The coming week may bring professional recognition through a long-awaited promotion or appreciation from seniors. Financial matters need caution, especially where borrowing or dependence on others is involved. Unresolved issues in marriage or family should be addressed directly before they deepen. **Watch out for:** Money pressure, relationship strain and breathing-related discomfort.



Makara | Capricorn: This week can help long-pending plans move ahead, especially an event or project you have prepared for. Finances may remain uneven, but support from family and friends helps you stay steady. Relationships benefit from thoughtful communication and greater openness. **Watch out for:** Delayed income, self-doubt and neck or shoulder strain.



Kumbha | Aquarius: In the week ahead, interviews, examinations and professional discussions can go in your favour as your ideas gain importance. Partnership business and past investments may bring encouraging returns, while your influence within the family grows. Be selective about whom you trust. **Watch out for:** Relationship misunderstandings, false friends and financial overconfidence.



Meena | Pisces: The week may not unfold as planned, making patience essential in work and personal matters. Finances need tighter control, especially around credit or lending, while property issues should be handled calmly. Important documents and health concerns also need closer attention. **Watch out for:** Hasty decisions, careless lending and ignoring persistent symptoms.



Scan to Download
DAIV App

धर्मो रक्षति रक्षितः

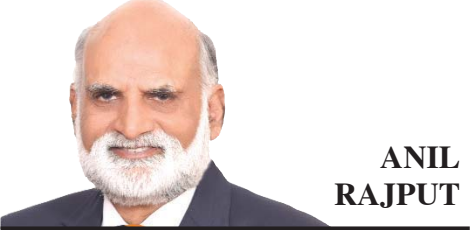
A platform for spiritual seekers from across the globe

Download on the
App Store

GET IT ON
Google Play

“CIVILISATION AS IT IS KNOWN TODAY COULD NOT HAVE EVOLVED, NOR CAN IT SURVIVE, WITHOUT AN ADEQUATE FOOD SUPPLY”
— NORMAN BORLAUG

Mahalakshmi vrat: Food, faith and the sacred sixteen



ANIL
RAJPUT

What does prosperity taste like after days of fasting? Mahalakshmi Vrat answers that question not with one signature dish, but through a sequence of foods that moves from simple phalahaar to carefully prepared offerings and, finally, to a concluding meal shaped by the number sixteen. In 2026, the vrat begins on Saturday, 19 September, on Bhadrapada Shukla Ashtami, and concludes on Saturday, 3 October, on Ashwin Krishna Ashtami. Though conventionally known as a sixteen-day vrat, the lunar sequence gives 15 fasting days this year because the observance follows tithis rather than a simple count of calendar dates.

The vrat is observed particularly across North India, including Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Delhi, and is dedicated to Mahalakshmi as the giver of fortune, wellbeing and household prosperity. Its ritual world is filled with the number sixteen. Devotees may prepare a sacred thread with sixteen knots, offer objects in groups of sixteen, light lamps and complete the worship with a formal udyapan. The number is not decorative. It gives rhythm to the vow and, in several household traditions, enters the kitchen itself. The concluding food is therefore not merely a festive meal after fasting. It is part of the ritual grammar of the observance.

The stories attached to the vrat vary across regions and family traditions. Some vrat-kathas speak of kings and queens who receive Mahalakshmi's grace through devotion, while another widely circulated tradition links the worship with Kunti, Gandhari, Arjuna and Airavata, the celestial elephant. This helps explain the prominence of Gajalakshmi imagery and the custom in some homes of worshipping a clay elephant. Such narratives have often been transmitted orally, through women's gatherings and household recitation, so the festival's history survives not only in texts but also in repeated practice. Food is part of that transmission because each stage of the vrat carries its own rules about what may be eaten, what should be offered and how the fast is completed.

During the fasting period, there is no single menu followed by every household. Some devotees take only fruit and milk, others eat one phalahari meal, while stricter observance may avoid ordinary grains and salt altogether. This variation makes it important to separate the foods that are specifically tied to Mahalakshmi worship from the wider North Indian vrat repertoire that supports the devotee through the days of fasting. The most distinctive foods appear at the conclusion, where one old custom calls for eighteen sweet puris made from eighteen handfuls of wheat flour. Sixteen are placed beneath a flour lamp and two are offered to Mahalakshmi, after which the sixteen are eaten within the family. The symbolism turns an everyday ingredient into a ritual count.

These meethi puris are far more than ordinary fried bread. The dough is lightly sweetened, rolled into small discs and fried in ghee or oil until puffed and golden. In the associated custom, they are eaten with seviyan kheer or meetha dahi, creating a combination that is unusual enough to give Mahalakshmi Vrat a culinary identity of its own. The seviyan are roasted before being simmered in milk with sugar and cardamom until



soft, while sweet curd is whisked until smooth and gently sweetened. The contrast between crisp puri, creamy vermicelli and cool curd creates a concluding plate built as much around ritual meaning as taste.

Milk sweets also hold an important place in the worship. Several Mahalakshmi traditions specify white barfi as prasad, its pale colour making it visually distinct from darker jaggery sweets. It may be made by reducing milk or khoya with sugar until the mixture can be set and cut into squares. In other homes, a simpler mawa prasad is prepared by lightly roasting khoya in ghee, sweetening it and perfuming it with cardamom. Kheer remains another recognised offering, but rather than treating it as the centre of the article, it is better understood as one part of a larger ritual spread. Rice or another permitted ingredient is cooked slowly in milk until the liquid thickens, giving the bhog the soft, spoonable texture traditionally associated with auspicious occasions.

The same milk base can be adapted for sabudana kheer, a preparation specifically mentioned in Mahalakshmi bhog traditions. Soaked tapioca pearls are simmered until translucent, then cooked in milk with sugar, cardamom and nuts. Their soft, pearly texture distinguishes the dish from ordinary rice kheer and also makes it suitable for households avoiding grain during the fast. Singhara barfi works from a different vrat ingredient. Water chestnut flour is roasted gently in ghee, cooked with milk or water and sugar, then spread and cut once firm. The familiar flour of fasting food is thus transformed into a sweet

that looks at home on a ceremonial platter.

Coconut provides another route to sweetness through nariyal laddoo, now widely prepared as Mahalakshmi bhog. Fresh coconut is cooked with milk and sugar until the mixture thickens enough to shape, then finished with cardamom and dry fruits. Kesar bhaat offers a contrasting grain-based preparation for the concluding meal, where family practice permits ordinary rice after the fast. Rice is cooked so the grains remain separate, then sweetened and scented with saffron and cardamom, sometimes with raisins or nuts folded through it. Alongside these cooked sweets, batasha, makhana, kishmish and pieces of fresh coconut are also used as offerings in Mahalakshmi worship, reminding us that prasad need not always emerge from an elaborate recipe.

The savoury side of the vrat kitchen is equally varied, although it belongs more to the wider fasting tradition of the regions concerned than to one compulsory Mahalakshmi menu. Kuttu ke pakore have a particularly strong claim here because they are specifically mentioned among foods offered during Mahalakshmi worship. Buckwheat flour is mixed with pieces of permitted vegetables, cumin, green chilli and

rock salt before being fried until crisp. The same flour can be steamed rather than fried as kuttu dhokla, where a lightly aerated batter is cooked until soft and cut into squares. The change in technique is important, allowing the same fasting ingredients to produce two

entirely different textures.

Water chestnut flour expands the savoury range further. Singhare ki puri is kneaded with boiled potato or another binder, rolled carefully because the dough lacks gluten, and fried until lightly crisp. Kuttu ki puri follows a similar method but has a deeper, earthier flavour from buckwheat. Rajgira puri, prepared from amaranth flour, brings yet another grain substitute into the North Indian fasting pantry. Because these flours behave differently from wheat, they demand experience. The doughs crack more easily, require careful moisture and are often rolled between sheets or pressed by hand. Their presence shows that vrat cooking has developed its own body of practical knowledge rather than simply subtracting ordinary grains from a normal meal.

Vegetables add further variety without falling back on the usual potato-centred fasting plate. Kacche kele ki tikki uses boiled raw banana mashed with cumin, green chilli and rock salt, shaped into patties and shallow-fried until browned on both sides. Lauki raita takes the opposite approach, combining cooked grated bottle gourd with chilled curd, roasted cumin and rock salt for a soft, cooling accompaniment. A kheera-aloo salad, documented in contemporary Mahalakshmi fasting menus, can be kept light by combining cucumber with small amounts of boiled potato, lemon and cumin rather than turning it into another heavy potato dish. Bhuni shakarkandi, roasted sweet potato seasoned only after cooking, adds natural sweetness and a faint smoky edge to the plate.

Makhana can also move beyond its familiar use in kheer. Ghee-roasted makhana, tossed lightly with cumin or rock salt where permitted, provides a crisp snack during the fasting period and carries an additional connection to Mahalakshmi because fox nuts are themselves offered in her worship. Singhara, whether eaten fresh when available or used through its flour, similarly occu-

pies both ritual and culinary space. Seasonal fruit phalahaar may bring together banana, guava, apple, pomegranate and grapes, while a panchmeva mixture of almonds, cashews, walnuts, raisins and other dry fruits provides another compact offering. Rather than treating fruit and nuts as culinary afterthoughts, the vrat places them at the centre of a food system shaped by season, simplicity and permitted ingredients.

There are also preparations that sit between sweet and savoury. Singhare ka halwa roasts water chestnut flour in ghee before cooking it with milk or water and sugar, giving it a dense, almost pudding-like body. Makhana panjiri, where household practice allows it, can combine roasted and crushed fox nuts with ghee, coconut, nuts and sugar to produce a dry prasad with far more texture than kheer. A simple dahi-makhana bowl may instead fold roasted fox nuts into curd with cumin and rock salt, allowing the ingredient to serve as part of the fasting meal rather than only as an offering. None of these dishes needs to be universal to be culturally useful. Together they show how the regional vrat pantry can be rearranged across many days without making every meal identical.

Beverages follow the same principle. Milk remains one of the most common choices during a fast, while kesar-badam milk may be prepared more richly for the concluding meal by simmering milk with saffron, almonds and cardamom. Chaas, where permitted by family custom, is made by thinning curd and seasoning it lightly with roasted cumin and rock salt, making it particularly welcome after fried foods. Coconut water offers a simpler option during the fasting period, while panchamrit, made from milk, curd, ghee, honey and sugar, belongs primarily to the ritual sphere and is received in small quantities as prasad rather than treated as an ordinary drink. The distinction between refreshment and sacred offering remains important even when both are consumed.

By the final Ashtami, these foods come together in a meal that looks very different from the beginning of the vrat. The kitchen may contain sweet puris, seviyan kheer, meetha dahi, white barfi, coconut laddoo, sabudana kheer, fasting flours, fruit, makhana and carefully prepared savouries, yet no household is required to reproduce one fixed national menu. What gives the cuisine coherence is the sequence: days governed by family fasting rules, foods chosen from a recognised vrat pantry, offerings associated with Mahalakshmi, and a final ritual meal in which the number sixteen reappears at the table.

That sequence is precisely what deserves to be preserved. A festival can survive on a calendar while losing much of its cultural substance if younger generations know when Mahalakshmi Vrat falls but not why sixteen puris are counted, why a flour lamp is placed above them, why seviyan kheer or sweet curd accompanies them, or why certain foods belong to the fast while others belong only after it ends. Recipes preserve technique, but explanation preserves meaning.

The future of Mahalakshmi Vrat therefore depends as much on the kitchen as on the prayer room. Families can keep the tradition alive by inviting younger members to shape the sweet puris, roast singhara flour, thicken milk for prasad, count the offerings and listen to the vrat-katha while the food is being prepared. When the reason behind a dish travels with the recipe, cuisine becomes a form of cultural memory. That may be one of Mahalakshmi's most valuable lessons: prosperity is not only what a household possesses, but also what it knows well enough to share, teach and carry forward.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Protein paradox

Food should stay the primary source for anyone without a diagnosed gap; supplements exist to close a shortfall, not to outrun it

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Walk into any gym in Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru or Hyderabad before office hours, and the ritual is unmistakable — protein shaker bottles lined up by the water cooler. Protein powder has moved well beyond the bodybuilder stereotype; it is now consumed by office workers, homemakers and students alongside athletes, and the industry chasing this demand is expanding fast.

The paradox

Here's the strange part. Even as tubs fly off shelves, most Indians still aren't getting enough protein — from food. ICMR-NIN's dietary guidelines set the recommended intake at 0.83 grams per kilogram of body weight a

day for a healthy adult — for the average Indian man, that's around 54 grams a day; for a woman, around 46. Most people hit this only on paper, because a cereal-and-pulse-heavy plate genuinely leaves gaps unless it's built out deliberately. And yet the same institute has, in the same breath, advised against routine use of protein supplements for healthy people — warning that the added sugars and other additives in these products may do more harm than good to kidneys and bones, and that a well-constructed diet is enough to meet

protein needs. The trend and the guidance are pulling in opposite directions: the country is buying more protein powder than ever, while its own top nutrition science body says the healthy majority never needed to buy it.

None of this makes protein unimportant — quite the opposite. It's the only macronutrient that supplies the amino acids used to build and repair muscle, manufacture enzymes and hormones, produce antibodies, and maintain

POWER-PACKED INDIAN INGREDIENTS

Protein per serving
Dal — 1 cup cooked: 18 g
Chana — 1 cup cooked: 15 g
Paneer — 100 g: 18 g
Curd — 1 cup: 8–10 g
Soy chunks — 50 g dry: 26 g
Eggs — 2 large: 13 g
Peanuts — 30 g: 7 g
Pumpkin seeds — 30 g: 9 g

skin, hair and bone. They specifically is popular because it digests fast and is rich in leucine, the amino acid that most directly triggers muscle repair after a workout.

But protein's importance doesn't end when the gym years do — if anything, the opposite is true. After the age of 30, adults naturally begin losing muscle mass at a rate of roughly three to five per cent every decade.

Protein, in other words, is not a young person's supplement; it's arguably more critical the older you get.

Do you know?
Quinoa is a complete protein, supplying all nine essential amino acids, while seeds add protein, fibre and healthy fats



The taste of Bengal comes calling anew



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Bengali cuisine, with its delicate balance of mustard, jaggery, spices and earthy flavours, has a way of turning simplicity into something deeply expressive. At Baluchi, The Lalit's celebrated pan-Indian kitchen, this culinary tradition takes centre stage with "The Taste of Bengal", an à la carte spread that trades North Indian bravado for the gentler, mustard-and-jaggery poetry of Bengali cooking. The evening opens gently with Aam Pora Shorbot, a roasted raw-mango cooler tempered with jaggery and black salt, tart and smoky, and a smart antidote to Delhi's heat. It sets up the Macher Matha Diye Dal well: moong dal simmered with fish head, a dish that shouldn't work as a starter conversation piece but does, its funk mellowed into comfort.

The kitchen finds its stride at the tandoor. Betki Fish Kobiraji arrives in a lacy egg-batter coat, crisp outside and flaking within, closer to a Bengali fish cutlet than anything Mughlai. The Mangshor Cholar Kebab, minced

mutton bound with chana dal, is denser and more rustic, built for those who like their kebabs to taste of the pan rather than the marinade. The Dhakai Chicken Kebab, yoghurt-marinated and warmly spiced, is familiar territory handled with the same care.

Mains are where the festival earns its

VEGETARIANS AREN'T AN AFTERTHOUGHT. ALOO POSTO'S POPPY-SEED GRAVY IS QUIETLY ADDICTIVE, AND THE KANCHKOLAR KOFTA'S RAW-BANANA DUMPLINGS ARE A REAL TREAT



name. Shorshe Ilish is the true test of any Bengali kitchen, and Baluchi's version, hilsa in a sharp, green-chilli-laced mustard gravy, has the right pungency without tipping into bitterness. Kosha Mangsho, mutton braised down with caramelised onion until dark and clinging, is the standout: patient, deeply spiced, and best mopped up with a flaky Porota. Chingri Malai Curry offers respite from the heat, its prawns gently by coconut milk into something creamy and mild. Vegetarians aren't an afterthought. Aloo Posto's poppy-seed gravy is quietly addictive, and the Kanchkolar Kofta's raw-banana dumplings hold their shape better than most.

Dessert is non-negotiable territory: a Sandesh, delicate and barely sweet, and a classic Rosogola, spongy and syrup-soaked, close the meal the only way Bengal would allow.

It's a tight, well-edited menu, proof that Baluchi's kitchen can step outside its usual repertoire without losing its polish.

Compassion, even in the face of war

AMMA (SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI)

Compassion is the foundation of peace. Tomorrow, September 21st, is the United Nations' International Day of Peace. As humankind faces many volatile conflicts, let us stand together and show the world that compassion, love, and concern for our fellow beings have not completely vanished from the face of this earth.

There has been no end to the war and death caused by man or to the tears shed by all the innocent victims of such tragedies. What were all these for? Only for conquering, establishing superiority and satisfying our greed for money and fame. Humankind has taken upon itself countless curses. In order to attain freedom from these curses, at least a hundred generations to come should wipe the tears of the suffering, striving to console them and alleviate their pain.

Compassion resides within everyone. But it is difficult to experience it and express it in all of our actions. We must turn inwards to search deep within ourselves. "Is my heart still vibrant with life? Have I cried along with those who are suffering? Have I really tried to wipe another's tears to console them or given someone at least a single meal or a set of clothing?" Like this, we can honestly introspect. Then the soothing moonlight of compassion will spontaneously shine within our minds.

If we don't eradicate our destructive emotions, there will be no end to war and violence. In wars today, the enemy's country is destroyed in every possible way. Conquerors plunder and monopolise the land, natural resources, and wealth of the defeated country and use them for their own selfish enjoyment.

The culture and traditions that have been passed down for generations are uprooted, and innocent people are killed without mercy. Furthermore, we cannot begin to fathom the amount of toxic



Ammamma leads prayers for world peace in Granollers, Spain during her 2025 Europe tour

fumes emitted by bombs and other weapons of war, filling the atmosphere and polluting the soil. In the wake of war, all that is left are death, poverty, starvation and epidemics. Such are war's gifts to humanity.

Spirituality is the key with which we can open our hearts and see everyone with compassion. But being blinded by selfishness, our minds have lost their proper judgment and our vision has become distorted. This selfishness only creates more darkness. Using the very same key with which we could open our hearts, our indiscriminate mindset locks them shut instead.

No matter what action we perform, even if it be war, the goal should be the protection of truth and dharma. In principle, there is never a time when war is necessary. But will we ever be able to completely eradicate war from the external world as long as conflict remains in the minds of humankind? This is something we really should contemplate.

The rivers of blood spilled by man in his attempt to seize everything for himself and bring everyone under his thumb have yet to run dry. In fact, when we look into the past, it may seem as though the human race has not possessed even an iota of compassion, so cruel have been our actions.

At least now, as an atonement, shouldn't we try to introspect? No power-

hungry, self-centred leader bent on protecting his own interests has ever attained peace and happiness by conquering the world and persecuting people. Their deaths and the days leading up to them were hell on earth. History has proven this great truth.

In the name of peace, we hold a lot of conferences. But how much change can we really hope to bring about by simply sitting around a table, talking? When all is said and done and we shake hands in parting, is that gesture an actual expression of a warmth of love and compassion felt in our hearts? If not, a real dialogue has not taken place.

For a real dialogue, there must be open and heartfelt oneness and the walls constructed by hostility, preconceived notions, and vengeance must disappear.

We should accept with gratitude this precious opportunity and move forward along the path of peace and compassion. Let us build a new world of peace and harmony by remaining deeply rooted in the universal values that have nourished humanity since time immemorial. Let us say goodbye to war and brutality forever, reducing them to the realm of fairytales. Let us be remembered in the future as the generation of peace.

(Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, known simply as Amma, is a spiritual master and humanitarian who has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people. Listening to the cries of the suffering, Amma leads the Mata Amritanandamayi Math, an NGO that reaches across more than 50 countries, working in healthcare, disaster relief, education, gender equality, and environmental restoration)



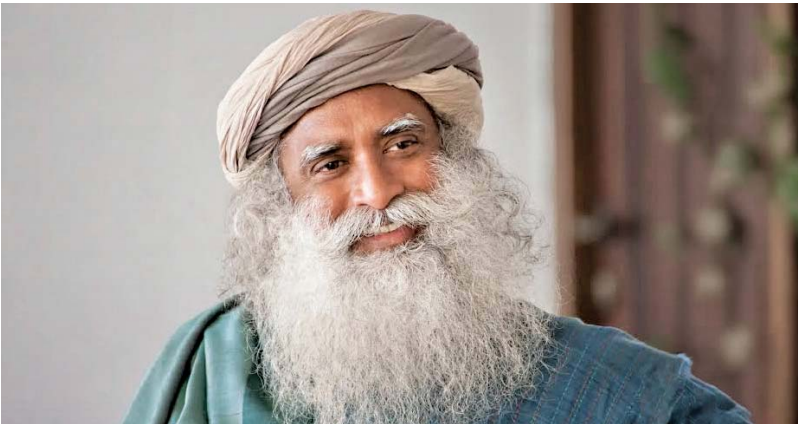
SADHGURU

Karma means action. As you sit here, you are performing four types of actions. Your body is doing something — otherwise, you would not be alive. Similarly, your mind, emotions, and life energies are also performing some action. These four are happening every moment of your life — in wakefulness and in sleep. More than 99 per cent of your karma, your actions, are unconscious. But the residual memory of these actions builds up within you.

For example, as you walk from one place to another, there may be 10 different kinds of smells, but you may not really notice them unless something is acute. But all the 10 different smells that entered your nostrils are recorded within you. The human system is a phenomenal machine. It does not miss anything. Whether you are conscious of it or not, it grasps and records everything, all the time. Based on this memory, you develop certain tendencies. The traditional word for these tendencies is vasana.

Depending upon the type of vasana you have, you tend to move towards certain kinds of life situations. We say "It's your karma" — that means "It's your doing." Unfortunately, karma is projected as punishment or reward for something. What karma means is that you are building up memory; you are unconsciously writing a "software", every moment of your life. Whatever your software turns out to be, accordingly you behave, function and experience your life.

Karma means life is entirely your



THE LIFE WITHIN YOU NEVER HAS INDIVIDUAL IDENTITY. IT IS ONLY YOUR SOFTWARE WHICH IS INDIVIDUAL. IF YOU WRITE IT UNCONSCIOUSLY, IT WILL ASSUME ALL KINDS OF FORMS - SOME YOU MAY LIKE, OTHERS YOU MAY NOT

making. Whether you create it consciously or unconsciously is the question. Once you understand that you are largely creating your life unconsciously, is it not natural for your intelligence to try to become as conscious as possible? Consciousness is like the voltage of a light bulb. If you crank up the voltage, it shows you everything. If you lower the voltage, it only shows you a little. You cannot try to be conscious. If you make your life energies very intense, consciousness will naturally burn within you. If there is no intensi-

ty, if you are only talking and reading about consciousness, it will not happen.

Mukti means we want to wear off the karmic information that we have gathered, which is trapping life in it and building a body around itself. If you dismantle this karmic information, the life within will not be you or me — it will be just life. Life is not only in you, it is all-pervading. It behaves according to whatever kind of information — which we refer to as karma — it gets trapped with. If you dismantle the karmic software completely, where will life go? Nowhere — it is just there. Only the individual identity will be lost. In fact, the life within you never has individual identity. It is only your software which is individual. If you write it unconsciously, it will assume all kinds of forms — some you may like, others you may not. If you write the karmic software consciously, you will create what you want.

(Ranked amongst the fifty most influential people in India, Sadhguru is a yogi, mystic, visionary and a New York Times bestselling author. Sadhguru has been conferred the Padma Vibhushan by the Government of India in 2017, the highest annual civilian award, accorded for exceptional and distinguished service. He is also the founder of the world's largest people's movement, Conscious Planet - Save Soil, which has touched over 4 billion people)

The Universal Message of Parivartini Ekadashi

Parivartini Ekadashi reminds us that true transformation is not merely change; it is the courage to turn within, rise above our limitations, and move steadily towards goodness, peace and divinity

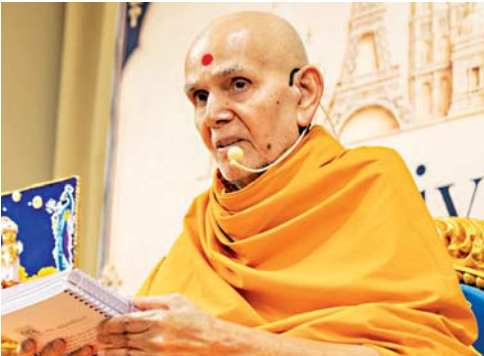
DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

There is something profoundly beautiful about a festival that does not merely ask us to worship, but quietly asks us to change. Parivartini Ekadashi (coming on Sep 22, 2026), also known as Jaljhuni Ekadashi or Parshva Parivartini Ekadashi, carries precisely such a timeless message. It is traditionally associated with the divine turning of Bhagwan Vishnu during his cosmic rest in the Chaturmas period. Devotees celebrate the day with devotion, fasting and worship, but beneath these rituals lies a deeper invitation: if the world is constantly changing, why should we remain unchanged?

However, change is the law of life. Every day, our eyes bear witness to its presence. Birth, growth and death are all manifestations of change. The rising and setting of the sun and moon, the blossoming and withering of flowers; nature itself is in a constant state of transformation. Alongside these natural changes, human beings have brought about countless technological and artificial changes to make life more comfortable and convenient. Scientific advancements have made it possible for us to travel effortlessly through the skies and explore the deepest parts of the oceans, achievements once thought impossible. We can communicate effortlessly with someone sitting barely ten centimetres away, and we can do the same with someone sitting 10,000 kilometres away.

In essence, the driving force behind these transformations has always been the human desire to live a life of greater comfort and peace. But are we truly more peaceful today? These changes have certainly added speed and convenience to our lives, but, at the same time, they seem to have taken away a measure of stability and tranquillity.

The Nobel Prize-winning poet TS Eliot aptly observes, "Endless invention, endless experiment brings knowledge of motion but not of stillness." Indeed, endless innovation may teach us how to move faster, but it does not



necessarily teach us how to remain happy. Clearly, changes in external possessions, behaviour, surroundings and appearance may give life greater momentum, but they cannot, by themselves, give us inner stability and peace. Kabir offers a powerful metaphor for those who believe that changing the outer circumstances is enough:

"The fool strikes at the anthill, but the serpent within remains unharmed."

One may strike the mound covering a serpent with a thousand blows, but the serpent hiding within will remain untouched. The real objective is to destroy the poisonous serpent; yet superficial efforts directed only at the exterior can never accomplish that purpose.

Unless a person transforms from within, external changes alone will prove inadequate. Inner transformation means a transformation in one's thoughts and perspective; a meaningful change in the way one understands and responds to life. Peace is fundamentally an inner state. Therefore, if we seek lasting inner peace, inner transformation is indispensable.

That is where Parivartini Ekadashi acquires a universal significance. Its message is not merely about the turning of the divine form; it is about turning within ourselves.

The true celebration of Parivartini Ekadashi begins when we ask ourselves: What within me needs to change? On December 6, 2019, in Surat, Gujarat, a rather unusual meeting took place. Indian television director Arvind Babbar, popularly known as

Babbalji, came to meet Mahant Swami Maharaj. He had come with a problem that had followed him for more than three decades.

Babbal had been a chain smoker for over 35 years, consuming nearly 40-45 cigarettes every day. He could hardly remain without a cigarette for even half an hour. The habit had become a source of deep anxiety not only for him but also for his family.

Interestingly, his association with BAPS had begun while he was directing 'Muktanand', a short film on de-addiction, commissioned for the birth centenary celebrations of Pramukh Swami Maharaj. He was directing a film about overcoming addiction while struggling with one himself.

That day, the sadhus accompanying him explained his condition to Mahant Swami Maharaj and requested his blessings. Babbal perhaps expected advice, encouragement or a long spiritual explanation.

Instead, Mahant Swami Maharaj simply looked at him, gently touched him, and uttered one word:

"Gone." Something extraordinary happened. Babbal later recalled that from that very moment, his craving simply disappeared. The cigarettes that had ruled his life for 35 years no longer had any hold over him. No cravings. No withdrawal. No return to smoking.

Sometimes, transformation does not arrive through a long lecture. Sometimes, it arrives through a single word spoken by an enlightened Guru. But that word can transform a life only when there is a deep desire within to change. During the making of 'Muktanand', Babbalji's constant association with sadhus and close exposure to their spiritual lives gradually awakened within him a genuine desire to transform. That inner desire eventually became the doorway to a life free from addiction.

Therefore, Parivartini Ekadashi reminds us, "Do not merely wait for life to change; allow yourself to change for the better."

(Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Our body comes with outstanding technology from nature, but we haven't updated the software. And our ancestors have been giving us notifications to do so, but we aren't doing it! We have not paid enough attention to our mental health, our inner peace, and our own communication skills. A disturbed individual creates disturbance not just within, but also in others. Conflict begins in a disturbed mind, and a peaceful individual creates harmony in society. When we update the software, that is, when we learn to calm the mind, we spread happiness around us and reflect human values in our lives.

Human values matter more than we realise. Caring for each other, sharing what one has with others — these are the real values. When they get eroded in society, it leads to corruption, violence, disease, and a whole host of undesirable outcomes.

Those who have more need to be more compassionate. Everybody should have a level playing field; no one should go hungry on this planet. If every country pays a little more attention to these values, we can have a peaceful and happy society.

Peace is the foundation of prosperity

Anyone who visited Colombia before 2015 (when the 52-year-old civil war ended there) and visits it now will find a sea of difference. When peace came to Colombia, prosperity started growing there. In India too, if anyone visited Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, or Bihar before 2000 and visits now, they will find a big difference. When thousands of Naxals laid down their arms, when violence ceased, the development path opened up.

The same happened in Assam, where misguided youths had taken to violence. When they came to terms with peace, progress happened. Today in Kashmir, people can walk around fearlessly; largely, there is peace and prosperity, which go hand in hand.

But peace is not complacency or running away from the world, and restlessness is not dynamism. It is possible to be peaceful and dynamic in the world at the same time.

The greatest of the scriptures to come from India, the Bhagavad Gita, talks about peace, but that conversation happened on the battlefield. Peace has more relevance when there is conflict, and I do not think any age has been more relevant for peace than today.

When I went to Iraq to teach meditation, people asked me, "Why would you go there?"



There is so much conflict, so much trouble, and a bomb blasts every day. And you want to go to teach meditation there?"

I said, that is where meditation is more relevant. Later, we opened our Art of Living centre there. But when the conflict started, there were heavy bombings everywhere. I called our volunteers in the centre there and asked them to return. They said, "Gurudev, if we also leave from here, who will take care of the injured people? This is when people need us more; we have to be here."

They were attending to seven hundred patients a day, talking to them, counselling them, bringing them relief through meditation and breathing practices.

Once a journalist asked me, "Why is peace so relevant?" I said, "Why not?"

If people are at peace and happy, why would anybody commit suicide or take the lives of others? Why would there be mass shootings? Globally, one person takes their own life every 40 seconds. In America, on average, 3 mass shootings happen daily. This makes one wonder if we have returned to a barbaric age. Where have we gone wrong?

Peace in the world is impossible without individuals being at peace within.

Today, mental health is a global challenge. I would even say it is one of the biggest challenges human society faces today, which is damaging families, causing pain, conflict, and division.

Our youth are either becoming aggressive or they are going into depression, not knowing that a middle path is available to them, that happiness and peace of mind are within reach. Violence and conflict are the outcome of a disturbed and stressed mind.

A conflict begins when communication breaks down

Stress and prejudice can lead to a total breakdown of communication. In fact, a conflict is born out of a perceived threat from the other. If we speak to either side of any conflict, we will find both of them seem right in their place. Each one will convince us in favor of their stance, what it means for their self-

defense, for their survival.

Here, we miss something.

The trust deficit and lack of communication can only be handled when our minds are clear. Communication breaks down when we remain in our own little world, unwilling to see the other person's point of view. A family is a good example of how diversity can coexist with togetherness. There are differences, there are arguments, sometimes there are raised voices, but the bond remains unbreakable. We do not stop being a family because we disagree.

In the same way, society can celebrate its diversity and remain united when we recognise the deeper value that connects us. For this, inner peace is essential.

When the mind is at peace, patience naturally comes with it. And without patience, there can be no real communication.

Communication is not just speaking; it requires the steadiness to listen, to understand, and to respond rather than react. When we are stressed, hurried, or agitated, our responses are impulsive. When we become impulsive, whatever we say from an impulsive mindset ends up in some sort of disaster sooner or later.

In such a state, even words spoken with good intention can create misunderstanding, and with clarity comes the skill to communicate, connect, and resolve differences.

To understand peace comprehensively, we have to take a journey within. A few moments of silence, a few moments of introspection, can free us from the clutter of our own thoughts and emotional patterns.

The breath is the bridge to inner peace

The way to calm impulsivity is through the breath. We have ignored the power and value of breathing right for far too long, though it is the first act of life, and it will be the last act of life too. Throughout our lives, we keep breathing, without really knowing how to use it. Breath is the link between our mind and our emotions. Each emotion is linked to a certain rhythm of breath. Similarly, when we breathe in a particular way, we can have a say over our emotions, still the mind and find a way to become peaceful.

Peace is not something distant from us. It begins with understanding our own mind, our own emotions, and our own breath. Each one of us can be a lighthouse of peace. When we carry this vision of belonging with the whole world as one family, peace will prevail over hatred and conflict, because peace is our very nature.